

Tai Chi Fa Jin

Advanced Techniques for
Discharging Chi Energy



For Martial Arts and Spiritual Practice

Mantak Chia and Andrew Jan

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Dedicated to Tai Chi practitioners everywhere

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Putting Tai Chi Fa Jin into Practice

The practices described in this book have been used successfully for thousands of years by Taoists trained by personal instruction. Readers should not undertake the practice without receiving personal transmission and training from a certified instructor of the Universal Healing Tao, since certain of these practices, if done improperly, may cause injury or result in health problems. This book is intended to supplement individual training by the Universal Healing Tao and to serve as a reference guide for these practices. Anyone who undertakes these practices on the basis of this book alone does so entirely at his or her own risk.

The meditations, practices, and techniques described herein are not intended to be used as an alternative to or substitute for professional medical treatment and care. If any readers are suffering from illnesses based on mental or emotional disorders, an appropriate professional health care practitioner or therapist should be consulted. Such problems should be corrected before you start training.

Neither the Universal Healing Tao nor its staff and instructors can be responsible for the consequences of any practice or misuse of the information contained in this book. If the reader undertakes any exercise without strictly following the instructions, notes, and warnings, the responsibility must lie solely with the reader.

This book does not attempt to give any medical diagnosis, treatment, prescription, or remedial recommendation in relation to any human disease, ailment, suffering, or physical condition whatsoever.

Preface

The purpose of this book is to outline the study of discharge power, or *Fa Jin*, through the principles and teachings of the Universal Healing Tao system. In particular, this book draws on the practices of Iron Shirt, Tai Chi, Tan Tien Chi Kung, and meditation.

Teachings from the internal martial art classics and from current masters of these disciplines provide us with clues about the methodology employed in discharge power. However, internal arts are always difficult to describe because they are, by nature, internal and subjective. Descriptions of chi, mind, and specific visualizations vary from master to master within a discipline as well as between different traditions. These variations occur even when the masters are performing essentially similar tasks. Perhaps there are multiple internal methods that achieve the same discharge power. Alternatively, a master may be unable to describe in words the internal happenings that occur with the release of power, or unwilling to reveal too much about this esoteric art. In former years, masters would teach such techniques only to a small number of select students. Consequently, the art of Fa Jin is on the decrease.

To further complicate matters, variations of Fa Jin exist. They range from Bruce Lee's one-inch punch to throwing an opponent in the air to transmitting an electric shock or intense heat. Despite these constraints, this book will nevertheless attempt to outline the methodology of Fa Jin and share this knowledge with all. By building upon the principles of Iron Shirt Chi Kung, the foundational form of Tai Chi Chi Kung, Tan Tien Chi Kung, the Fusion practices, and Kan and Li practice, we hope to arrange the information in a succinct and understandable way.

This book endeavors to create an original view of Fa Jin by blending the Universal Healing Tao internal training with the yang Tai Chi classics and teachings from present-day masters. The power generated by this blend of insight is practiced in the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form, which demonstrates five of the eight gates that can express discharge power. Another practice for cultivating discharge power that uses all eight gates is Push Hands. As a part of its discussion of discharge power, this book provides an overview of Push Hands routines and principles.

Many Tai Chi classics are now available in English thanks to authors such as

Yang Jwing-Ming, Benjamin Lo, Barbara Davis, and Douglas Wile. This book will make direct references to available English translations of the works of Yang Lu-Chan, Wu Yu-Hsiang, Wu Cheng-Ching, and Li I-Yu. (Please note that spelling in some of the quotations that retain pinyin is altered slightly to maintain consistency with the authors.) The next book in this series will explore the Wu style, focusing on the works of Wu Quan-Yu.



Iron Shirt Chi Kung



The foundational Tai Chi Chi Kung form

However, translation of historical Tai Chi texts is difficult because there are

multiple meanings for many of the original characters. Accurate translation requires an appropriate depth of understanding of Tai Chi principles in order to extract the inner meaning. In other words, the depth of translation can be only as deep as the translator's current mindset. Furthermore, understanding of the principles of Fa Jin can only occur when the student is ready to comprehend. Much of that understanding will come through meditation and the domain of martial interaction that allows hidden forces to materialize in the physical realm.

This book focuses on the reader who has an interest in both Taoist mystical practices and martial practice. It will suit the accomplished Tai Chi practitioner who seeks a deeper understanding of the energetic aspects of Fa Jin training, as well as the practitioner who has made some accomplishment with meditation and seeks a deeper understanding of the physical and martial domains. The book will be invaluable not only to students of the Universal Healing Tao system, but also to Tai Chi and meditation students of other schools who are searching for a fresh approach to this internal art or wishing to broaden their knowledge.



Tan Tien Chi Kung



Kan and Li Meditation

1

History of the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form

Discharge power is best known in Chinese as *Fa Jin*, which is translated as “discharge” or “transfer” of power (fig. 1.1). *Fa* means “to issue,” while *jin* translates as “internal force.” The word *Fa Jin* is thus used to describe the transfer of a large amount of momentum with seemingly little or no external strength. In contrast to *Fa Jin*, *Li* power uses external strength and gross muscular force. *Li* power requires outward telegraphing of movement prior to the strike, whereas *Fa Jin* does not.

發 勁

Fig. 1.1. Chinese characters for *Fa Jin*

The first purpose of this chapter is to explore the use of *Fa Jin*—discharge power—in the history of internal martial arts within China. The second purpose is to understand the Universal Healing Tao Yang Discharge Form within this historical framework.

Discharge power is the ability of the practitioner to issue force or power without evident effort. This is the form of practice that is responsible for those legendary stories of Tai Chi Chi Kung masters hurling their opponents several yards away without even touching them. It involves the cultivation of power deep within and a calculated discharge of that power in a highly focused and carefully executed form.

Discharge power is featured in the three internal Chinese martial arts: Tai Chi Chuan, Ba Gua Zhang, and Hsing Yi Chuan. Tai Chi Chuan can be defined as a soft internal style of martial arts characterized by forms practiced in a slow meditative state of mind. Ba Gua is a style based on the eight trigrams of the I Ching. It has eight palms and is characterized by circular movements. Like Tai Chi, Ba Gua Zhang translates the spiritual aspects of Taoism into physical form. Hsing Yi or “heart mind” boxing involves a more direct, rapid, and staccato approach to fighting. Each of these disciplines draws on classic texts and methods to cultivate and express discharge power.

To understand the nature of discharge power it is useful to use the laws of physics, in which $\text{Power} = \text{Mass} \times \text{Acceleration} \times \text{distance}$ within a unit of time (fig. 1.2). In the case of Fa Jin, mass is the weight of the opponent; acceleration is the change in velocity when the opponent is propelled; and distance is the measure of how far the opponent is thrown. Some practitioners are able to discharge huge power with the techniques described in this text.

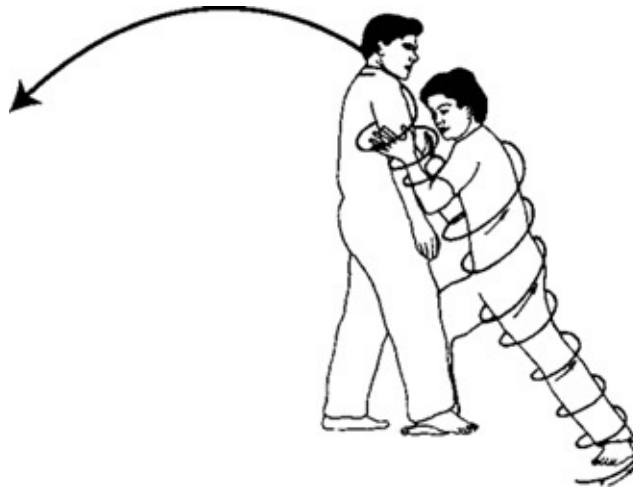


Fig. 1.2. $\text{Power} = \text{Mass} \times \text{Acceleration} \times \text{Distance}$. The farther the throw, the greater the power.

In martial arts practice, this power can occur with minimal external manifestation and seemingly minimal effort (fig. 1.3). Furthermore, it is not related to the youth or muscle mass of the practitioner.

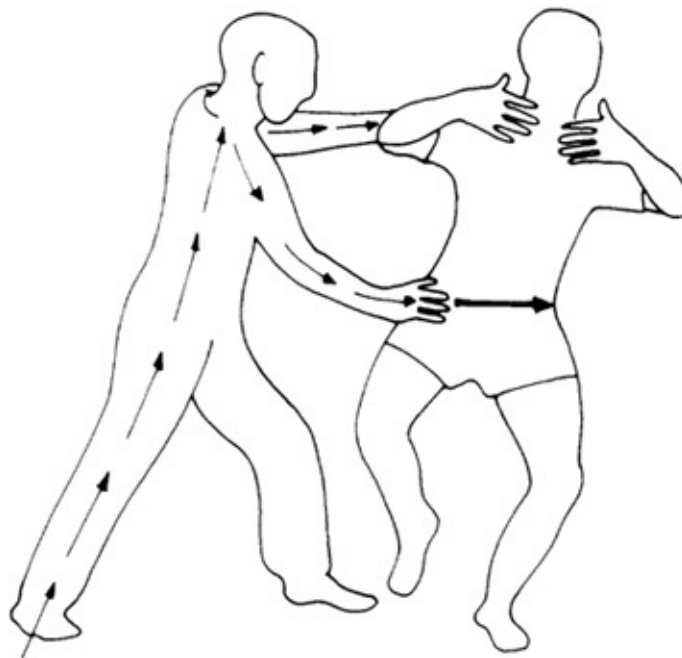


Fig. 1.3. If the force is not grounded, it does not pass through the structure, and the body falls.

Power transfer can be used as a healing force or as a destructive force. When it is used as a healing force, it is called Fa Jia.⁴ When power is transferred to exert a destructive effect on certain acupuncture points, it is called Di Mak.

THE HISTORY OF TAI CHI CHUAN

The practice of Tai Chi Chuan was allegedly created by Chang SanFeng (1279–1368 CE), a Taoist monk who lived at the Wu Tang Mountain—the site of many schools of internal martial arts training (fig. 1.4). Chang SanFeng had also studied at the Shaolin temple, but he reformed their external art techniques (Li power) to incorporate Fa Jin. The principle of including yin techniques in martial arts practice was a paradigm shift that led to notions of softness and yielding, and to the incorporation of slow, meditative forms.

Tai Chi Chuan is an internal martial art based on the philosophical and cosmological concepts of Taoism. The term *Tai Chi* is a philosophical term—arising from Taoist cosmology and creation theory—that is directly translated as “the supreme ultimate.” It represents the primal duality of yin and yang. According to Taoist cosmology, beneath the nothingness there is the Tao, and from the nothingness arose the yin and yang. The interplay of this duality to facilitate experience of the Tao is the reason why it is regarded as the “supreme ultimate.” The internal martial art of Tai Chi Chuan integrates with the philosophical and cosmological concepts of the Tao at many levels. The methods and experiences required to develop within the art of Tai Chi require a deep understanding of these concepts.



Fig. 1.4. Chang SanFeng

The *Tai Chi Chuan Ching* is regarded as the principal Tai Chi Chuan classic and is attributed to Chang SanFeng, though its true authorship is unknown. Many classics of Chinese thought are attributed to legendary immortals, though this cannot be proven in most cases. Perhaps adepts feel that they have been inspired by the forefathers of the discipline—or even that they have channeled the thoughts of the immortals—and humbly attribute ownership to them.

In the *Tai Chi Chuan Ching*, Chang SanFeng says:

Let there be no hollows or projections; let there be no stops and starts. Its root is in the feet, its issuing from the legs, its control from the *yao* (waist), and its shaping in the fingers.¹

This passage highlights two basic principles of Tai Chi that are also fundamental teachings of the Universal Healing Tao system. The first principle is Iron Shirt training, which removes segments of tension within the spine and limbs. This tension correlates to the “hollows and projections” described by Chang. The second principle describes the passage of chi from the heels through the body and spine, which is the primary teaching of the foundational form of Tai Chi Chi Kung. It will be discussed in greater detail in chapter 3.

After Chang SanFeng there is a period of several hundred years during which both written classics and legendary Tai Chi masters seem to have disappeared. It is not until the likes of Wang Tsung-Yueh that the available history of Tai Chi Chuan resumes (see fig. 1.5 on page 6). The biography of Wang Tsung-Yueh is uncertain, though it seems that he was a teacher who lived in Shanxi province and taught in Honan province. His exact dates of birth and death are unknown. Chen village and Yang proponents have him existing prior to Chen Wang-Ting somewhere in the Ming Dynasty (1368–1644), hence his position on the lineage tree between Chan SanFeng and Chen Wang-Ting. However Douglas Wile questions this and has him living in the eighteenth century.² His classic *Tai Chi Chuan Lun* marks the first verified Tai Chi classic.³

Wang comments on the cultivation of jin, saying:

Yin and yang mutually aid and change each other. Then you can say you understand jin (internal force).

The process of interaction between yin and yang energies—between the substantial and insubstantial—is found in the Universal Healing Tao Fusion practices and Kan and Li practice. Fusion practices involve the merging of the various yin and yang elemental forces. Kan and Li practice teaches us to invert

yang (fire) beneath the yin (water) energy and then couple them together. This process creates a new energy, which is closer to the Primordial Chi. It creates an expansion in the tan tien, which is used to fuel the release of jin.^{*2}

The oldest of the Tai Chi forms is the Chen style, which was developed by Chen Wang-Ting (1628–1736) in the Chen family village (fig. 1.6).⁴ Chen Wang-Ting is said to have learned Tai Chi from Jiang Fa, who had learned it from Chang SanFeng. Alternatively, some scholars believe that Chen WanTing was the true creator of Tai Chi Chuan, rather than Chang SanFeng.⁵ There maybe a hidden agenda here, as proponents of this position may be seeking to add authenticity to the Chen family name, but in any case hard evidence of the actual existence and contributions of these legendary Tai Chi forefathers is difficult to come by. Nevertheless, the usefulness of the *Tai Chi Chuan Lun* and the Chen approach to Fa Jin is undeniable.



Fig. 1.5. Wang Tsung-Yueh



Fig. 1.6. Chen Wang-Ting
(1628–1736)

To this day, the Chen style carries several forms within its repertoire that make use of Fa Jin, including Cannon Fists, Buddha's Warrior Attendant, and Light the Firecrackers. The external manifestation of these forms includes a sudden release of force through the physical musculature, which looks, to the naked eye, like a shaking at the end of the move.

The Yang style was an adaptation of the Chen style created by Yang Lu-Chan (1799–1872) (see fig. 1.8 on page 8). It is alleged that he spied on Chen Chang-Xing (1771–1853) and achieved his skills in discharge power this way.⁶ The Yang style is characterized by its more consistent tempo, which contrasts with the staccato rhythm of the Chen style. It is therefore aligned with Chang SanFeng's principle that "Tai Chi Chuan is like a great river rolling on unceasingly."⁷ Each move has that characteristic flow despite the fact that the moves are executed in various directions. The current long 108 form has no

overt exhibition of Fa Jin, although the little-known Small-Frame Fast Tai Chi form does. (The Small Frame is a compacted long form that is executed with speed.) Nevertheless, each form in the long form can rehearse and create familiarity with the principles of Fa Jin. On this point, Wang Tsung-Yueh reminds us that “from familiarity with the correct touch, one gradually comprehends the jin.”⁸ The use of jin begins with the closing of the arms, which assists in the contraction of the tan tien and its consequent expansion, followed by the passage of chi through the spine and structure.

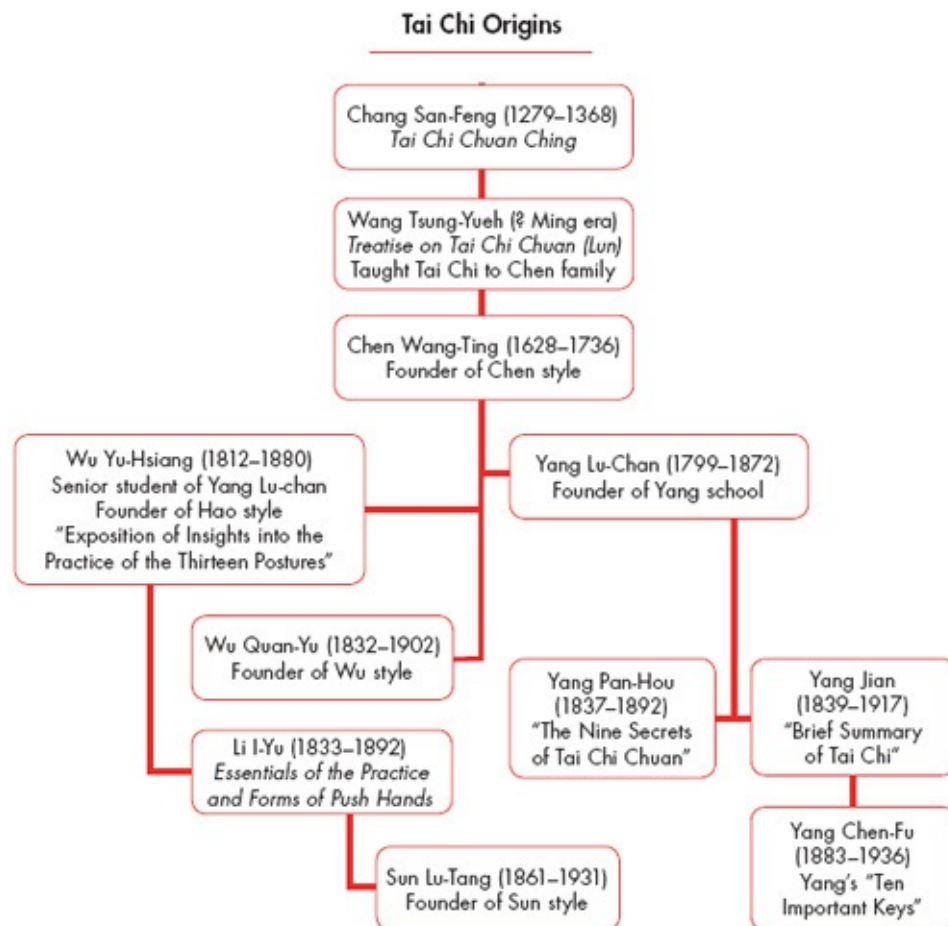


Fig. 1.7. Tai Chi founders and authors of the Tai Chi classics



Fig. 1.8. Yang Lu-Chan (1799–1872)

The Universal Healing Tao form is in part derived from the Small-Frame Fast Yang Tai Chi form and the Bird’s Tail form from the long Tai Chi form.

Yang Lu-Chan had three sons: Yang Qi (died early), Yang Pan-Hou (1837–1892), and Yang Jian (1839–1917). Yang Pan-Hou was likely the original author of “The Nine Secrets of Tai Chi Chuan,”⁹ and a contributor to the *Yang Family Forty Chapters*, which included oral transmissions from the legendary Chang SanFeng (fig. 1.9).¹⁰ This book, which will be discussed in greater detail in chapter 3, makes the important connection between “closing” and Fa Jin. Closing is the returning of the arms to the torso, which activates and expands the tan tien, providing the power for executing the discharge. Chapter 24 says, “When there is a closing (therefore storing the jin), (the jin) immediately emits.”¹¹



Fig. 1.9. Yang Pan-Hou (1837–1892)

Yang Lu-Chan’s third son, Yang Jian, wrote the work known as the “Brief

Summary of Tai Chi.” The third son of Yang Jian was Yang Chen-Fu (1883–1936), who gave the oral transmission of “Ten Important Keys to Tai Chi Chuan” and the “Explanation of Tai Chi Chuan’s Harmonious Stepping in Four Sides of Push Hands” (fig. 1.10). In the “Ten Important Keys,” he says:



Fig. 1.10. Yang Chen-Fu (1883–1936)

Taijiquan uses the Yi without using the Li. From the beginning until the end, continuous without breaking [when] complete, again repeated from the beginning, cycling without limitation. It [is] what was originally said [to be] “Like the long great river [i.e., Yangtze River], flow fluidly without ending.” It is also said: “Transporting the jin as drawing the silk.” All of this means the [movements] are threaded through [i.e., together] with a sole Qi.¹²

This excerpt explains some aspects of Fa Jin that are unlike the coordination that occurs in our everyday mind. Instead, Tai Chi—and in particular Fa Jin—requires the use of a deeper state of mind. This state of mind arises when the practitioner is able to relinquish control to an integrated self. This integrated self is called Yi power, and it is formed in the merging of the brain, heart, and lower tan tien. Yi power moves chi, which transports the jin. This movement of chi is a very pleasant sensation, which involves a very delicate yin approach—like drawing fine silk. Paradoxically, it is this delicate yin power that generates the overt maximal yang power.

Yang Lu-Chan taught Wu Yu-Hsiang (1812–1880), who was the author of “Exposition of Insights into the Practice of the Thirteen Postures” (fig. 1.11). This work teaches us that “to Fa Jin, sink, relax completely, and aim in one direction!” The sinking and relaxing is a vital aspect of Fa Jin. Since discharge power is generated from the realm of yin, it is important to embody yin

thoroughly—to relax, contract the tan tien, tuck in the coccyx, and sink deeper into one’s structure. This gives a sensation of connecting to the earth and even to the vast realm of empty space beyond it. From that space a spark alights within the tan tien, which inflates it at maximal acceleration. Sinking and relaxing is more powerful than using muscular strength or Li power.



Fig. 1.11. Wu Yu-Hsiang (1812–1880)



Fig. 1.12. Li I-Yu (1832–1892)

Wu Yu-Hsiang taught Li I-Yu (1832–1892), who was the author of many classic works, including “Thirteen Postures,” “The Secrets of Withdraw and Release,” “Five Key Words,” “Important Keys of Stepping and Striking,” “Song of Tai Chi Chuan Applications,” “Secret of Eight Words,” “Song of Transporting and Applying Spirit and Chi,” “Song of Random Circle,” “The Acclamation of Tai Chi Sparring,” and “The Small Forward of Tai Chi Chuan” (fig. 1.12). Li I-Yu says:

To Fa Jin it is necessary to have root. The jin starts from the foot, is commanded by the waist, and manifested in the fingers and discharged through the spine and back. In the curve seek the straight, store, then discharge, then you are able to follow your hands and achieve a beneficial result. This is called borrowing force to strike the opponent or using four ounces to deflect a thousand pounds.¹³

In this quote we are reminded of the basics of the Universal Healing Tao system. Iron Shirt structure is the foundation that provides the rooting power. The waist, also known as the Chi Belt or Dai Mai, maintains the solid connection between the legs and the torso. As per the foundational form of Tai Chi Chi Kung, the chi is transmitted from the earth through the spine and discharged via the palms. This is done with a sense of the delicate or yin power. By following all these principles, a seemingly minute force is enough to move a large man.

BA GUA ZHANG AND FA JIN

Dong Hai-Chuan (1797–1882), the creator of Ba Gua Zhang and author of the *Thirty-six Songs and Forty-eight Methods*, believed that connections to the eight forces would give a practitioner access to universal power.¹⁴ This power is the same discharge power that is used by the Tai Chi masters.

At times, Dong moves from the mystical to the practical. In song nine, he refers to Fa Jin and reminds readers to “use the ‘Hen’ and ‘Ha’ sounds when releasing the power. The whole body’s energy rises.”¹⁵ Although the use of sound has not been mentioned to this point, it may be a useful adjunct in the manifestation of discharge power. Sound activates the empty force and lower tan tien, which are vital aspects in the release of discharge power.

Dong also says, “Step back to know the situation/small force can deflect much greater power.”¹⁶ He reminds us of the importance of reading the opponent correctly, and of choosing the right moment so that only a small amount of effort is required.

To continue with Dong’s classic; in chapter eight on the internal power method he says, “Power discharge is from harmony of mind and force.”¹⁷ Here he emphasizes but fails to elaborate on the importance of the mind in discharge power. Universal Tao practice teaches that with refinement, force and mind merge: the three minds become one mind. The mind moves the chi, which moves the limbs. Minimal separation exists between intention and actualization of force.

In chapter nine on the power storing method, Dong comments that storing

power is just as vital, if not more important, than releasing it.¹⁸ Another way to look at this is to recognize that the tan tien needs to be full. If the tan tien is empty then the execution of discharge power is disabled. Everything is done in moderation and nothing to excess such that the lower tan tien is never depleted.

HSING YI AND FA JIN

Hsing Yi is the third internal art. It is older than Ba Gua Zhang and Tai Chi, and supposedly originated in the tenth century during the Song Dynasty. The founding of Hsing Yi is credited to General Yue Fei. Although it is labeled an internal art, Hsing Yi's forms are more typical of an external martial art. This is because its strikes and blows are linear and aggressive. It demonstrates Fa Jin through explosive strikes rather than the throwing and uprooting of opponents as seen in Tai Chi. However, the cultivation of Fa Jin that is behind these strikes is based on internal softness, stillness, visualizations, and connections to the elements and symbolic animals. The five different types of power released are Pi, Tzuan, Beng, Pau, and Hern; they correspond to the elements of metal, water, wood, fire, and earth. The three main schools of Hsing Yi—Shanxi, Hebei, and Henan—vary in certain details, but the twelve animals generally included are: dragon, chicken, monkey, hawk, sparrow, Tai bird, eagle, bear, snake, tiger, horse, and turtle.

2

Why Practice the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form?

Students of the Tao may wonder why they should practice a discharge form. “Surely I can experience the Tao through sitting meditation,” they may ask. “Why would I ever partake in fighting activities?”

There are, of course, many methods for the discovery of the Tao, and it is legitimate to question whether the pursuit of discharge power is one of them. If it is, where would it fit in the range of Taoist practice? Scholars generally recognize paths of religious Taoism (the worship of Taoist immortals and gods embellished with ritual and hierarchy), and folk Taoism (practiced by the masses), as well as philosophic Taoism, internal alchemy (*nei dan*), and external alchemy (*wei dan*).¹

Beyond this list of Taoist paths, however, is another way—the so-called way of the warrior, which is a merging of the warrior path with Taoist practice. The writings of Chang SanFeng and the teachings of masters with extraordinary abilities (especially within the Lei Shan Tao/Thunderbolt tradition) are the foundation of this path. While many areas of Taoist practice are involved in the way of the warrior, the internal alchemy methods are the primary vehicle for this integration.²

THE WAY OF THE WARRIOR

Wars and fighting have influenced cultural development in China just as much as Taoism. While the goals of immortality and merging with the Tao may seem incompatible with the goals of war, there are many examples of productive interchange between the two philosophies. In Sun Tzu’s *Art of War*, we find an early example of Taoist thought merging with military strategy. Success in this text incorporates the principles of longevity and the welfare of the people as prime objectives. In Zen Buddhism, we also find a path of enlightenment through martial practice creating a code called the Budo.¹⁴

The successful merging of pugilism and spiritual realization can be understood as an archetype of the hero’s journey. It requires the resolution of the

seemingly impossible paradox of finding peace by engaging in violence. This is possible only through the acceptance of all drives of the self—including the lower desires. This process is akin to the acceptance of sexual feelings, which are transformed, in the Universal Healing Tao system, via the alchemical practices of Fusion and Kan and Li. On the warrior path there is an initial acceptance of the desire to fight. The more compulsive yang side of our nature is incorporated just as much as the thoughtful yin aspects. They all contribute to the whole person.

The Discovery of the Self

The discovery of all aspects of the self is an obligatory stage in the realization of the Tao, and therefore also in the way of the warrior. This holistic approach is not unique to Taoism, but is also seen in many other mystical traditions. Plato (428–348 BCE), for instance, divided the psyche into four elements that needed to be united in order to realize the mystical world of eternal forms. Paracelsus (1493–1541) fused all aspects of the psyche with sexual drive to form the philosopher's stone, which was akin to the rebirth of Christ consciousness.³ Integration of the whole self is also a vital principle in contemporary psychology, as seen in the works of Carl Jung and Sigmund Freud. They both maintained that the discovery and union of the subconscious is vital to healing and to the realization of God.

Taoist cosmology teaches us that the Tao begot the Wu Wei. From the Wu Wei, yin and yang were born. From this duality came a third—now called the three pure ones. Next came the five elements, which are each then further divided into yin and yang subdivisions. The five elements can manifest themselves now as the eight forces. After multiple divisions, life is manifest as the ten thousand things.

In the Taoist framework, wholeness is the awareness, understanding, correct use, and merging of all the multiple forces within us, including those difficult-to-integrate forces like sexual drives and a desire to harm. From an internal alchemical perspective, the eight forces signified by the eight trigrams of the pakua (Ba Gua) represent the multiple aspects of self. The five elemental forces of existence can also represent these aspects of self.

Discovery of the Tao involves firstly the simplification of the ten thousand things into the eight forces or five elements. From there, the process of fusion and the power of sexual union can be employed to reduce the multiple divisions to a duality, from which the unitive experience of the Tao is achieved (fig. 2.1).

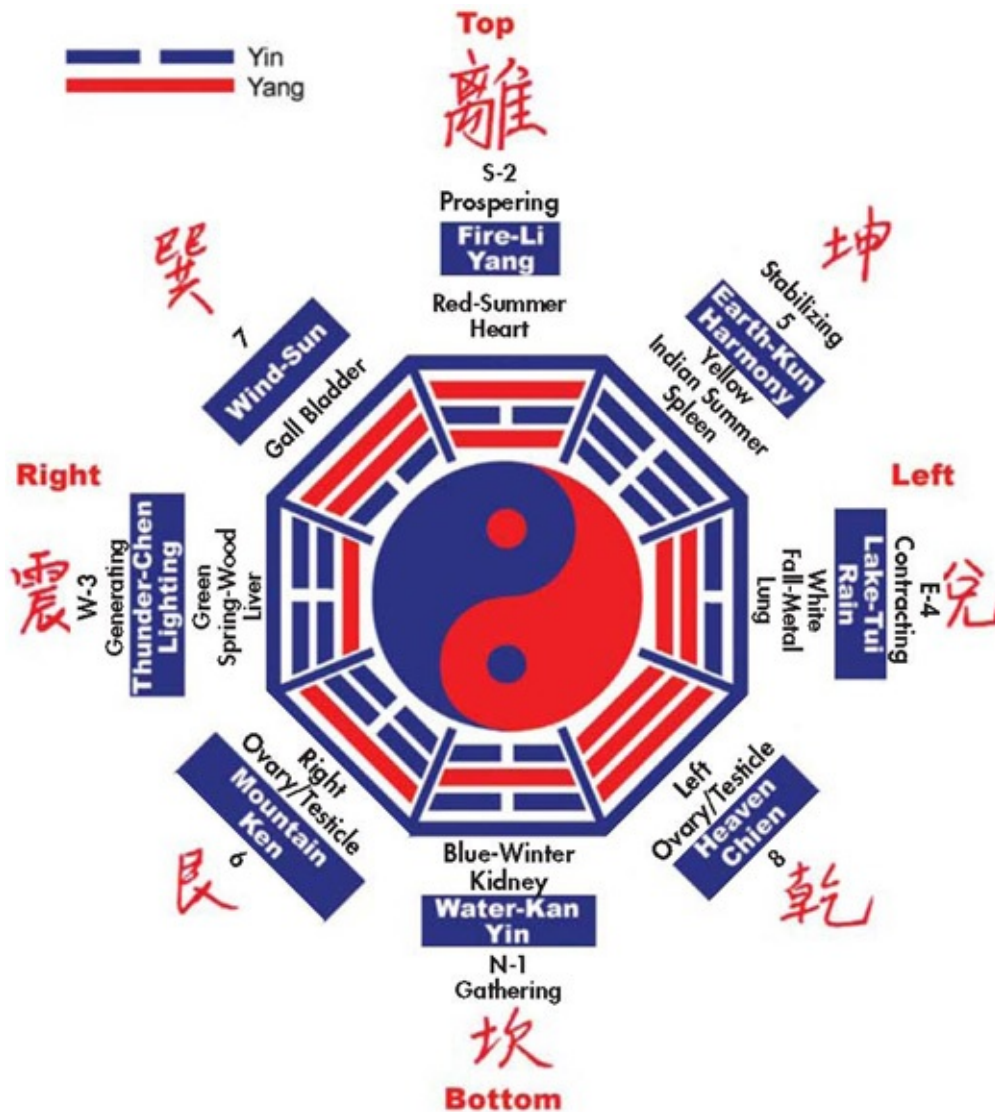


Fig. 2.1. Pakua fusion

This progress toward wholeness and simplicity in the Tao is called self-cultivation. Self-cultivation is a means of achieving sagehood—a full realization of the Tao. In other traditions, this state might be called enlightenment. In the history of Taoism, advanced stages of self-cultivation are frequently associated with achievement of high levels of discharge power, so it may be that the pursuit of Fa Jin can assist the adept in realization of the Tao.

Chang SanFeng discussed the realization of the Tao, saying, “If [you] are capable of doing so, then outside or inside, refined or coarse, there is no place that cannot be reached, [which allows you to] comprehend [the Tao] suddenly. The wish of reaching sagehood and holiness can be achieved.”⁴ Chang correlates the outside or coarse world to the postures and forms of martial arts. He states that while his ancestors taught self-cultivation through spiritual and physical

practice, they did not teach self-cultivation through martial practice. While acknowledging that self-cultivation can be achieved on many spiritual paths, Chang makes clear that his teachings “should be transmitted as a martial art for self-cultivation.”⁵ As a part of this effort, Chang correlates the components of cosmological theory and internal alchemy to Tai Chi practice.

Chang describes the thirteen postures of battle, which are the eight gates and five steps. The eight gates have a correspondence to the pakua, and are defined as the eight methods of release of jin. These are the forces of Peng, Lu, Ji, An, Tsai, Lieh, Chou, and Kou, which will be discussed in detail in chapter 3. The five steps are forward steps to the left and right, backward steps to the left and right, and the center. These postures are the manifestation of the forces of the universe in action. When we develop these postures in reference to our relationships with the internal alchemical essences, we facilitate our movement toward the Tao. Chang implies that mastery of the inner worlds and discovery of the Way cannot occur without understanding of—and competence in—its earthly manifestations. Furthermore, he states that the potential for exchange of the yang essence of two males engaged in battle may be a tool for even more rapid development than the paths of exchange in sexual practices.^{5 6}

Chang further highlights the correlation between mystical meditation and Push Hands practice, saying:

The eyes view the three unifications (limbs, inward awareness, and external action) and the ears listen to the six ways (six directions). . . . Though they are situated on the surface of the body, the knowledge obtained can lead your innate knowledge back to its origin. The ears, eyes, hands, and feet can be divided into two; this is the two poles. All of these combine together, become a single unit, and become Taiji.⁷

THE UNITIVE STATE

In meditation practice, the Fusion meditations begin with the unification of the senses, inward awareness, and the body. In the Universal Healing Tao practice of the Three Tan Tiens and Six Directions, there is a merging of spatial existence beyond self with the unified mind. In these practices, experience is reduced to a duality before there is perception of the Original Chi. In Push Hands practice, the same principle is employed, except now two people are involved in ever-changing motion. When principles of internal alchemy are applied to martial interaction, they enhance martial skill and also facilitate experience of the unified or unitive state.

Of course, unitive experience is not exclusive to the Taoist system, but occurs in many mystical traditions. Within Western psychology, a unitive experience is described as a “peak” experience. If the metaphor of a mountain can be used to describe the adept’s journey, then the peak is the realization of the Tao, while the journey toward it can be called self-cultivation.

The journey of self-cultivation on the warrior path correlates well with progression through psychologist Abraham Maslow’s “hierarchy of needs.” Maslow describes a hierarchy of goals or needs, which all people strive to meet in the following order: satisfaction or gratification of body needs; safety needs and self-protection; love, affection, warmth, acceptance, and a place in the group; a desire for self-esteem, self-respect, self-confidence, and for the feeling of strength or adequacy; and finally self-actualization, self-fulfillment, and self-expression. With each stage, there comes an experience that provides the self a sense of satiation, or completeness, which then allows progression to the next stage. Of course, the journey is rarely a linear progression, but the hierarchical framework is helpful.

SUMMARY OF MASLOW’S STAGES WITH CHAN SANFENG’S CORRELATIONS		
STAGE	MASLOW	CHANG SANFENG
Basic needs	Self-gratification (food, sexual desire, sleep) and self-preservation (housing, self-defense)	“When the mind and physical body are protected safely” ⁸
Knowledge of self	Self-acceptance and self-esteem (to have self worth)	“Know our origin and understand where we are going (it does not matter whether we are smart or stupid, virtuous or not, all can use their capability to approach the Tao.” ⁹
Development of capabilities	Self-actualization (becoming oneself)	“It is the natural knowledge and capability that (we) are born with.” ¹⁰
Peak or transcendental experience	Self-transcendence ¹¹	“Comprehending the Tao from martial arts” ¹²

In the beginning, a martial artist relishes his newly found strength, coordination, and skill. He finds health and joy at being accomplished in the martial arts. However, his emotions and questions of status among his peers remain troubled. “I fight because I am angry. I fight because I am inadequate. I fight yet I am restricted by fear of being hurt or humiliated.” With time, maturity, meditation, and self-reflection, the fighter’s capabilities and ego begin to melt. The mystical experience of being one with nature, and marvel at the Tao, soften all these sticky emotions and unsolvable problems. Eventually, these human frailties merge with the Tao in such a way that the adept finds peak experiences in the arena of meditation and fighting. In letting go of the desire to be accomplished, one paradoxically becomes accomplished.

In this final step there is working out of one’s own fundamental personality—the fulfillment of its potentials, the use of its capacities, and the desire to become the most that one is capable of being. Paradoxically, self-actualization comes with self-transcendence: one finds oneself by moving beyond oneself. The

achievement of self-transcendence is usually associated with a peak or transcendental experience.

In Maslow's hierarchy, "transcendental" or "unitive" experience is the peak experience associated with self-actualization. It is a perception of the unitive state, which can be equated with the mystical experience of the Tao: it is at this moment that the self is dissolved. As occurs with all high level work, the phenomena of paradox reveals itself: to become oneself one loses oneself. The adept lets go without any motivation for sexual desire, self-preservation, or acceptance by others. When the adept genuinely passes through this gate, the skills of the Tao will become manifest.

The following quotation by Bruce Lee (1940–1973) highlights these stages:

Right then as I was absorbing myself with the lesson of water, another mystic sense of hidden meaning revealed itself to me; should not the thoughts and emotions I had when in front of an opponent pass like the reflection of the bird flying over the water? This was exactly what professor Yip meant by being detached—not being within emotion or feeling, but being one in whom feeling was not sticky or blocked. Therefore in order to control myself I must first accept myself by going with and not against my nature. I lay on the boat and felt that I had united with the Tao; I had become at one with nature. I just laid there and let the boat drift freely according to its own will. For at that moment I had achieved a state of inner feeling in which opposition had become mutually cooperative instead of mutually exclusive, in which there was no longer any conflict in my mind. The whole world to me was one.¹³

In this passage, Bruce Lee finds that zone where negative emotions like fear are only fleeting. The opponent's moves become a part of a spontaneous unrehearsed play within something marvelous and unifying for all. Bruce Lee clearly articulates this sense of unity that was associated with his insight, which could accurately be called a "peak experience."

Further and varied paths to self-cultivation are noted in the classics. In the *Yang Family Forty Chapters*, Yang Pan-Hou divides the journey of self-cultivation and scholarship into three stages: low, middle, and top.¹⁴ Low-level cultivation includes external physical and martial accomplishments. Top-level cultivation involves internal energetic development and spiritual accomplishment. At this level, internal development includes the ability to turn the senses inward and transform them into listening and understanding jin. Yang Pan-Hou equates internal spiritual development with the acquisition of Fa Jin;¹⁵

at this point, neutralization of an opponent's force can be achieved. Important to the Universal Healing Tao practitioner, top-level accomplishment would mean the mastering of Fusion, Kan and Li, and Sealing of the Five Senses meditations.

However, as is the case with most life-long journeys, the ultimate benefits of the path are not recognized at the beginning. Within each warrior there is a deep subconscious attraction that draws him or her—much like the attraction of a lover. But it is only the years of exploration that reveal the wonders of the path itself. The warrior's journey becomes a valid path to self-realization when the principles of self-cultivation and internal alchemy are juxtaposed over a framework of the individual's maturation. The maturation of the warrior may be reflected in the acquisition of skills within the fighting arts that include emotional control, spontaneity, and Fa Jin. The authors acknowledge that this path is not for all adepts seeking the Tao. Deeper unknown portions of our being may determine who chooses to embark on this path; the hero or successful adept along it is the one who finds peace through the fighting arts.

There is another benefit to consider. When you use this form over a period of fifteen or twenty years, it becomes locked in the molecular memory of your cells and is a part of your consciousness. When you ascend—that is, when you die—you will take the Fa Jin form with you to the other realm. What you are indirectly doing with these years of practice is building a protective vortex that will aid you in the next realm. Remember: he who chops his own wood is twice warmed.

3

Principles of Discharge Power

In this chapter, we hope to provide a definition of discharge power and the stages of its expression. The steps required to accomplish Fa Jin will be explained through the lens of practices taught within the Universal Healing Tao system, including Iron Shirt structure, the transfer of power from the tan tien and turning of the waist as taught in the basic form of Tai Chi Chi Kung and Tan Tien Chi Kung, and the coupling of yin and yang as taught in the Fusion practices and Kan and Li meditations. References will be made to teachings of past masters as well as to living ones.

WHAT IS DISCHARGE POWER?

As described in chapter 1, discharge power is the issuing of internal power with seemingly little force, which is characteristic of the three internal martial arts—Tai Chi, Hsing Yi, and Ba Gua Zhang. There is little or no gross external movement or muscle power (li power) involved in the release of this force. Rather, it is transferred from the energetic realm to the opponent via the practitioner’s whole structure. In these arts, discharge power is better known by its pinyin name, Fa Jin.

There are various levels of achievement with Fa Jin. At a rudimentary level, one learns to discharge explosive force so that an opponent sustains a jolting impact. This correlates to a “one-inch” or “three-inch” strike.^{*6} At the other extreme, opponents can be thrown meters away with minimal touch or distortion. This is usually accomplished in the context of Push Hands and is known as “uproot and discharge.”

The primary teacher for Master Chia’s Universal Healing Tao system was Master Yi Eng, who collected various internal alchemical techniques from many masters throughout China. While the Universal Healing Tao system includes aspects of many traditions, it focuses primarily on meditation—and in particular on Internal Alchemy (*jin dan*) and the development of the Immortal Fetus (*yang tan shao*) (fig. 3.1). While the Universal Healing Tao system is comprehensive, it does not specialize in discharge techniques. So while it does teach the basic practice of merging yin and yang chi in the lower tan tien, which is fundamental

to any discharge practice, it does not profess to teach students the advanced skills of the Lei Shan Tao/Thunderbolt sect.



Fig. 3.1. The Immortal Fetus

The authors recognize the achievements of masters external to the Universal Healing Tao system in the practice of Fa Jin, and will explore their teachings on its principles here. While the Universal Healing Tao teachings are not geared toward the cultivation of Fa Jin, its practices can be used to help explain—and learn—this internal art.

The first question that must be asked—and answered—in regard to discharge power is, “What does jin feel like?” Since most martial artists will be seeking jin for the entirety of their careers, learning how to recognize it is an important step. The explosion of jin is often first experienced during deep meditation, when the mind becomes soft and absorbed in the pleasure of connection to the refined energies that can be found in this state. There is a sinking, and a period of relative apnea (cessation of respiration). From this space of deep connection, there is a sudden explosion of chi from the earth and the lower tan tien. It comes from a merging or copulation of the diametric energies of yin and yang.

In the Fusion and Kan and Li practices, this principle is often used to ejaculate the pearl out of the body to form the energy body. In Fa Jin, it is employed to direct an opponent’s force or energy to the tan tien and the earth. This is done in a state of pleasure, such that the practitioner’s body remains open and relaxed. The yang force from the opponent—along with any tension in your own body—is sunk deeply into the earth. This sinking means all major points of the body are relaxed to the earth: the neck is long, the shoulder and elbows are down, the lumbar vertebrae are tilted back, the coccyx is tucked under, and the *kua* (pelvis) is open. (The *kua* are the ligaments that connect the sacrum to the pelvis posteriorly and anteriorly between the crest of the ilium along the inguinal area

to the pubic bone.)

This yang energy reaches a zenith and finally touches or connects with a deeper aspect of yin. From this yin comes a rapid explosion that is transmitted from the earth—via the tan tien and body structure—to the opponent. Thus Fa Jin is the transformation of an opponent's yang and tension energy, which is neutralized deep in the earth and the lower tan tien, and combined with yin energy. From this coupling there is an explosion of jin, which is then discharged back to the opponent.

LEARNING FROM FA JIN MASTERS

Living and historical masters of Fa Jin can teach us a great deal about what it really is, and how it works. We have selected a few of these masters to help us illustrate the range and principles of discharge power. The adepts we have chosen to profile are:

1. Wu Yu-Hsiang
2. John Chang
3. Master Jiang
4. Chen Man-Ching
5. Chen XiaoWang
6. Lama Dondrup Dorje (Sifu Yeung)

Wu Yu-Hsiang (1812–1880)

Wu Yu-Hsiang provides us with a good description of certain aspects of internal power:

Store up the chin (jin) like drawing a bow.

Mobilize the chin like pulling silk from a cocoon.

Release the chin like releasing the arrow.

To fa chin relax completely and aim in one direction!

In the curve seek the straight, store then release.¹

To begin analysis of this quotation, let us figure out the anatomical correlates of the bow and arrow. In figure 3.18 of *Iron Shirt Chi Kung* the string for the bow was the Conception Vessel, while the bow itself was the spine or Governing Vessel.²⁷ In the context of Fa Jin, I would like to propose that the anatomical metaphor be reversed. As the body relaxes, the coccyx tucks underneath and the

Crown Point gets pulled up, so that the spine is pulled back like a string (fig. 3.2). At a precise moment, the opening and relaxation of the channels results in a conversion to yang and the arrow is released in a forward direction.

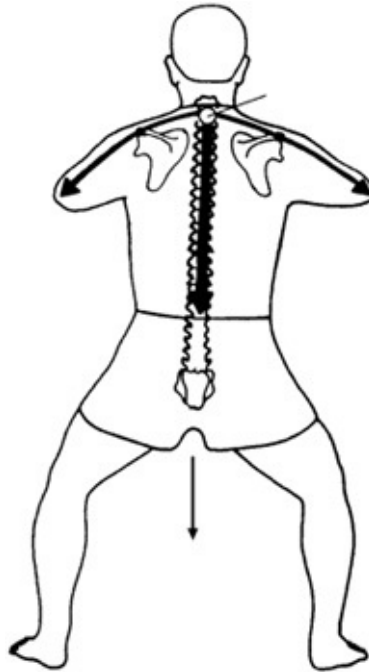


Fig. 3.2. Connect hands, scapulae, and spine to sacrum, then load bow and arrow.

To gather the jin, Wu suggests that the sensation should be akin to the pulling of silk. This silk feeling—described in the silk reeling exercise discussed in chapter 4—can be equated to kidney yin or Ching Chi; it is a step closer to perceiving the Original Chi. The silk feeling is promoted by letting go, and allowing the chi to move the arms and the body rather than using the mind to move the arms directly. Hence, in the returning or closing movement, allow everything to be soft. Allow the chi to move the arms and focus on the pleasant yin sensation in your lower tan tien.

The fourth line tells the practitioner to “relax completely” (*fang sung*). This is a big request, and one that is open to misinterpretation. Relaxing completely is more than just going limp. It implies all of the above in terms of letting go and allowing the chi to be directed by the Yi power (integrated three minds). It means allowing all tension to fall deep into the tan tien and the earth as your awareness moves beyond self and connects to the earth below. Arguments could also be made that “relax completely” means to release all tension or blockages from the major acupuncture channels. In other words, develop the ability to connect with the Original Chi and open up the Microcosmic Orbit in an instant.

The fifth line tells us, “In the curve seek the straight.” This is a phrase we

frequently use in Universal Healing Tao practices, including Iron Shirt training and the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung. As energy or jin passes up through the spine, the arms let go. They find their own coordination pattern. Interestingly, a forward strike does not involve a straight line. It involves a complex coordination of the musculature as the spinal vertebrae move backward, energy rises, the scapulae rotate, and the elbows drop as the wrist rotates.

“Store then release” is the last part of Wu’s quotation. This refers to seeking a place of stillness, or placing the tension or yang chi in a quiet place and allowing the transformation magic to occur. From stillness comes movement. The more stillness, the more discharge power.

John Chang (Magus of Java) (1944–)

John Chang is able to demonstrate the release of yang discharge power in the form of heat or an electric shock. He can also discharge yin energy. John Chang describes the foundation of his ability as lying within the tan tien. He practices in the Mo Pai tradition,²⁸ which has similarities to the Lei Shan Tao/Thunderbolt sect of Taoism. In the first stage of Mo Pai practice, the lower tan tien is filled with yang chi. In stage 2 the chi becomes solid. In stage 3, the tan tien can be moved to various places within the abdomen. In stage 4, yin and yang chi are compressed together, resembling the Tai Chi symbol as they mutually change and interact. Stage 4 is associated with the ability to emit an electric shock at a distance, as well as some telekinesis. Higher levels of practice include pyrokinesis. John Chang alleges that Chang SanFeng later reached the highest level achievable—level 72.²

On the surface, these stages have correlates with the Universal Healing Tao system. Stage 1 could be the perception of chi in the lower tan tien in the Microcosmic Orbit. Stage 2 occurs in the Fusion practices, as chi condenses to become experienced as a pearl. Stage 3 correlates to the multiple collection points of Fusion. Stage 4 is the Fusion itself, as fire and water or metal and wood are brought together in the lower tan tien.

Yet if these practices are all that is needed to emit a shock, why isn’t such an emission achievable by most students? There are many answers to this question including the simple one—that the right intention and the appropriate degree of mastery are needed to be able to juxtapose yin and yang chi in the right way. It may take time for the subtle aspects of these accomplished arts to be fully transmitted to students.

Master Jiang (1967–)

Like John Chang, Master Jiang is able to discharge chi at a distance. I (Andrew Jan) have personally experienced this myself. In our first encounter, he stood a few meters away and emitted chi from a sword finger, aiming it at my chest. I instantly felt a burning electric sensation there, which felt like I had touched a 240-volt AC domestic outlet.

Master Jiang's disciple Wu (a student of Jiang's for sixteen years) gives electric shocks as well, in the context of healing Chi Kung diagnosis and treatment. I watched as he first opened up the Bubbling Spring point by rubbing it with a wet towel, then used a sword-finger technique to emit chi and open the point further. Typically, the patient would then go for a brief jog, jump up and down, and stand on a wet towel. Wu would engage in a brief warm-up, rolling yin and yang chi between his heart and his lower tan tien, then with some effort would move the chi ball down from his shoulder to his hand. His hand would then go into spasm as he clasped the patient's hand. Immediately, the patient's arm would go into spasm and the patient would report strong electric shocks. Wu could sense whether this shock was passing freely into the patient's tan tien and back to him. He could touch any part of the body and cause contraction of the muscles and a sense of prickly, hot electric shocks.

Master Jiang's teacher displays the ability to burn a hole in a piece of paper at a distance. He can also telekinetically move a small object like a cigarette lighter a small distance across the floor.

Cheng Man-Ching (1902–1975)

The following information comes from Cheng Man-Ching's written work entitled "Master Cheng's Thirteen Chapters on T'ai-Chi Ch'uan."³ Cheng, who was taught by Yang Chen-Fu, sincerely wished to disclose the secrets of the art. This was in opposition to mainstream masters who would only teach to a select few, often withholding essential teachings. We are therefore indebted to masters like Cheng Man-Ching who are committed to revealing their teachings openly, and thereby keep the study and practice of Fa Jin alive.

Cheng Man-Ching places considerable emphasis on:

- Relaxation
- The metaphor of the two-man saw
- The bow and arrow metaphor
- Using four ounces to deflect a thousand pounds

Relaxation/Fang Sung

As mentioned above, discharge power relies on the body being totally relaxed. This means that when the practitioner is sinking down, all tension and blockages have largely disappeared. The neck becomes long as the head suspends, the kua (pelvis) opens, and the mind and chi go deeply into the earth. As Universal Healing Tao students learn during the practice of Iron Shirt and Tai Chi, power lives in relaxation, not in tension or willpower alone.

The Two-Man Saw

Cheng introduces this new concept and metaphor. He tells us that “the Rollback, Ward Off, Press, and Push of Push Hands move back and forth like the action of a two-man saw.”⁴ It seems that discharge power is a two-person phenomena. It is not carried out in isolation (fig. 3.3). If the opponent pulls then you follow and issue energy at just the right moment. Do not use force against force. As the opponent pulls, follow this force and amplify it.



Fig. 3.3. Two-man saw

The Bow and Arrow Metaphor

Cheng expands upon the bow and arrow metaphor used by Wu Yu-Hsiang. He says, “Shooting an arrow relies on the elasticity of the bow and string. The power of the bow and string derives from their softness, aliveness, and elasticity.”⁵ In other words, the foundation of discharge power is the dissipation of force, blockages, and tension, so that the body and mind are in a state of flowing chi and softness. This is no easy task, for it requires that the state of being we attain on a long meditation retreat be transposed to this moment of martial interaction, when fear and tension seem to take possession of our being.

Cheng emphasizes that in this state, the practitioner has “. . . the ability to unify the feet, legs, and waist into one flow of chi.”⁶ In this state of letting go, the

body finds its optimum functioning.

Repelling a Thousand Pounds with Four Ounces

This claim is of high importance and is quoted by many who refer to the classics and Fa Jin. To explain it, Cheng uses the metaphor of a bull being led with a rope via a ring in his nose. Transferring this metaphor to a Push Hands or martial situation, Cheng points out that the adept needs to find the circumstances—of both anatomy and timing—within the thirteen postures, wherein four ounces is all that is required to topple an opponent: this equates to the ability to lead a bull with a small force. Circumstances have to be created to reduce the power of the opponent by disrupting his Iron Shirt. These circumstances include the application of force to vital areas such as the elbow or shoulder when the opponent is on the edge of losing balance. Breaking the root can be achieved by disrupting the knee or by pushing or pulling the elbow away from the correct Iron Shirt position (fig. 3.4). Often a push is needed just prior to breaking the opponent's structure.

Chen XiaoWang (1945–)

Chen XiaoWang is one of the top four Chen masters in the world today. Collectively, Chen XiaoWang, Zhu Tian-Cai, Chen Zheng-Lei, and Wang Xi-An are called the “Four Tigers.” Chen XiaoWang's teachings offer some further insights into discharge power.

Chen style is noted for its training of spiral energy, which begins as large circles that become smaller and smaller with time and practice, until the initiation of the circle becomes invisible. Davidine Siaw-Voon Sim, author of *Chen Style Taijiquan* and a student of Chen XiaoWang, describes it this way: “With the energy generated from the ground through the feet. . . spiraling energy begins in the kidney area of the waist, goes down to the feet, and then rebounds to whichever part is going to express one's power.”⁷ Ultimately, he says, the outward manifestation of Fa Jin is like “a dog shaking water from its back” or the “crack of a whip.” Thus, when the spark appears from stillness, it is spiraled in an instant—like an immediate shiver or chill. It is then released with a shake.⁸

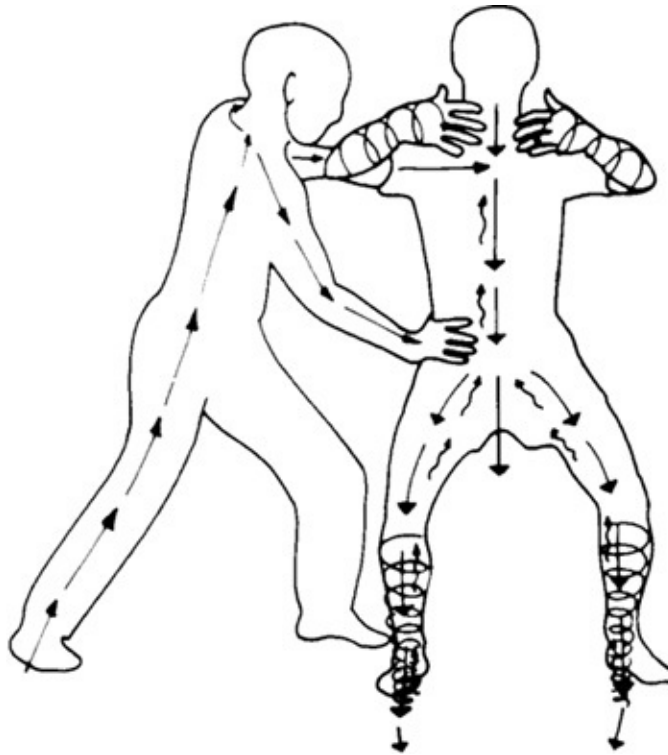


Fig. 3.4. The opponent's force is transferred down to the ground through the bone while maintaining correct structure.

Chen also emphasizes that the jin should be unimpeded on its journey from the earth and tan tien to the chosen endpoint. No resistance or friction must exist along its path. Hence, the body should not fight against itself. To this point he says:

Tan tien is at the heart of the body's motion
 Once a part moves, the whole body moves
 Joint by joint energy threads through
 Thus the force transmits unimpeded in one action.⁹

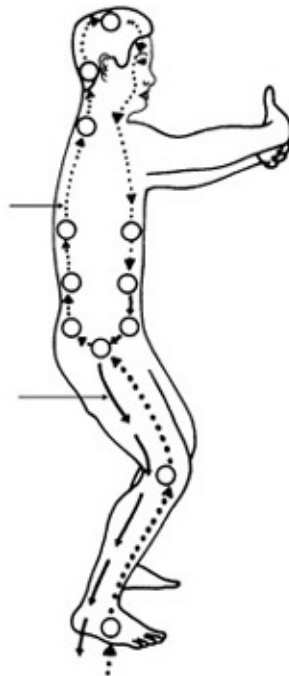


Fig. 3.5. Directing the chi flow

There should be no chi blockages and the body should be very relaxed (fig. 3.5). Chen remarks that Fa Jin is much like the art of calligraphy. Like a brush, the tan tien stores and releases the jin. The chosen point of impact is the endpoint.⁴⁹ The practitioner must be relaxed, open, and integrated, allowing the chi to move the limbs. There must be no stiffness or Fa Jin will be impeded.

Finally, Chen's disciple Sim emphasizes the principle that the monkey mind has no place in Fa Jin. Instead, it must be replaced by the integrated mind, which is a product of the merging of the three tan tiens to create Yi power (fig. 3.6). The integrated mind creates a template for the chi to follow. It can then move the limbs in a relaxed, coordinated, and optimum fashion. To these points, Sim repeats the instruction from the Yang classics about "using the Yi to lead the chi and using the chi to lead the body."¹⁰

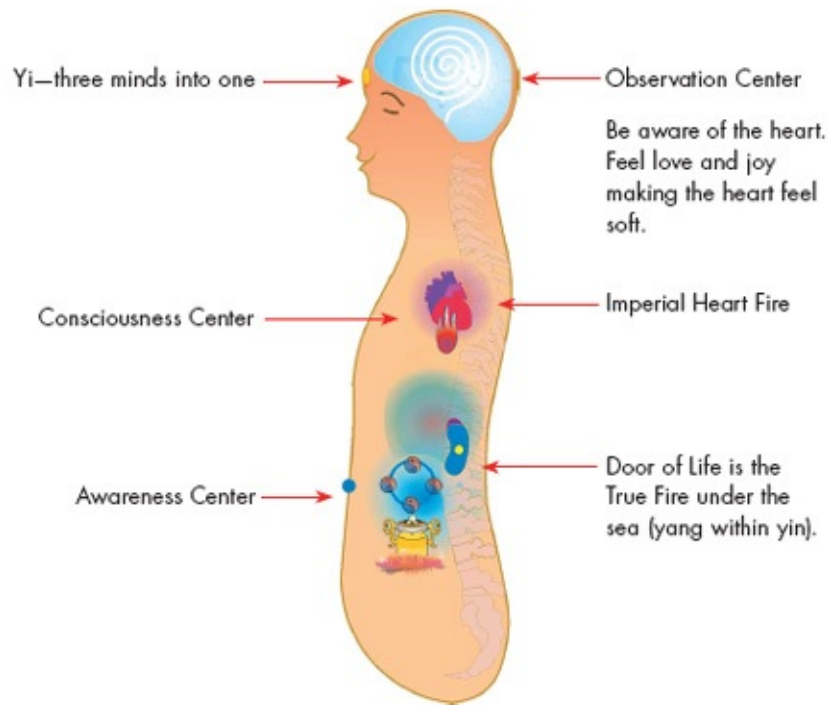


Fig. 3.6. Three minds into one

Lama Dondrup Dorje (Dr. Yeung) (1954–)

Lama Dondrup Dorje has given repeated demonstrations of discharge power that are viewable on his website.¹¹ His skill seems almost magical, as he is able to uproot an opponent with minimal or no touch. He defines Fa Jin as:

The projection of vibrational power that arises from the Ching plane (*the Plane of Primordial Essence*) of the lower tan tien through integrating the Wei Chi (protective energy) with the triangulated action of tendons, ligaments, and a relaxed yet properly aligned physio-skeletal structure.¹²

We believe that what Lama Dondrup Dorje is explaining here is the intimate and current connection between the Primordial Chi, the lower tan tien, the Defensive Chi (auric field), and the material bodily self. Ching Chi and Primordial Chi are closely related and are sensed as a silk-like feeling within the genitals and lower tan tien. The bubble of the Wei Chi is also connected so that the inner and outer worlds are united. Opponents need only come into contact with the Wei Chi and theoretically they will be uprooted. Lama Dorje's comments on the triad of tendons, ligaments, and bones accord with the basic teachings of Iron Shirt and the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung.

Lama Dondrup Dorje provides an explanation of the transition from the material Fa Jin to the magical (fig. 3.7). He describes the stages beyond Fa Jin as

Fa Chi and *Fa Shen*. With *Fa Chi*, the subtler powers of the middle or heart tan tien can disrupt an opponent's energetic structure. Likewise with *Fa Shen*, wherein the refined heavenly and spiritual energies of the upper tan tien or Crystal Palace are used to affect another's energetic existence.¹³

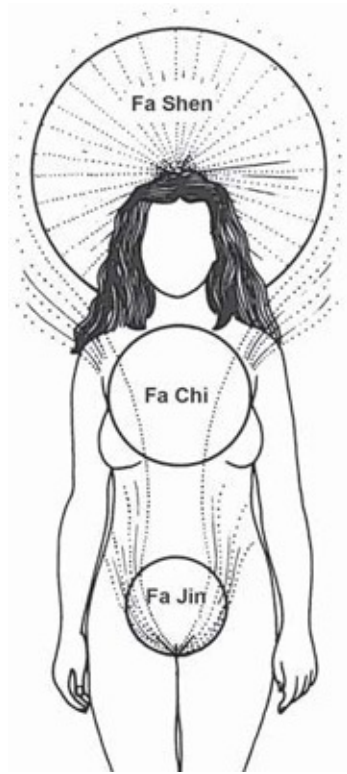


Fig. 3.7. Transformation of Fa Jin into Fa Chi and Fa Shen

Like the Chen masters, Lama Dorje emphasizes the power of reducing the size of the spiral energies used in *Fa Jin*. However, he goes a step further and makes a connection to the subtler planes of existence. He quotes Grand Master Wang Xiang-Zhai (1885–1963):

A big movement is not as effective as a small movement, a small movement is not as effective as the appearance of no movement, and it is the presence of movement within the appearance of no movement that is the real movement.¹⁴

In the practice of Chi Kung and other energy disciplines, the pathway from the material to the immaterial is fundamentally achievable (fig. 3.8). It requires the practitioner in his alert self to hold the earthly world of the senses and objective reality alongside the mystical sense of the void. If he can maintain a simultaneous experience of rapid physical movement and the ultimate stillness of the void, then much progress has been achieved in the journey to discovering

Fa Jin.



Fig. 3.8. Spirals getting smaller

FINDING THE PRINCIPLES OF UNIVERSAL HEALING TAO PRACTICE IN FA JIN

In the pages above, we have drawn upon fundamentals already taught within the Universal Healing Tao system to help students use skills they already know to understand discharge power. In the subsequent paragraphs and tables, the principles described above will be systematized and summarized. The first section will provide an overview in tabular form and break Fa Jin into stages. Within the table, each principle will be described and the corresponding practices from the Universal Healing Tao system briefly described. The third section will elaborate on these stages and finish with a summary.

STAGES IN THE RELEASE OF FA JIN

STAGE	DESCRIPTION	PRINCIPLE	ASPECT OF UNIVERSAL HEALING TAO TRAINING/ GENERAL COMMENTS
1	Yi creates a template for the chi, which in turn moves the body. Connect, link, adhere, and pursue (<i>zhan, lian, nian, and sui</i>) the opponent's force by listening (<i>ting</i>) and understanding (<i>dong jin</i>) through the body's structure. Lead it to lower tan tien and the earth.	In solo practice, allow the chi to move the arms. Feel the tan tiens activate as you pull in the arms. In Push Hands or fighting, stick lightly to the opponent. Initiate the "two-man saw."	In Iron Shirt practice the adept eventually learns to abandon muscular force (Li power) and replace it with the openness and softness of chi or jin. In Tai Chi practice and the Six Healing Sounds meditation, experience the chi moving the body. In meditations like the Fusion practice, awareness and the senses are projected through the body and even beyond it.

STAGE	DESCRIPTION	PRINCIPLE	ASPECT OF UNIVERSAL HEALING TAO TRAINING/ GENERAL COMMENTS
2	The yin stage of Iron Shirt	The art of relaxing and using the incoming force to open the adept's structure. This stage includes the formation of the bow and string.	This practice is learned through sitting meditation and rooting in Iron Shirt. Learning to enjoy, relax, and be stretched by a push. This relaxation sees the tan tiens contract. There is emptying and consequent cessation of the breath with activation of the empty force.
3	Transformation: neutralizing the force	The yang energy of the opponent and any tension are sent into the earth. The yin energy of the earth and lower tan tien combine with this yang chi until there is a moment of stillness. The incoming force has thus been neutralized.	In Iron Shirt practice the opponent's push is neutralized by rooting force into the earth. In the Microcosmic Orbit, Fusion, and Kan and Li meditations, the beauty and power of the Wu Wei and stillness is appreciated. The moment of stillness is a connection to the mystery of the Tao.
4	Taking aim: rotation and reorientation	Use the Central Thrusting Channel (<i>Chong Mai</i>) and allow the body to rotate around this axis spontaneously.	In the moment of stillness, like the eye of a storm or the hub of the wheel, the body prepares to take aim. In the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung, the transitions between each of the thirteen forms eventually become effortless. Chi or jin moves the body as it rotates on its central axis.

STAGE	DESCRIPTION	PRINCIPLE	ASPECT OF UNIVERSAL HEALING TAO TRAINING/ GENERAL COMMENTS
5	Power appears to originate from the earth.	Chi passes without effort through the feet and legs to the waist/lower tan tien.	Correct Iron Shirt structure of the lower half of the body. Practice letting chi pass unheeded from the feet to the waist. Partner work can be used to push and test the lower half of the body. In the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung, multiple transitions, rooting, and adjustments are made between the lower tan tien and the earth.
6	Expansion of the lower tan tien, which then cascades to the other two tan tiens	Separation of the Governing Vessel from the Conception Vessel. The bow is being loaded.	Correct Iron Shirt structure for the entire body. Structure can be tested by a partner at T11, T5, C7, the base of the skull, and the shoulders.
7	Controlled expansion of structure while advancing or entering application	The adept prepares and moves into a position where "four ounces will repel a thousand pounds."	The adept finds the ideal setting for release of discharge power via one of the eight gates. With years of Tai Chi practice, the adept has mastered transitions, interchanges, and genuine understanding of the thirteen postures.
8	Sudden release of jin through the structure into the opponent	Spark arises in the kidney area. Sudden and massive release of jin. The body shakes and discharges via one of the eight gates to topple the opponent.	The adept's Iron Shirt structure is open, which allows the unimpeded flow of jin. Jin flows up the spine through the sacrum, Ming Men, T11, T5, C7, and Jade Pillow. Jin is released through arms, by "finding the curve in the straight"—the scapula round, elbows drop, and wrists rotate. "Shaking" is often experienced in sitting meditation when a burst of chi is sensed in the body. In Fusion and Kan and Li practices, the spontaneous ejaculation of the pearl has similarities to this release of jin.

THE EIGHT STAGES OF FA JIN

The following eight stages of Fa Jin describe the sequence of events that are required for the cultivation and release of discharge power. While the individual stages are steps in the sequence, they also describe successive levels of mastery.

Stage 1: Sticking to the Opponent or Following the Chi

In the first step of the Fa Jin sequence, the adept needs to develop a sensitivity and softness in solo practice, learning to let the body be moved by the chi (fig. 3.9). This lesson is emphasized by the Yang lineage and in the teachings of Chen

XiaoWang discussed above. (See pages 32–35.) The first step is to feel the chi and the second step is to be moved by it. In the Universal Healing Tao system, the sensation of chi can occur during the Six Healing Sounds meditation and during the practice of the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung. When you are connected to the chi, you can allow your hands and trunk and legs to move by themselves. To facilitate movement by chi, open the three tan tiens in either sitting or standing postures. With very slight movements of the finger joints, the movement by chi can be initiated. If there are any blockages in the body, then the body will not move.



Fig. 3.9. Stage 1: Chi moving arms, blocking, and sticking to opponent

In Push Hands and fighting, sensitivity is developed to stick to the opponent. The senses are acute and one gains insight into the opponent's intention and balance. In terms of Fa Jin, the force from the opponent is followed, then borrowed and used at a later stage.

Stage 2: Yin Formation of Iron Shirt Structure

Stage 2 correlates to the yin stage of Iron Shirt training, where an opponent's force is used to open and lengthen the adept's structure.¹² This yin stage can also be described as activating the empty force—the extra power that is generated at the end of exhalation with the sucking in of the Ren channel. This yin stage is separate from the yang stage, which involves inflation of the lower tan tien and packing of the structure. This division of Iron Shirt structure into yin and yang aspects is not described in the original Iron Shirt text but is a key element of discharge power (fig. 3.10).

The fundamental characteristic of this yin aspect of Iron Shirt is relaxation, called *fang sung* in pinyin. As the opponent's force enters into the body, relaxation and sinking must match this force exactly. Yang energy from the opponent is guided down to the earth with the sinking of the mind's awareness. This relaxation includes the elongation of muscles, rather than just becoming like a dead fish. It allows the arms, neck, and legs to lengthen.



Fig. 3.10. Stage 2: Empty Force and Iron Shirt posture

In other words, the body relaxes within the specified structure. To sink does not mean to simply bend the knees, but means to sink by opening the kua and the Ming Men while tucking in the coccyx. Along with these changes, the shoulder blades round, the sternum sinks, the neck becomes long, and the Crown Point (Ba Hui) is lifted. Wu Yu-Hsiang tells us that “this is called the suspended head top.”¹⁶ Throughout the body, the muscles are elongated to their optimum length. There is a sense of fullness and openness that is obtained through relaxation by allowing the whole body to be filled with chi.

In many respects, this yin stage of Fa Jin is just an extension of Iron Shirt training and pushing. The incoming force is borrowed and utilized to lengthen the spine, open the channels, and connect with the empty force. Often but not always, the breath is also emptied and ceases for a moment.

Stage 3: Transformation

The transformation stage embodies the mystique of discharge power. At this

level, forces are taken to a still point deep in the earth and lower tan tien, where they are magically transformed (fig. 3.11). This highlights the essence of the Tai Chi symbol and even the cosmological theory of the Tao. Yang from the opponent is courted by the yin of the adept into stillness.

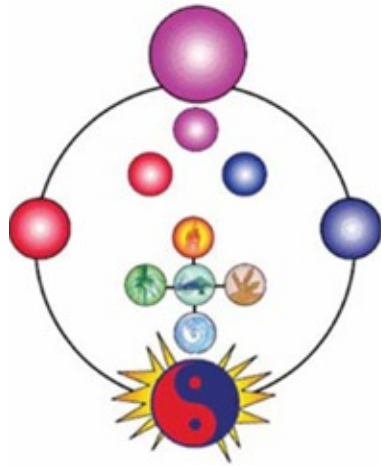


Fig. 3.11. Stage 3: Transformation, a cosmic Big Bang

If Fa Jin is viewed from an alchemical and cosmological perspective, this process can be seen as the return to unity—to the Tao—via the coupling of yin and yang. It is a reversal of the Taoist creation theory, enabling a return to the One. From unity, the Big Bang occurs with an explosion that can be correlated to the discharge power of Fa Jin.

Stage 4: Rotations and Taking Aim

While jin power is in its undifferentiated or quiescent form, the adept can begin preparing to send it in the chosen direction. This is more easily achieved if the adept has opened the Central Thrusting Channel (*Chong Mai*). The body can rotate around it while maintaining Iron Shirt structure. Development of the Central Thrusting Channel in Push Hands means that even in the backward posture, there is strength. The central axis is used in the central and forward positions, and also enables power to be released left or right (fig. 3.12).

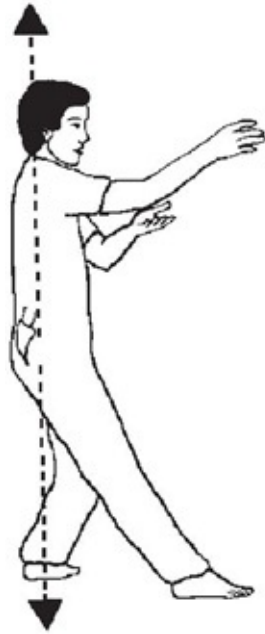


Fig. 3.12. Stage 4: Central axis in sink-back position

Stage 5: Jin Appears from the Earth

From the stillness an initial force appears. This initial force feels like silky Ching Chi or Earth Chi, but is theoretically Primordial Chi, because the yin and yang chi have been merged. This Primordial Chi prepares root in the legs, sacrum, and waist, and is the foundation for the ultimate release of Fa Jin (fig. 3.13). This foundation loosens the structure and creates an environment for the spark or Big Bang to appear.



Fig. 3.13. Stage 5: Rooting to the earth force with Fa Jin

Stage 6: Expansion of the Lower Tan Tien

The rush of Primordial Chi comes from the earth and passes up through the legs to the lower tan tien, inflating it (fig. 3.14). The kidneys separate from the navel. For a moment the chi/jin is stored in the lower tan tien.

Stage 7: Passage of Chi/Jin Through the Structure while Preparing Application

In the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung, students learn to release the power from the earth or the opponent in an effortless and structured manner. This power is stored in the earth and the lower tan tien, then released through the body in a specific pattern. The first pattern we learn is a release through the spine in the classic Push, or in a Two-Hand Push (fig. 3.15). The jin or power ascends from the feet via the legs, which are kept in their rooted form. Chang SanFeng says, “The motion should be rooted to the feet, released through the legs, controlled by the waist.” This means that the legs are lengthened because the kua has been opened in a way that allows the coccyx to be tucked under and the front kua to open.¹³ Power is released via the spine’s sacral, lumbar, thoracic, and cervical vertebrae. The arms are connected to the power via C7 and the rounded scapulae. As Wu says, “In moving the chi, it sticks to the back and permeates the spine.” If the adept has a broken structure, then the final jin force cannot be discharged freely. Chang SanFeng reminds us that “. . . All parts of the body must be light, nimble, and strung together.”¹⁷

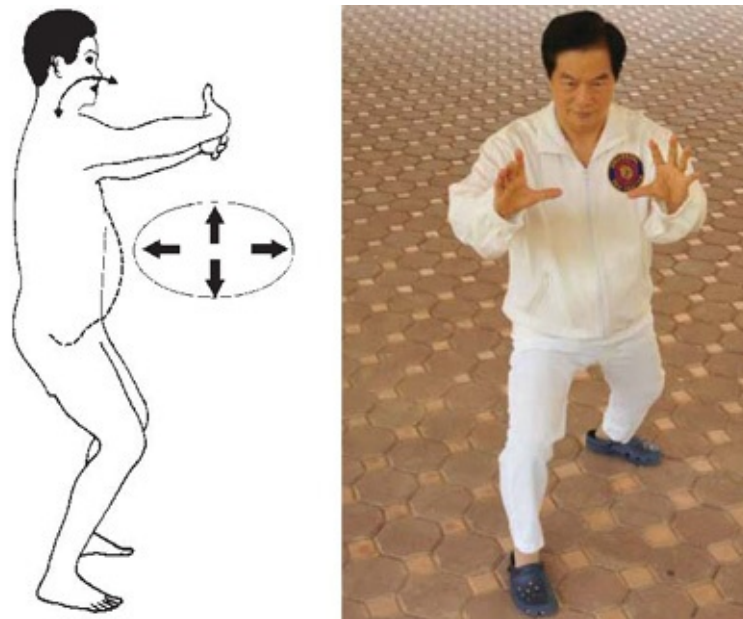


Fig. 3.14. Stage 6: Inflated tan tien



Fig. 3.15. Stage 7: Opponent being pushed in Iron Shirt posture as jin passes through structure

The whole structure is now prepared for the final climax. It is fully bathed in Primordial Chi and awaiting the final spark. The opponent is also now at the zenith of imbalance, and those proverbial “four ounces” are now all that is needed to throw him.

Stage 8: Discharge of Power into the Opponent

The spark or bang is now ignited. It makes itself known with a different sensation—a shiver or a spiral in the lower back. The whole structure is impregnated with this force; it is like a sneeze or an orgasm, shaking the back like a dog shakes water from its body. There is no friction or impedance to this force, because the pathway has been laid open by the prior stages of practice, and by the bathing and expansion of the body with Primordial Chi.

The arms find the “straight via the curve,” as in the Tao Yin postures of Bow and Arrow and Dragon Tucks in its Tail and Stretches its Claws. The arm tendons rotate in a particular pattern that follows the jin as it travels through the spine. In the standard Two-Hand Push, C7 goes back, the scapulas rotate medially from their inferior portion as well as spreading out laterally, the elbows drop, and the hands rotate laterally.

Just as the adept’s body is prepared for this final jin, so too is the opponent’s. He has been trapped, his structure is broken, and he is on the point of imbalance. The force or jin connects, and he is thrown (fig. 3.16).



Fig. 3.16. Stage 8: Uprooting discharge

SUMMARY OF FA JIN FROM A UNIVERSAL HEALING TAO PERSPECTIVE

The eight stages of Fa Jin can be summarized as follows:

1. Following an opponent or the chi
2. Using the opponent's force to develop the yin aspect of Iron Shirt structure
3. Neutralization and transformation
4. Taking aim and rotating using the Central Thrusting channel
5. Preparing the legs and waist with Primordial Chi
6. Expanding the tan tien with Primordial Chi
7. Moving into position where the adept is vulnerable and expanding the rest of the body's structure
8. Release of discharge power—like a spark that initially shakes the back

THE EIGHT GATES OR EIGHT FORCES

Discharge power manifests itself via eight different pathways or gates. These are known as Peng, Lu, Ji, An, Tsai, Lieh, Chou, and Kou. Development of these inner forces requires skill developed from the Fusion practices and Kan and Li practice.

Certain texts and masters correlate the eight forces to various forms within the long Yang 108 Form. However, the forms can have varied gates or forces applied to their movements. Therefore, the primary focus should be on the discharge energy behind the move or the form, rather than on the external container for that force.

Many authors have attempted to correlate the eight gates with the eight trigrams of the pakua (Ba Gua), but these correlations have been inconsistent throughout the literature. The trigrams from the pakua are quoted by Chan SanFeng in the *Yang Family Forty Chapters*.¹⁸ However, there seems to be little correlation with the energetic metaphors described by Tan Meng-Hsien. We choose to adopt the correspondences outlined in the table below:

EIGHT GATES FOR DISCHARGE OF POWER

TACTIC	OUTWARD MANIFESTATION	TRIGRAM	INNER MANIFESTATION
Peng	Ward Off	<i>Chien</i>	Spring
Lu	Rollback	<i>Kun</i>	Emptiness
Ji	Press	<i>Kan</i>	Bounce
An	Push	<i>Li</i>	Water
Lieh	Circular diversion	<i>Chen</i>	Spinning
Tsai	Lever	<i>Sun</i>	Lever
Chou	Elbow	<i>Tui</i>	Continuity of yin and yang
Kou	Shoulder	<i>Ken</i>	Pounding a Pestle

棚 Peng

Peng is the internal energy that results in relaxed resistance within the body. It is generated from the original source that inflates the body from the inside, and it is like a spring that is ready to be released. To cultivate Peng force, Tan Meng-Hsien recommends visualizing the tan tien as expansive and pushing out like a

charged coiled spring through the fascial planes to the hands and fingers.¹⁹ The closest element would be wood power.

In order to be properly expanded by this internal energy, the body needs to be a hollow vehicle. Practitioners often describe Peng as a feeling of vitality and resistance. In the *Songs of the Eight Postures*, Tan Meng-Hsien says, “The whole body has the power of a spring. Opening and closing should be clearly defined.”²⁰

To release the Peng force, either slip away from an opponent’s force, or remove it like a quick-release valve. This will allow the Peng force to drive home into the opponent (fig. 3.17). Peng is activated by the Push but never overreaches it. Hence the master of Peng will not be uprooted once the opponent’s Push is withdrawn, as the force is generated from the original source and not from muscular strength, which would throw the body off center.



Fig. 3.17. Single Push Hands releasing Peng force into the lower tan tien

Peng is classically used in the Ward Off position but can theoretically be applied to many forms. The important principle is to use the body as a loaded spring.

璐 Lu

Lu cultivates extreme yin and requires a body memory of the Wu Wei or emptiness. For many students, this may start as visualization. With time, the body integrates the knowledge into the body and movement. Therefore, one moves from visualization to actualization.

The magical Lu is able to lead an opponent’s force in a desired direction. It is magical because it typifies the transformative power of softness in martial arts

and because it is a gateway to all the other gates (fig. 3.18). Classically, it is a lead to the side as a Rollback in the Bird's Tail, but it can also be executed up or down. In its highest form, the opponent's force is led into a sensation of emptiness (fig. 3.19). The sensation of emptiness is cultivated by mystical practice, and in this situation, is integrated into a martial application.

During Push Hands, the practitioner feels the opponent's energies and senses departure from the true ideal state—the Iron Shirt posture. Any deviation—sensed as tension or aggression—is led back to the Wu Wei or nothingness. Tan Meng-Hsien says, “We follow the incoming force. . . . When his force is spent, he will naturally become empty.”²¹ In this way, Push Hands can be seen as a martial practice that helps cultivate the Tao. Lu is cultivated by the silk reeling exercises explored in chapter 4.



Fig. 3.18. Outward tactic of Lu diversion



Fig. 3.19. Outer space in the tan tien

挤 Ji

The Ji force is characteristically performed using the Press from the Bird's Tail form but can be used in any other movement (fig. 3.20). Inwardly, the discharge force is likened to a coin bouncing off a drum.²² The tan tien expands and stretches the fasciae of the body like the skin of a drum or the strings of a tennis racquet. Therefore the body needs to be rooted, packed, and strong prior to the release of the force. The opponent is then bounced away with seemingly minimal effort. Releasing the power of the Ji force is more effective when the opponent is on the brink of toppling over.

During the Press, a connection is made to the opponent that gets him ready to topple. The practitioner roots to the earth, and at the moment that he places his second hand behind the first, the force is released. While the Press typifies this force, Ji can be used in many external strikes including those of the shoulder and elbow.



Fig. 3.20. Press posture

按 An

The external manifestation of the An force as used in the Bird's Tail is the Push. This force relies on the transmission of force from the earth via the Iron Shirt structure (fig. 3.21). While this has been said many times in this text, it is so important that it really cannot be said enough. The chi/jin begins from the earth like roots of a tree. The nine points of the feet softly connect with the ground. The legs are screwed gently into the earth.

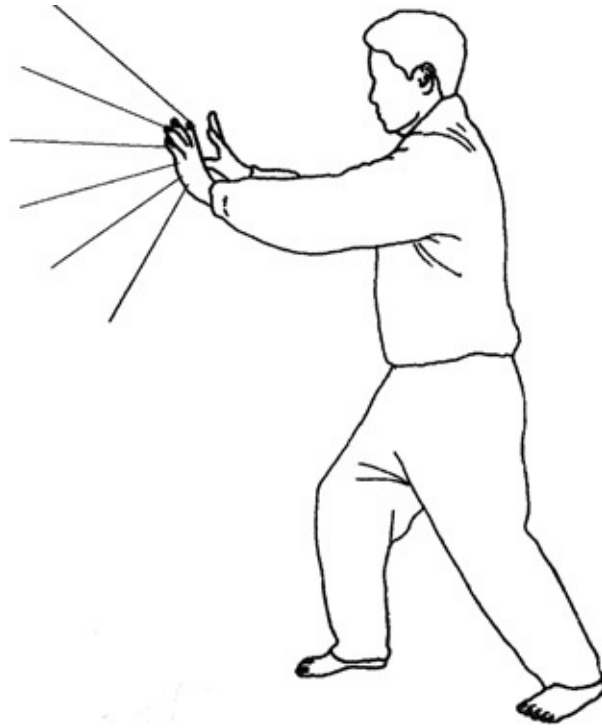


Fig. 3.21. Double-Handed Push transmitting chi

At the same time, the coccyx and sacrum tuck underneath, which then opens the kua. Consequently, the lumbar goes back, which reverses the usual lordosis. The jin or chi is then transmitted segment by segment through the lumbar, thoracic, and cervical vertebrae, and then moves into the arms. As it is transmitted through the arms, the scapula rotate, the elbows drop, and both arms rotate externally. This movement uses the principle of the curve to access the direct transmission of power from the trunk and is described as “In the curve seek the straight.”²³ It allows an effortless passage of chi from the earth through the Iron Shirt structure, which enables the Push (fig. 3.22).



Fig. 3.22. Outward form of An in a Push

Once this basic alignment of movement has been learned, then the essence of the force can be applied. According to Tan Meng-Hsien, the principle of the discharge is water.²⁴ Through careful listening by the practitioner, every small crevice or break in the opponent's structure is filled with water chi. Through the effortless power of water, the opponent is backed up until he has no reserve. His structure is broken and only a feather is now needed to move him. One small force will now push the opponent back.

冽 Lieh

The internal manifestation of this force is a spinning disc or whirlpool. This sensation is created in the tan tien and extends around the Central Thrusting Channel (*Chong Mai*) (fig. 3.23). Any external force that enters the body will be caught up in the centrifugal force and be cast out faster than it entered. Therefore, to cultivate this force the central axis must be internally defined through sitting practice and standing meditation. Opening the Central Thrusting Channel is a core practice in *Fusion of the Eight Psychic Channels*.^{*14}

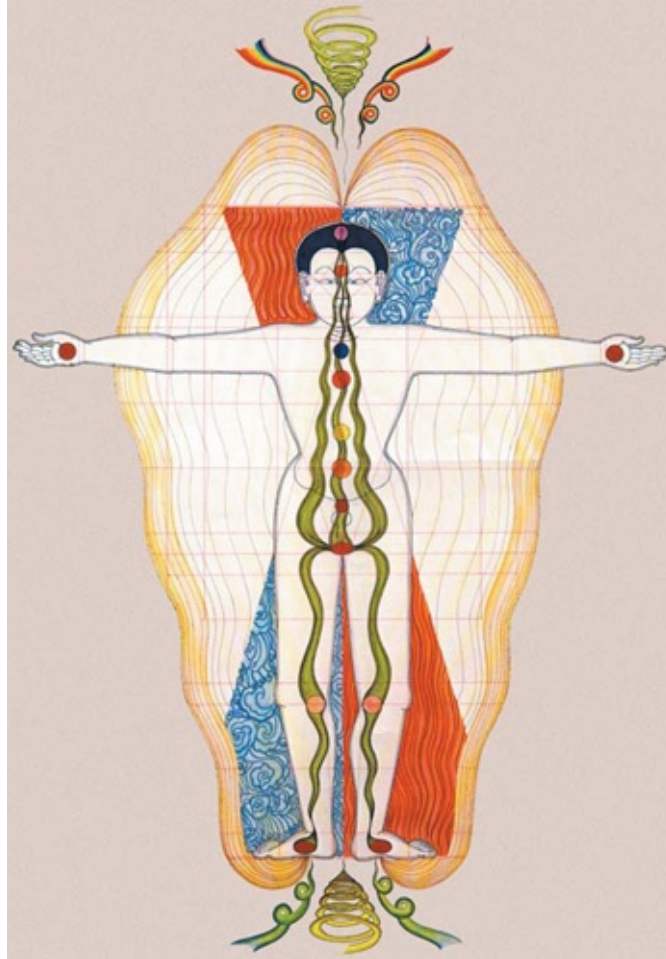


Fig. 3.23. Central Thrusting Channel

This awareness of the Central Thrusting Channel must be translated to both the Push Hands and boxing arenas. The Central Thrusting Channel is maintained with 80–90 percent of the weight on the back leg in the retreat position of Push Hands. Any force will then rotate around this central axis and accelerate with the internal energy produced by the practitioner.

The external manifestation of this movement usually originates from Lu and multiplies as the movement or force engages the spinning Central Thrusting Channel. The movement originates with both arms starting their journey close together, but vectors of force can fly from the center at varying angles, thus enabling the power of a double strike (fig. 3.24).



Fig. 3.24. Outward manifestation of Lieh as a splitting force

This means that one hand can control and strike the wrist while another can strike the elbow or shoulder. This double force is compared to an agricultural implement used in China to cut hay. In the West it would be more akin to flicking a towel to sting a friend, or cracking a whip. Again, this force is characterized by a slow entry into the spiral and then acceleration with a fast release. Momentum of the leading arm is balanced by the rear arm moving in the other direction. This force can be applied with such moves as the Single Whip and the Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (figs. 3.25 and 3.26).



Fig. 3.25. Application with Single Whip



Fig. 3.26. Application of Fair Lady Works the Shuttle

钛 Tsai

This force is characterized by leverage—usually at the elbow, but it can easily be applied to the wrist, shoulder, or torso (figs. 3.27 and 3.28). Tsai takes over from the Lu force, which precedes it, lengthening the opponent's arm to break his Iron Shirt structure. The Tsai force then locks the elbow and uses it as leverage to either take the opponent to the ground or fling him off. In the discharge form this move is practiced with the Rollback after the Ward Off.



Fig. 3.27. Elbow lock position



Fig. 3.28. Shoulder lock position

肘 Chou

The Chou force uses the elbow as an alternative striking implement to the hands (fig. 3.29). There are times when the hand is engaged and the opponent is within short striking distance; in this case, the elbow can be used. Often the Chou is applied when an opponent has executed a move with the Lu force. Turning disadvantage into advantage, the practitioner uses the opponent's force against him, altering its vector slightly via the elbow strike.



Fig. 3.29. Execution of the elbow strike as a counterattack

The inner manifestation of the Chou force is described by Tan Meng-Hsien as maintaining within the body the varied energies of yin and yang (full and empty) and the five elements (fig. 3.30). This principle may be difficult to understand on first examination, but the skills have already been learned in the Fusion

practices.

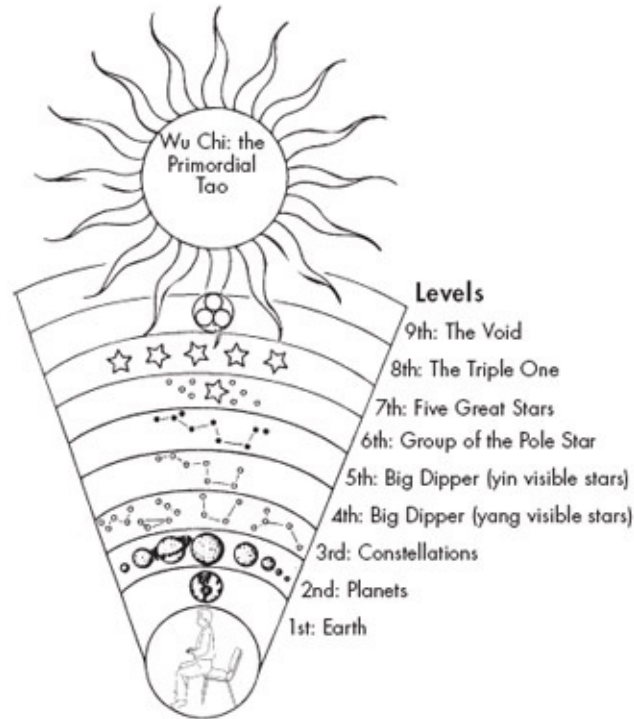


Fig. 3.30. Taoist cosmology and creation sequence

扎 Kou

Kou—the shoulder strike—can be used in various situations, from an unsuspecting neutral position to a last-resort counter attack similar to the one described above with the elbow strike. In the latter circumstance, the practitioner has used the Lu force and the shoulder takes a minor detour. Power is discharged through the shoulder to the opponent's torso. It can also be used front-on, especially if the opponent attempts to split or separate the practitioner's hands. In non-fixed-feet Push Hands, the shoulder strikes the opponent while the practitioner is stepping through. Its application is best understood in the Tai Chi form Flying Oblique (fig. 3.31).



Fig. 3.31. Flying Oblique

The shoulder strike can be used as a technical exercise. In this case, both the front and back Kou strikes are practiced (fig. 3.32). Power is obtained by Iron Shirting the body during the moment of impact so that the force is evenly distributed. Care must be taken to place chi in the neck to prevent whiplash injury to the cervical spine.

The Kou force's internal energetic image is that it “crashes like a pounding pestle.”²⁵ The explosion occurs after grinding; there is an initial contact and spiraling force, which release the energy like friction igniting a spark. This release of power relies on creating a strong Iron Shirt structure via the connection with the opponent during grinding. The spark is then lit from the tan tien and power is released.

We hope that this step-by-step analysis will give you new insights into Fa Jin practice. However, as with all complicated human achievements (especially those concerning the Tao), all of these stages—once mastered—will ultimately melt into one.



Fig. 3.32. Technical exercises for front and back Kous

4

Warm-ups and Technical Exercises

Warm-ups are basic to both Eastern and Western physical disciplines. In this chapter, both aspects will be offered, allowing the reader to compare and contrast them. The chapter will finish with specific warm-ups that we believe are beneficial to practicing Fa Jin and the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form.

THE WESTERN VIEW OF WARM-UPS

Most Westerners are familiar with warm-ups and recognize the physical and psychological benefits of them.¹ They are geared toward optimizing performance while minimizing physical injuries. Depending on the sport, warm-up goals may include aspects of agility, flexibility, balance, and strength. Injury avoidance during a warm-up includes surveillance of previously injured parts, awareness of vulnerable positions, and removal of stiffness.

From a Western point of view, warm-ups are needed to physically warm the tissues involved. A slightly higher body temperature encourages peak performance, bringing neuromuscular excitation and length-tension relationships to optimal levels. Increased body heat also reduces the viscosity of synovial fluid, resulting in better lubrication of the joints. The increased suppleness that results from an adequate warm-up is an antidote to injury and is helpful in preventing post-exercise pain.

The mind also benefits from a warm-up, as lack of focus can lead to poor timing, and consequent incorrect delivery of a technique. This places excessive stress on particular joints, muscles, or tendons and can cause strain or injury. Psychologist David Kauss explains that the warm-up is a chance to reduce fear, minimize negative chatter, and quiet the mind by engaging the body in light exercise.² And while Western culture does not emphasize the unity of mind and body the way that Eastern practices do, many athletes and performers do recognize a “zone” of optimum performance that involves the mind and mental focus. Author Robert Kriegel calls this the “C Zone” and outlines six characteristics of it. According to Kriegel, this state of mind is: effortless, positive, spontaneous, focused, vital (characterized by high energy and joy), and transcendent (more effective than usual).³

In the West, warm-ups are classified into general and specific types.⁴ General warm-ups involve certain body movements and general mind/body preparation that does not necessarily include the specific skills associated with the final performance. Specific warm-ups verge on technical training and include a warm-up of the neuromuscular pathways that are required for the task at hand.

THE TAOIST VIEW OF WARM-UPS

From a Taoist perspective, the warm-up must provide a transition from our everyday mind and bodily state to one that is conducive to the successful release of discharge power. Chang SanFeng gives us an idea of what state we are seeking to achieve with a warm-up practice. He says:

Whenever one moves, the entire body must be light and lively, and must all be connected throughout. The chi should be excited and the spirit should be gathered within. Let there be no hollows or projections; let there be no stops and starts. Its root is in the feet, its issuing from the legs, its control from the Yao and its shaping in the fingers. From the feet, to the legs, and then the Yao; there must be completely one chi.⁵

Here Chang SanFeng emphasizes that the body, the chi, and the spirit must be awakened. The hollows and projections he refers to are those parts of the body that can become stiff due to blockages in the acupuncture channels that prevent the formation of Iron Shirt posture. The Yao refers to the waist, including the lower tan tien and the Belt Channel (*Dai Mai*). “One chi” means that the various energies throughout the body are connected and able to work as a unit.

In this passage, Chang highlights the Taoist notion of where strength comes from: the body, mind, chi, and tan tien all work as one. This phenomenon of spiritual strength is outside the orthodox Western scientific paradigm, but it is integral to Eastern concepts of ability. Spiritual strength can be understood as drawing upon a consciousness beyond self. In other words, true power comes from tapping into a force outside of oneself—the power of the earth and the heavens.

From the Universal Healing Tao perspective, any warm-up should include the awakening and merging of the three tan tiens. When the upper tan tien (Crystal Palace), the middle (the heart) tan tien, and the lower tan tien are all awakened and connected, they operate as one unit—the integrated mind—and this is the mind that is a prerequisite for discharge power. In the everyday mind, the upper tan tien exists as a perversion of its higher self. This “monkey mind” lacks the capacity to execute Fa Jin, so any effective warm-up must subdue it. This is

usually done through easy, repetitive, quieting exercises.

Optimum and balanced organ energy is another aspect of discharge power that should be achieved during warm-ups. Each organ should be balanced so it can offer its elemental energy to the tan tien. Although recognition of organ power is outside the scope of the Western clinical paradigm, it is not necessarily beyond the scope of Western culture. For example, warriors and sportsman who perform incredible feats are often given names that describe their heart energy, like William “Brave Heart” Wallace (1272–1305) and King Richard the Lion Heart (1157–1199). Shakespeare believed that many varied states of being arose from the spleen, including the connection between heaven and earth.¹⁵ He also described Lady Macbeth as wanting to replace her breast milk with bile, so that she would have the “gall” to kill Duncan.¹⁶ In the wisdom of our own language, openness is equated with a vented spleen and excessive anger is equated with being liverish (livid).

In the Eastern paradigm, excessive arousal or overexcitement of any of the emotions will interfere with performance. Hence a warm-up is used to bring the organs and their associated emotions into a balanced, relaxed, and neutral state (fig. 4.1).



Fig. 4.1. Smiling to the organs

STRETCHES

Stretching is an important component of all generic warm-ups. From a Western viewpoint, stretching improves the range of motion of the involved joints. It

helps to prevent injuries and post-exercise soreness. From a physiological perspective, stretching facilitates neuromuscular pathways, and in particular the proprioceptors, which are nerve endings that provide the central nervous system with information on the location of joints and muscles within space and time.

From an Eastern perspective, stretching opens acupuncture channels and helps settle the monkey mind. Blocked channels are perceived as either a lack of chi flow to a particular body part or a feeling of stagnant or unhealthy chi. For example, sensations of prickliness, excessive heat, and even lethargy are features of blocked channels, while feelings of openness, pleasant body sensations, and muscle vigor are indicative of open channels.

In the Eastern way of thinking, gaining extra range of motion requires the mind to integrate with the body. For example, in a hamstring stretch, the burning sensations of these contracted muscles are explored and welcomed by the mind. By the act of a relaxed acceptance, the muscle fibers release. When muscles and channels are relaxed and open this allows the monkey mind to settle down (fig. 4.2).

The Taoist approach of the Universal Healing Tao system uses gentle stretches that highlight chi flow rather than extreme ranges of movement. (This is seemingly different from yoga practices, where an extreme range of motion is regarded as both the endpoint and the goal.) The Taoist approach is similar in many ways to orthodox Western stretching, but it also includes the perception of chi and the integration of the mind and body.

Variations on stretching occur in both the Western and Universal Healing Tao systems. Plyometrics is a Western type of exercise training designed to produce fast, powerful muscle movements. It includes activities such as skipping and repetitive on-the-spot jumping. Bounce or ballistic stretching is an attempt to gain increased range of movement by bouncing off muscle resistance. Recently, ballistic stretching has fallen out of favor in the West because it has been shown to increase muscle injury.⁸ While it's true that muscle stretching against a contracted cold muscle may precipitate injury, bouncing is safe when used in the neutral (non-extreme) range of joint movement. This kind of bouncing is done in the Universal Healing Tao practices by shaking a leg or an arm while standing. Bouncing is also a part of the Tao Yin exercise of the Turtle, when the practitioner sits with the soles of the feet facing each other, and increases abduction of the thighs by bouncing them off the ground. It is also used in the Hummingbird posture (see fig. 4.3 on page 70). These kinds of warm-ups have the benefits of warming the tissues and opening channels without increasing the risk of muscle injury.

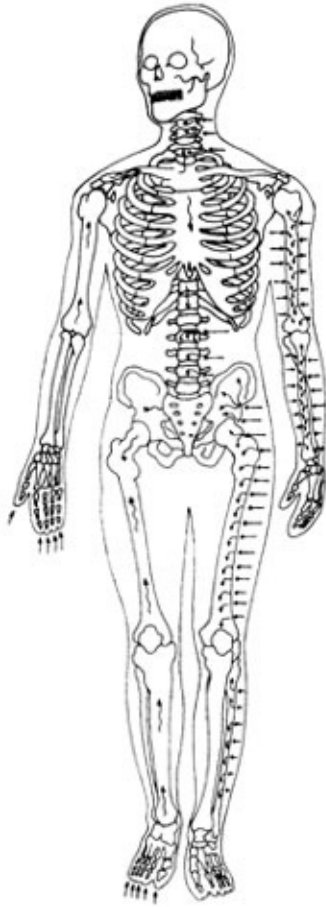


Fig. 4.2. Relaxing the muscles by breathing into the bones



Fig. 4.3. Bouncing in the Hummingbird posture

Stretches are focused on certain body areas that are notorious for being stiff and blocked. Chang refers to “hollows and projections,” which is another way of

saying areas of chi blockage. The classic problem areas are the mid-lumbar spine (Door of Life/Ming Men), the pelvic ligaments (kua), the peri-scapular region, and the cervical spine (fig. 4.4). These areas hold tension and need to be opened to obtain the Iron Shirt posture and execute Fa Jin.

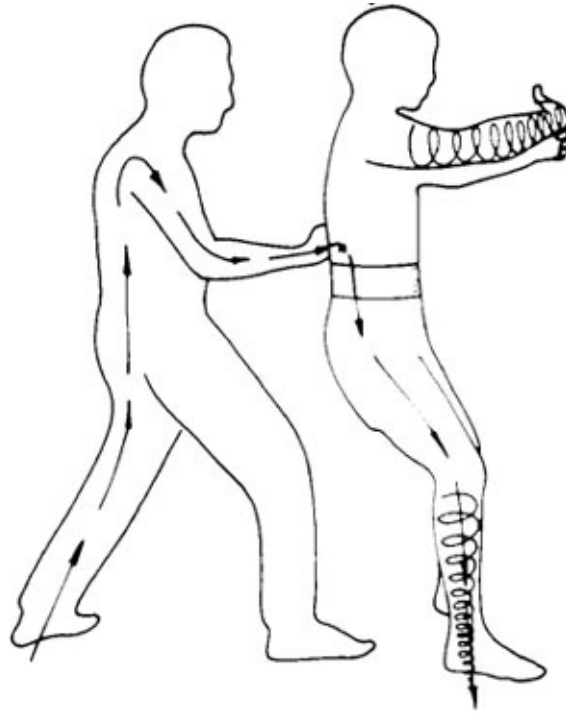


Fig. 4.4. Blocked chi in the lumbar area will interfere with the flow of jin from and into the earth. Bad posture can be corrected by proper adjustment to correct problem areas.

JOINT ROTATIONS

Joint rotations are used extensively in both Western and Eastern sports. From a Western perspective they warm the soft tissues around the joint, increase the temperature of synovial fluid (and thereby its lubricative characteristics), and activate proprioceptors. Certainly as the body ages—and the threshold for injury becomes lower—the warming up of joints prior to exercise becomes crucial.

From a Taoist perspective, joint rotations activate all the meridians that pass over the joint. In the Universal Healing Tao system we teach that by placing the mind in the joints when warming up, we increase regeneration of cartilage through the glucosamine/glycosaminoglycan pathway. There is no hard evidence for this, but there is little doubt that placing awareness in the joints assists with coordination, prevention of injury, and the achievement of higher mystical states.

PERCUSSION

Percussion is not a common warm-up technique in Western sporting exercise, though it is used as therapeutic technique in physical therapy and massage. In

physiotherapy, drainage of pulmonary secretions is promoted through various postures and percussion of the chest and back. In massage, it is known as “tapotement” and is used to warm and stimulate soft tissues as well as bones. Percussion is used in Eastern massage techniques that include chopping, pummeling, and hitting with sticks or wires (see fig. 4.5 on page 72).¹⁷ It is a useful way to warm up tissues, promote chi flow, and develop body awareness. It is likely that heavier percussion practices—such as hitting with heavy-gauged wire—cause minor tissue damage and even occasional cell death. This may, in fact, have powerful benefits. The theory is that the injury causes weak—and even potentially cancerous—cells to die. This creates cell turnover, so that the body can generate healthier new cells. In this scenario, keeping all cells alive, including sick ones, may actually be a retardant to ongoing health and longevity.



Fig. 4.5. Wire hitting technique

WARM-UPS AS TRANSITION

As discussed above, Chang SanFeng wanted the body to be lively with open channels rather than cold and blocked. Therefore, a warm-up is oriented to the transition from one state to the other. In the warm-up process, all the hollows and projections, i.e., blocked channels, are removed. The waist—which includes the tan tien, Central Thrusting Channel, and the Governing Channel—becomes open and loose. All parts of body and mind become connected rather than fragmented. All parts become one chi.

Warm-up exercises are usually classified according to the anatomical region they focus on. However, the theme for each exercise—regardless of the specific anatomy it addresses—is that the monkey mind is quieted. As the three minds integrate, they begin to aid the flow of chi, so that stagnant and sick chi are gently removed from the body (fig. 4.6). As the chi flows into stagnant areas, the body changes its shape. The “hollows and projections” disappear and gradually the Iron Shirt posture is achieved. Opening the heart invites the spirit. Opening the upper mind or upper tan tien connects the practitioner to the heavenly chi. Opening the lower tan tien and particularly the sacrum connects the practitioner to the earth force.



Fig. 4.6. Three tan tiens connecting spirals to the heavenly force

THE BENEFITS OF WARMING UP

AREA OF BODY	EVERYDAY STATE	WARMED-UP STATE
MIND—upper tan tien	Rooted in thought, in the “monkey mind”	Rooted in the body and connected to the heavens
HEART—middle tan tien	Often closed	Open, spirit awakened. Warmth from the heart radiates through the body.
WAIST—lower tan tien	Closed and tight	Open: lumbar open, sacrum tucked in, connected to the earth. Tan tien awakened, with Belt Channel, Central Thrusting Channel, and Governing and Conception Channels open. Lively with increased blood flow
BODY	Low blood flow to joints and muscles. Synovial fluid sticky. Fasciae are crinkled. Organ energies stagnant.	to joints and muscles, synovial fluid warmed and lubricating while fasciae are comfortably stretched open. Organ energies balanced.
CHI and acupuncture channels	Often stagnant with “hollows and projections.”	Microcosmic Orbit, tan tien, and Belt Channel are all open.

As a general principle of the Taoist approach, that which is smooth, without force, and bordering on the spontaneous is closest to the correct technique. If an injured part is forced to become pain free, then any improvements are likely to be temporary, and pain and stiffness will recur after the training session. The wise, more experienced Taoist practitioner uses more yin techniques for warm-ups and practice. More yin means more relaxation, better focus, less effort, and yet paradoxically more discharge power.

Finally, it is important to remember that the older one gets, the lower the threshold for injury. Practitioners who are elderly, and those who have preexisting injuries need to tailor their warm-ups according to their injuries and vulnerabilities.

WARM-UP EXERCISES

Below are some general warm-up exercises that are important preparation for any Tai Chi practice, including Fa Jin.



Waist Loosening

This exercise involves waist rotations around the Central Thrusting Channel. It also helps loosen the lumbar vertebrae (the Governor Channel) by warming up the synovial fluid in the small facet joints that connect each vertebra and the soft

tissues, including the discs.

1. Stand with the feet parallel, slightly wider than shoulder width apart. Allow the arms to dangle loosely at your sides (fig. 4.7).
2. Begin to turn the hips from side to side. Let the arms swing naturally and easily with the momentum of the hips turning. Explore your natural and comfortable range of hip motion. Don't go to extremes; just stay within your free and easy comfort zone.
3. After turning just the hips ten or twelve times, allow the lumbar vertebrae to relax and loosen and to gently twist with the hips. You should still begin the movement from the hips, but now allow the lumbar vertebrae to respond as well.
4. Next allow the middle spine, upper back, and neck to twist gently with the movement.
5. Keep your shoulders loose and let your arms swing with the movement. Don't use effort to move the arms; let them be totally limp and just let the body swing them. At the same time, be aware of the gentle twisting of your knee and ankle joints as you twist the whole body. Do this at least 36 times to each side.

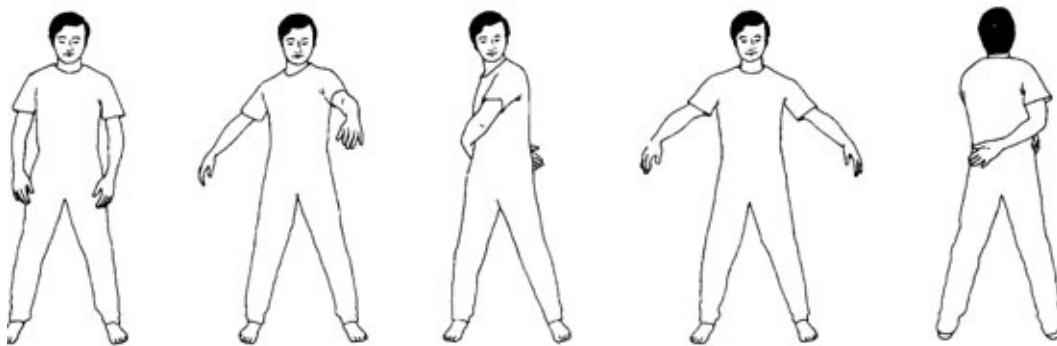


Fig. 4.7. Loosening the waist



Opening the Door of Life

This is a stretching exercise that works the pelvic floor muscles and the anterior abdominals to enable the opening of the Governor Channel.

1. Begin in the same stance as for Waist Loosening. This time twist to the left, again initiating the movement from the hips. Let your right arm swing across the front of your torso, raising it up to head height with the palm

facing away from you. At the same time, let your left arm swing around to the back, and place the back of your left hand over the Door of Life—the area on the spine opposite the navel (fig. 4.8).

2. When you reach your full extension, relax, and then extend again by loosening your low back. Feel the gentle stretch and increased extension coming all the way from the Door of Life, not from the shoulders. Relax and extend in this way 3 times.
3. Twist to the right and repeat the steps as above on the right side. Repeat for a total of 9 times on each side.



Fig. 4.8. Opening the Door of Life



Windmill Exercise: Opening the Spinal Joints

This exercise is a mixture of complex stretches and rotations. It stretches open the fasciae of the whole body, including the arms, torso, and legs.

Practice each phase of the exercise slowly and mindfully.



Outer Front Extension

1. Begin in the same stance as for Waist Loosening. Bring your hands to the midline of your body and hook the thumbs together (fig. 4.9).
2. Keeping your hands close to the torso, inhale and raise your arms until they are extended straight up over your head, the fingers pointing up. Gently stretch upward in this position, extending your spine slightly backward. You can even say “Ah-h-h-h-h,” as you would when you stretch first thing in the morning.
3. Begin to exhale slowly and bend forward, reaching as far out in front as you can, keeping your head between your arms (fig. 4.10). Try to feel the joints of the spine releasing one by one in a wavelike motion. Bend first from the lumbar vertebrae, then from the thoracic vertebrae, and finally from the

cervical vertebrae. At this point your spine is released all the way toward the floor.

4. Slowly straighten back up, again feeling each joint of the spine, from the sacrum and lumbar area through the thorax, neck, and the base of the skull. Keep your arms hanging heavily and let your head be the last part of your body to come to vertical. Now you are back in the stretching position.
5. Repeat the above steps 3 to 5 times. Finish with your arms overhead, as at the end of step 2.



Fig. 4.9. Stretching the arms up

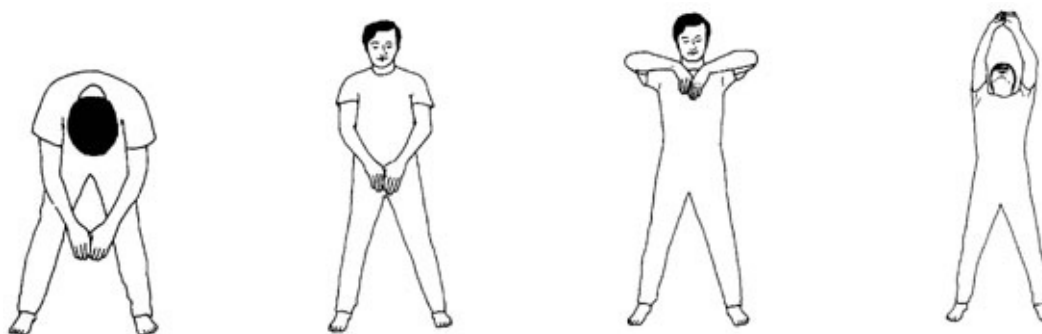


Fig. 4.10. Outer front extension of the Windmill exercise

Inner Front Extension

1. Now do the same movements in reverse. Point your fingertips down toward the floor and slowly lower your arms, keeping the hands close to the torso. When your arms are completely lowered, begin to bend forward; release the head, the cervical vertebrae, the thoracic vertebrae, and the lumbar vertebrae until you are bent all the way forward, as at the end of step 3 of the Outer Front Extension. Feel each joint opening.
2. Keeping your head between your arms, begin to straighten up. Feel each joint of the spine, from the sacrum and lumbar area through the thorax,

neck, and the base of the skull. This time let your arms extend out in front as you slowly stand erect. When you come to vertical, your arms will be straight against your head.

3. Gently stretch upward in this position, extending your spine slightly back. Say “Ah-h-h-h-h,” as you would when you stretch first thing in the morning.
4. Repeat the above steps 3 to 5 times.

Left Sidebend

1. Begin standing erect, with your feet shoulder width apart. With your head between your arms in the overhead position, lean to the left. You should feel a gentle stretch on the right side of your waist.
2. Continue stretching to the side until you’ve reached your limit, then gently rotate toward center as you stretch all the way down to the floor.
3. From the center, circle back up on the right side until you are again standing straight with your arms overhead.
4. Repeat 3 to 5 times, bending left to center and returning on the right.

Right Sidebend and Conclusion

1. Repeat the same movements as in the Left Sidebend, but this time begin bending to the right side and return on the left side (fig. 4.11).
2. Repeat 3 to 5 times.
3. To finish, unhook your thumbs and let your arms slowly float back down to the sides.

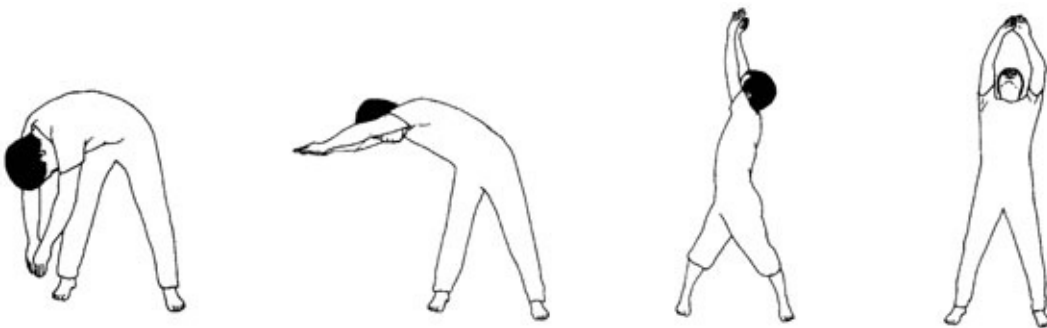


Fig. 4.11. Right side-bending movements



Tendon Twisting

This specific warm-up exercise might also be classified as a technical exercise. It is the foundation exercise for tendon wrapping, and exemplifies the principle of “in the curve seek the straight.” It showcases many basic practices, including the passage of chi/jin up the spine.

The multiple stages of this exercise stretch and twist the tendons of the wrists, elbows, and shoulders to enhance flexibility and power. The movements should feel as though you are turning a screw into a wall.



Small Tendon Twist

1. Begin standing erect, feet shoulder width apart. Reach forward with both arms, palms up. Using a circular screwing motion, twist both thumbs so they face downward (see fig 4.12 on page 80). Then reverse directions and circle the hands forward, returning to the starting position. While doing this, the wrists and elbows should be fully torqued to the point where, if you listen carefully, you can actually hear the stretching of the tendons that are being affected. The shoulders should be relaxed and rounded.
2. Repeat 3 to 9 times.
3. Repeat this movement with both arms above the head, with arms at the sides, and with both arms in front of the body but down at the groin.
4. Repeat 3 to 9 times in each position.
5. Now repeat in all positions, but reverse the direction of the tendon twist.

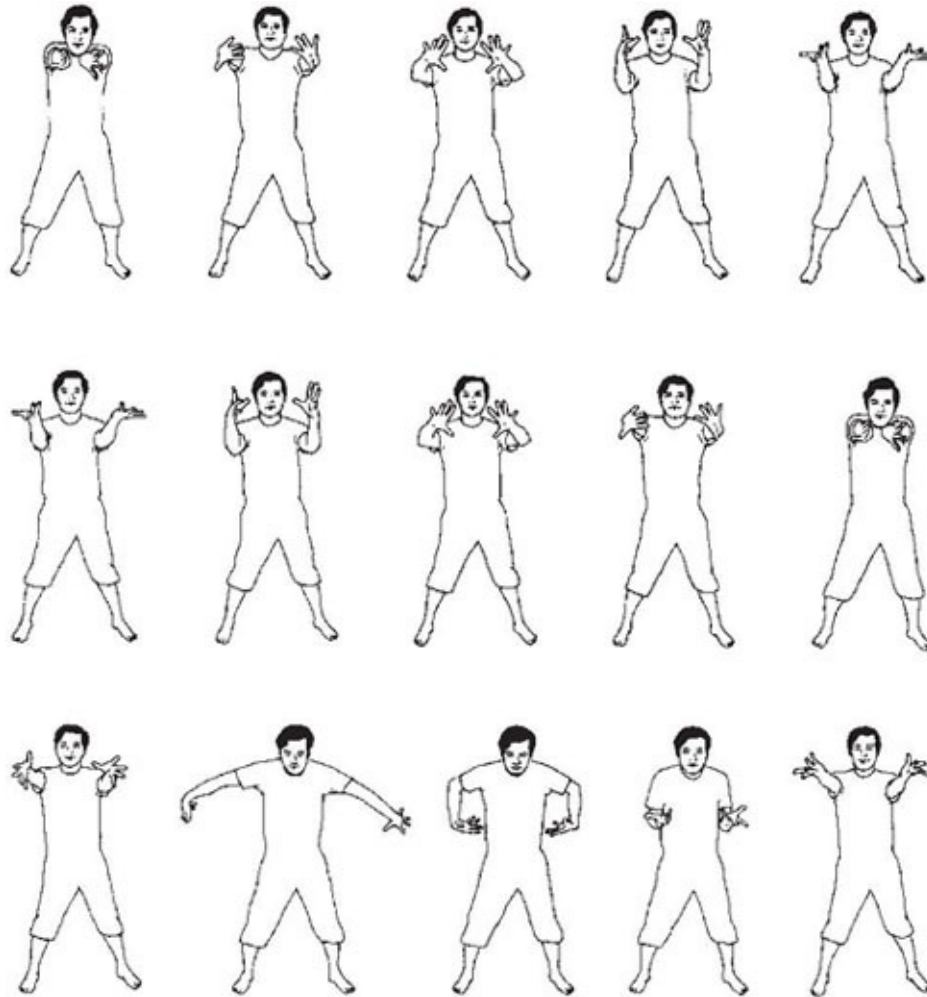


Fig. 4.12. Tendon twisting, front and sides

Large Tendon Twist

1. This exercise is comprised of the same movements as the Small Tendon Twist but it is performed in large circles. This movement should only be practiced with the arms in front of the body.
2. Do 3 to 9 rounds of the Large Tendon Twist.
3. Repeat the movements, reversing the direction of the tendon twist and joint opening. Practice 3 to 9 rounds in this direction.

Head Rotations and Neck-Joint Opening

This exercise, when done slowly and with focused concentration, warms up the soft tissues and also opens the channels. The secret to opening the channels is to move slowly, opening each vertebra one at a time. Allowing the chi to move

your head further enhances this opening. Always remain soft and relaxed (*fang sung*). Smile and allow soft chi to dissolve blockages. These principles apply to all the rotation exercises.

1. Stand erect with your hands on your hips. Let your head relax forward. Feel the weight of your head providing a gentle stretch to the back of the neck. Allow the weight of your head to provide all the loosening and stretching force; this helps you relax and release and avoids the risk of injury from overstraining.
2. Gently roll your head to the right and feel the stretch on the left side of your neck (fig. 4.13).
3. Feeling the weight of your head, gently roll it to the back. Feel the stretch on the front of your neck.
4. Gently roll your head to the left, feeling the stretch on the right side of your neck.
5. Repeat the above steps 2 more times, then repeat the sequence 3 times in the opposite direction.



Fig. 4.13. Head rotations



Shoulder Joint Rotations

This exercise increases your scapular power. Many people, especially if they have a good strong back, develop knots of tension in the shoulders. In this exercise, the scapulae are loosened and rounded to develop the type of scapular power used by tigers and other big cats.

1. Begin by standing with your feet parallel and slightly wider than shoulder width apart. Relax the entire body, paying special attention to relaxing your shoulders, scapulae, and back. Keep your palms loosely on the front of your thighs throughout this exercise.
2. Lift the shoulders straight up.

3. Extend the shoulders forward (fig. 4.14).
4. Lower the shoulders downward.
5. Draw the shoulders back.
6. Repeat the above steps 8 eight more times.
7. Now reverse direction: raise the shoulders, draw them back, lower them, and bring them forward.
8. Repeat 9 times.

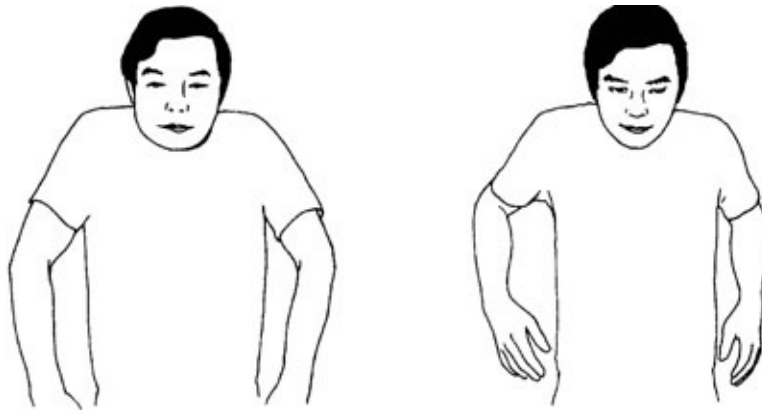


Fig. 4.14. Shoulder rotations



Hip Rotations

As you perform the hip rotations, keep your head positioned over your feet—don't jut your jaw and head forward or let your head fall behind the centerline of the body. Move slowly and easily, breathing deeply and continuously.

1. Stand with your feet parallel and slightly wider than shoulder-width apart. Place your hands on your waist (fig. 4.15).
2. Bring your hips forward.
3. Move your hips in a big circle toward the right.
4. Now move your hips in a circle toward the back.
5. Circle your hips toward the left.
6. Repeat the above steps 8 more times.
7. Reverse direction and repeat 9 times.

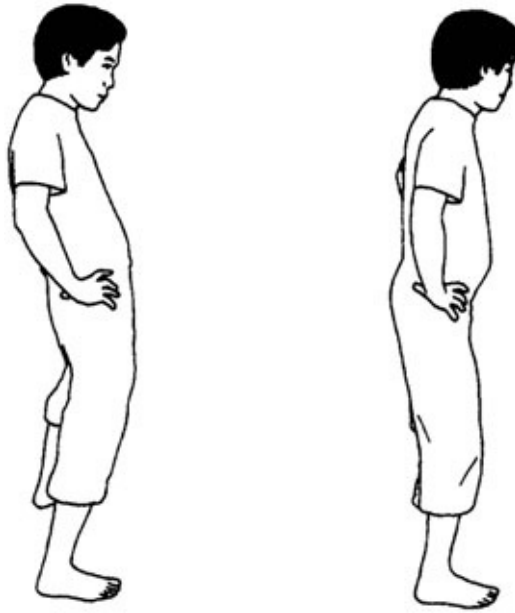


Fig. 4.15. Hip rotations



Knee Rotations

1. Stand erect with your feet together. Bend your knees and place your palms lightly on the kneecaps (fig. 4.16).
2. Slowly and gently rotate your knees to the left.
3. Rotate your knees to the back. The muscles behind the knee will lengthen.
4. Rotate your knees to the right.
5. Repeat the above steps 8 more times.
6. Now reverse direction and repeat 9 times.



Fig. 4.16. Knee rotations



Ankle/Knee/Hip Rotations and Joint Opening

Keeping the joints open is an important part of allowing the energy to be properly stored and available to flow into the bones. This exercise helps open the joints and flex the tendons so you do not overstress them during Tai Chi practice.

1. Stand erect with your hands on your hips, feet together. Raise your right leg and rotate the right ankle clockwise 9 to 36 times (fig. 4.17).
2. Now rotate the ankle counterclockwise the same number of times.
3. Keeping your leg raised, rotate the foreleg from the knee in a clockwise circular motion 9 to 36 times.
4. Now rotate the foreleg the same number of times counterclockwise.
5. Finally, rotate the entire leg from the hip joint in a clockwise circular motion 9 to 36 times.
6. Rotate the leg the same number of times counterclockwise.
7. Repeat the sequence with the left leg raised.



Fig. 4.17. Ankle rotations



Opening the Groin (Kua)

Opening the kua exercises the psoas muscles. As you do this exercise, pay close attention to deeply relaxing and lengthening the lower back and psoas muscles.

1. Stand with the feet parallel and slightly wider than shoulder-width apart. Place one hand on your sacrum and the other on your pubic bone (fig. 4.18).
2. Rock your sacrum forward and back, alternately tucking your tailbone and pushing it backward like a duck's tail, to open the groin area.

3. Repeat 9 to 36 times.

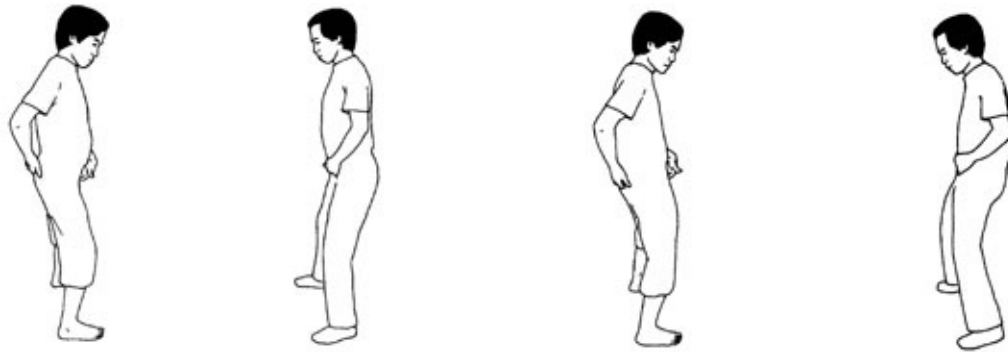


Fig. 4.18. Moving the sacrum to open the kua



Tan Tien Hitting

While this exercise includes waist rotation, it also employs the principles of percussion discussed earlier in this chapter. Percussion warms the tissues and removes stagnant chi from the channels. It helps awaken the tan tien.

Since the lower tan tien is the major storage center for the chi of the body, this area should be activated prior to Tai Chi practice.

1. Stand with your feet parallel and slightly wider than shoulder-width apart. Totally relax your arms and gracefully swing them in free-fall from left to right. As you swing to the left, your right hand comes in front of your body, with the palm hitting your navel area at the exact same time that the back of your left hand hits the Door of Life, opposite the navel (fig. 4.19).
2. As you swing to the right, your left hand comes in front of your body, the palm hitting your navel area at the exact same time that the back of your right hand hits the Door of Life.
3. Repeat 36 times to each side.



Fig. 4.19. Tan tien hitting



Bouncing and Shaking the Joints

Bouncing the body can be likened to a ride on the subway. For those of you who commute this way, this exercise can be practiced to and from work as well.

As mentioned above, bouncing and shaking can be seen as an alternative way to warm up the tissues. Remember, however, to bounce and shake only in neutral joint positions, as bouncing and shaking can damage tissues that are tight or contracted.

1. Stand with your feet parallel and slightly wider than shoulder width apart. Relax your body and concentrate on opening the joints.
2. Now bounce without any tension. Let the vibration in your heels work its way up through your entire skeletal system, from legs to spine to neck to skull (fig. 4.20). Let your shoulders and arms vibrate as they hang loosely by the sides of your body. To enhance the vibration you can hum a vowel, which will make the voice tremble as well.
3. Rest and feel chi entering the joints.



Fig. 4.20. Shaking the joints



Empty Force Breath

Empty Force Breath is basically the ability to suck in a chosen part of the body. This involves using the core muscles and imitating an inward breath but doing it with a closed glottis. This desire for breath is then transferred with focus of the mind to whatever part of the body the adept chooses. It is an important skill to obtain not only for Fa Jin, but also for high-level meditation.

In Fa Jin, the empty force is used during the yin stages of its execution. It helps load the bow and open the vertebral column (*Dai Mai*).

1. Stand in a comfortable Horse Stance position, with the legs just shoulder width apart. Exhale all the breath out forcefully and poke out your tongue.
2. Close the glottis, open the kua (coccyx tucked in and front part of pelvis widened), and transfer the desire to breathe to the abdominal musculature.
3. Focus the mind on a ball of chi in the pelvis and suck it up into your chest (fig. 4.21).
4. Next, roll the chi ball in the center of the abdomen, then relax and allow the abdominal wall to relax and protrude out.
5. Repeat steps 1–4, but roll the chi ball at your solar plexus (fig. 4.22).
6. Repeat steps 1–4, this time rolling the chi ball at the lower tan tien.
7. Continue repeating steps 1–4, rolling the chi ball on the right side and the left side of your abdomen.
8. Relax after each cycle and allow the abdominal wall to protrude out.

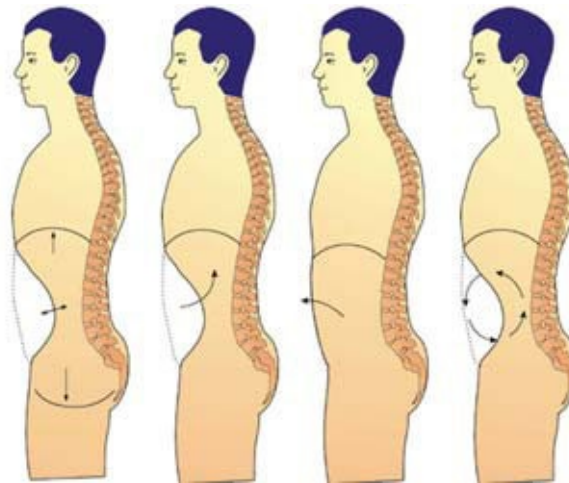


Fig. 4.21. Empty Force Breath

This suction force can be called yin breathing; it is the opposite of the packing breath, which is called yang breathing. In the packing breath, air is sipped and packed into the body at the chosen point. It can be used to move the chi to areas that are stagnant. The empty force breath can likewise be used to move chi into blocked areas. It can also be used in sexual practices like the upward orgasmic draw, and may even happen spontaneously during high-level meditations like the Fusion practices and Kan and Li practice.

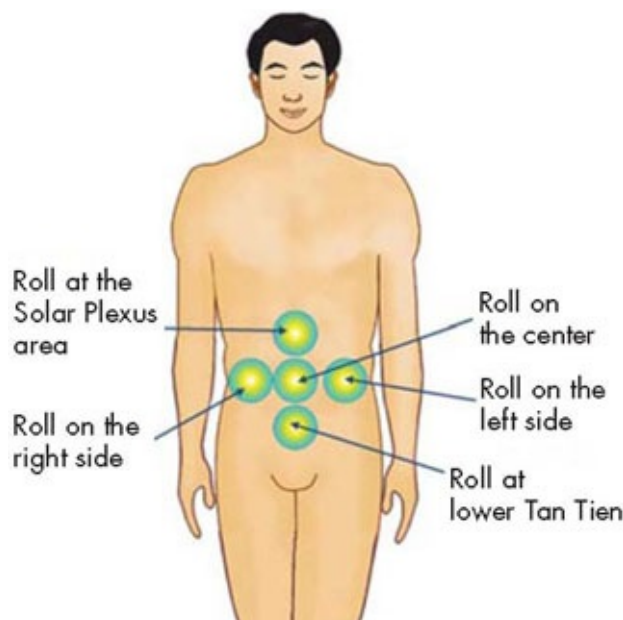


Fig. 4.22. Additional areas to work on with the Empty Force Breath



Energy-Connection Exercises

These exercises strengthen the realm of chi and spirit. They help to connect the mind and the tan tiens with the forces outside oneself. Remember that Fa Jin relies on the integration of the energies of heaven, spirit, the three tan tiens, the body, and the chi.



Washing the Body with Heaven and Earth Energies

1. Stand in the Embracing the Tree position: the feet are a little more than shoulder width apart, and the nine points of the feet are pressing firmly against the ground. The knees are bent and torqued slightly outward, with a corresponding torque in the ankles and hips. This acts to screw the body into the ground and to initiate the earth connection. Straighten the spine by slightly tucking the sacrum under, which increases the connection to the earth, and by tucking in the chin to connect with heavenly energy. Round the scapulae, sink the chest, and hold your head erect. Position the arms as if they were encircling a tree, keeping the elbows sunk.
2. Reach down and forward, keeping the palms cupped, and slowly scoop the earth energy up through your body. Use your imagination at first, until you become sensitized to the feeling of the rising earth energy. Since you are washing your body with this energy, simultaneously feel a cool blue water-like healing sensation rising through your body at the level of your hands as

you raise them up, lifting them until they are fully extended above your head.

3. Turn your palms up and connect with the heavenly energy.
4. Slowly arc your arms downward to the sides, palms out. Feel heavenly energy descend through your body at the level of your hands. The heavenly energy can feel like an expansive hot white fire that washes down through the body until it reaches the ground, at which point your hands will be reaching toward the ground.
5. Repeat this exercise 9 to 36 times, until you feel fully suffused with both earth energy and heavenly energy.

Cosmic Energy Mid-Eyebrow Connection

This exercise should only be performed at night, or at sunrise or sunset, when the light of the sun is softer and will not damage your eyes. Close and rest your eyes if ever the light from the sun or the moon feels too intense.

1. Begin in the Embracing the Tree position as described in step 1 above, but this time face the sun or the moon.
2. Bring your arms up to just above the level of the mid-eyebrow, and make a triangle between the index fingers and thumbs of both hands, with either the sun or the moon centered within that triangle.
3. Hold this position and draw the sun (yang) or moon (yin) energy in through the mid-eyebrow.
4. Gather some saliva in your mouth and let the energy of the sun or moon that you've drawn in mix with saliva to collect a ball of chi energy in the mouth. This will increase saliva production and more will gather in the mouth.
5. Extend your neck slightly. Swallow the saliva with a strong gulp and mentally direct it to your navel. Feel your navel warm with the arrival of this new energy.
6. Repeat the above steps 9 to 36 times.
7. Close the exercise by slowly lowering your arms to the navel, placing the left hand over the right, and collecting energy by spiraling at the navel.

Navel/Palm Connection

1. Stand tall with your feet slightly wider than shoulder width apart. Position

both palms approximately 2 inches out from the navel, palms facing inward.

2. Slowly inhale, allowing the abdomen to expand completely. As this is happening, lightly tug a “string” of energy away from the navel, using the centers of the palms.
3. Now slowly exhale and feed the energy string back in to the navel.
4. Repeat this sequence 9 times, and then collect energy at the navel.

Sink Back and Push Tree

1. Find a tree that beckons you with its positive energy. Selecting the proper tree is vital, since there are trees with negative energy.
2. Facing the tree with your right leg forward, sink into the Tai Chi sink-back position. Your fingers should be facing the tree.
3. As you proceed forward into the push, feel a connection as the energy from your fingertips shoots out and connects with the positive energy of the tree. Project out from your body any sick or negative emotions. Let those energies be taken in by the tree, to be healed and recycled through the earth.
4. Sink back and draw in the newly processed positive energy.
5. Repeat this yin and yang action 9, 18, or 36 times. This exercise is particularly effective for energy sensitization.

TECHNICAL EXERCISES

Technical exercises have the primary purpose of supporting a specific skill that is used in a given martial art. From a physiological perspective, technicals create specific neuromuscular patterns that form the groundwork for discharge power. Secondarily, technical exercises function like warm-ups, opening channels and meridians that are often closed in the everyday state.

This section explores four kinds of technical exercises. First are the silk-reeling exercises, which are yin exercises that refine the execution of Fa Jin—especially the first four stages. The second type are exercises that utilize the eight gates. The third type is a summary and focused appreciation of Tan Tien Chi Kung, and how it promotes discharge power. The fourth section explores yang technical exercises that focus on real-time speed release of jin.

Yin Technicals

Silk-reeling technicals are classified as a yin training exercise for the release of

discharge power. They are yin because they are done in slow motion and because they cultivate softness, fullness, and absorption. However, being yin does not mean they are weak. We hope we have made it clear that by cultivating yin, the adept simultaneously empowers the release or yang phase. Silk reeling (*chan su jin*) is taught in the Chen tradition,⁹ but it is certainly not unique to the Chen style. In fact, technicals have been an important aspect of Tai Chi Chuan training in the Yang, Wu, Li, and Sun styles.¹⁰ For example, Li I-Yu tells us to “move the chi like coiling silk.”¹¹

Yin technicals train all phases of the release of Fa Jin.¹² They cultivate the four yin stages described in chapter 3: sticking/following the chi, the yin phase of Iron Shirt, neutralizing, and rotation around the central axis. They also cultivate the yang aspect of release, which comprises stages five to eight as described in chapter 3. These stages include drawing power from earth, expansion of the tan tien, expansion of whole body, and final release. However, because they are yin exercises they are done in a soft and gentle way. Like general warm-ups, these yin technicals also serve the purpose of opening the acupuncture meridians and the three tan tiens.

Yin technicals are an alternative to prolonged sitting or standing in Iron Shirt postures. They help open the Microcosmic Orbit, the twelve main acupuncture channels, and the tan tiens. During yin stages of Fa Jin practice, the body and mind are in an absorptive state that collects chi from the heavens (including from the sun, moon, planets, and stars) and from the earth (the five elements of the earthly plane). The three tan tiens are activated to store jin/chi that is absorbed. Stagnation and blockages are cleared with the gentle movement of chi and jin through the aforementioned channels. In some respects, the yin technicals have significant overlap with soft Chi Kung exercises that are taught within the Universal Healing Tao system. They follow all the principles of the soft movements of Tai Chi Chuan.

To help understand the principles of yin technicals, we will analyze them in terms of the areas of the body they focus on.

Hands

During yin technicals, the hands—like the rest of the body—trace a circle. They do this with two purposes in mind: first of all they retain their martial purpose and therefore the ability to parry, and secondly they follow the natural connection and power with the wrist, elbow, and shoulder.

According to Li I-Yu: “Relax the fingertips and spread the fingertips. There is a slight feeling of swelling in the fingertips.”¹³ Because the fingers are constantly

absorbing chi and also serve as a conduit for releasing prickly stagnant chi, they must be relaxed. Each finger retains a connection to one or more major acupuncture channels, and therefore must remain open. This openness brings a sensation of fullness or swelling, which is different than tension. Tension is synonymous with blockage and should be avoided. When each finger is open and spread, the chi has the power to move the entire limb.

Waist and Tan Tien

The waist (*yao*) is a center of much activity during the delivery of Fa Jin. Within the waist is the Central Thrusting Channel, which allows effortless rotation while maintaining rooting within the Iron Shirt structure. As Yang Pan-Hou says:

The two arms are like a balance that swing left and right. The waist is the stem of the balance. . . . The plumb line suspending the head and the base of the balance located in the waist connects the Wei-Lu point in the coccyx and the Hsin-Men point at the crown of the head.¹⁴

The balance point in the waist allows effortless rotation while the arms and torso release jin. The Belt Channel (*Dai Mai*), which follows the outer circumference of the waist, is also active and full during Fa Jin.

The focus of mind and activity within the waist also varies throughout Fa Jin practice. In stages 1 to 3, the focus is on the back or the Ming Men. With rotation of the waist in stage 4 there is also some movement forward, and a momentary focus on the front aspect of the tan tien. The focus then moves back to the Ming Men again before the tan tien expands in stage 6.

During the yin phase, neutralization of yang chi/jin from the opponent occurs via the Conception Channel (*Ren Mai*), which must pass through the waist into the earth. Similarly, the primary release of jin in the yang stage of Fa Jin is initiated by the back part of the tan tien and released via the Governor Channel (*Du Mai*/vertebral column) (fig. 4.23).

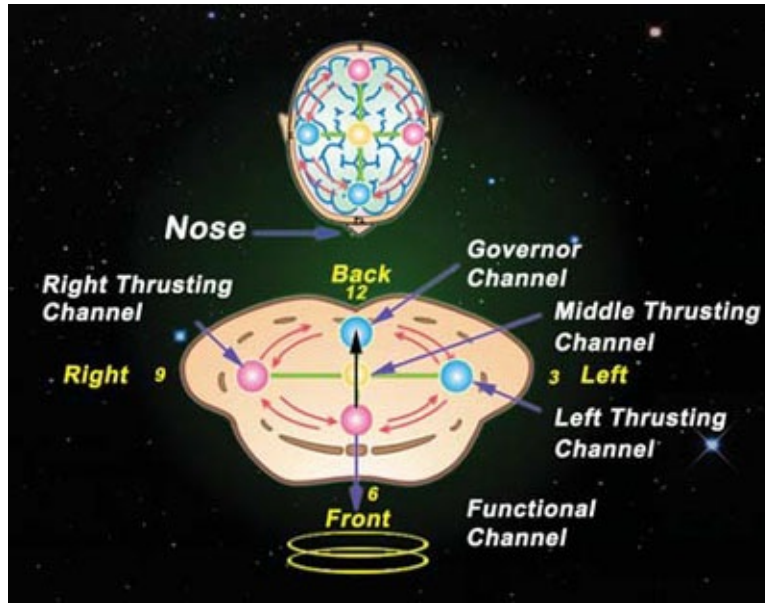


Fig. 4.23. Transverse section of waist and Thrusting Channels

Yang Pan-Hou describes it this way:

With one wave of the signal flag
 The wheels of the two Ming Men begin to turn.
 When orders are issued by the mind,
 the chi goes into action like army banners.¹⁵

In other words, when the integrated mind says “Fire,” the back tan tien shakes itself around the Central Thrusting Channel. Finally the jin is released via the Governor Channel. As Li I-Yu reminds us, “Energy issues from the spine.”¹⁶

The whole body engages in the execution of discharge power. From the little toe to the little finger, all parts engage in letting go and opening to forces beyond the self. This concept is antithetical to the Western analysis of movement, which naively attributes movement during complex actions to individual muscle groups. While Tai Chi Chuan practitioners would agree that certain muscle groups can carry a large percentage of the load, thoughtful complex motion is always understood to be a function of the whole body and mind.

Yi/Mind

The Yi (integrated mind) creates a template for the chi, which in turn moves the muscles and tendons. Yang Chen-Fu says, “If you do not use Li but use Yi, when the Yi arrives, the chi arrives immediately.”¹⁷ This implies that with successful coordination of complex moves, the monkey mind that believes pure muscular power is the way must let go and rescind authority to something larger. One

successful technique, which Chinese martial artists have used for centuries, is to ascribe animals to some of the martial forms.

Many of these nominal allocations pertain to the celebration of earthly or heavenly existence. For example, we have the Bull exercise in Tan Tien Chi Kung, which is also known as Moving the Sampan Oars. Some names highlight the poetic beauty of the Taoist path, like the Jade Rabbit Pounding the Drug of Immortality. The integrated mind works better with simple pictures or impersonations. This is because the body/mind connection in its pure state works more like a child's mind. The adept playfully lets go and immerses the whole body and its movement into a template. This is not done by the adult intellectual mind (monkey mind), which would attempt to direct a complex form overtly, but through the indirect play of the integrated whole mind.

The Movement of Mind Focus During Yin Technicals

Prior authors have made many attempts to trace the body's center as it executes Fa Jin.¹⁹ According to Universal Healing Tao teachings, the center begins forward and returns in a straight line back to a rear position. This comprises stages 1, 2 and 3. In stage 4 there is a sideways rotational movement and the center moves toward the front leg. The waist then returns to the original position. This rotation and return is like the first part of the flicking of a towel or the cracking of a whip. Once returned, the body can then release the jin. In releasing jin the center moves from the back to the front, and the focus now moves up the body to the extremities and into the opponent.

The following diagram illustrates the stages of Fa Jin release as marked by movement of the center (fig. 4.24). Not all technicals trace this course, but most do. Those that don't tend to minimize stage 4.

The exercises that follow are basic technicals that highlight particular aspects of Fa Jin practice.

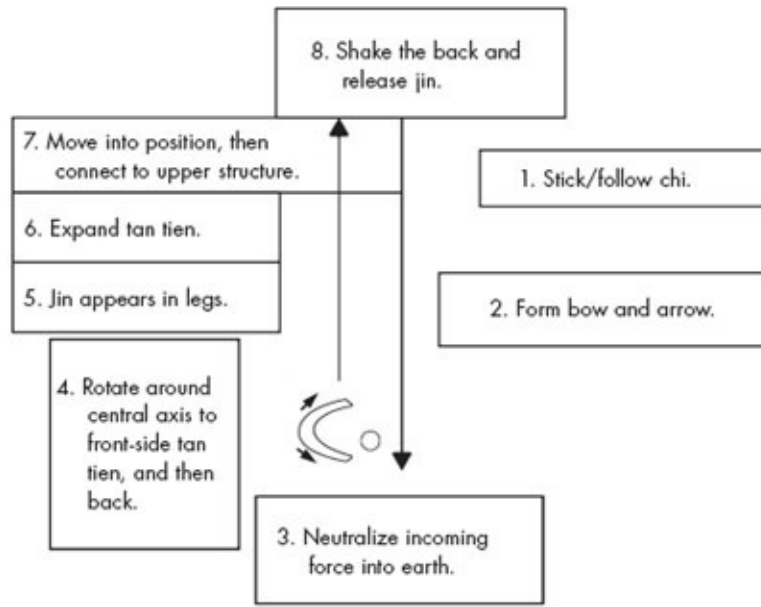


Fig. 4.24. Eight stages of Fa Jin



Silk Reeling



Turning the Wheel

This is a classic Universal Healing Tao practice whose emphasis is twofold. One is to open all the points of the Microcosmic Orbit. The second is to cultivate the appropriate coordination of the whole body—from the feet to the fingertips—in simple circular movements. Jin is released via the vertebral column. The hands are moved by the chi. The novice begins by learning to turn from the waist and release power via the spine. Later, chi is allowed to move parts and then all of the entire structure. Any monkey mind intention is gradually removed. The following illustration shows the external moves and the movement of focus (or the chi ball) within the Microcosmic Orbit (fig. 4.25).

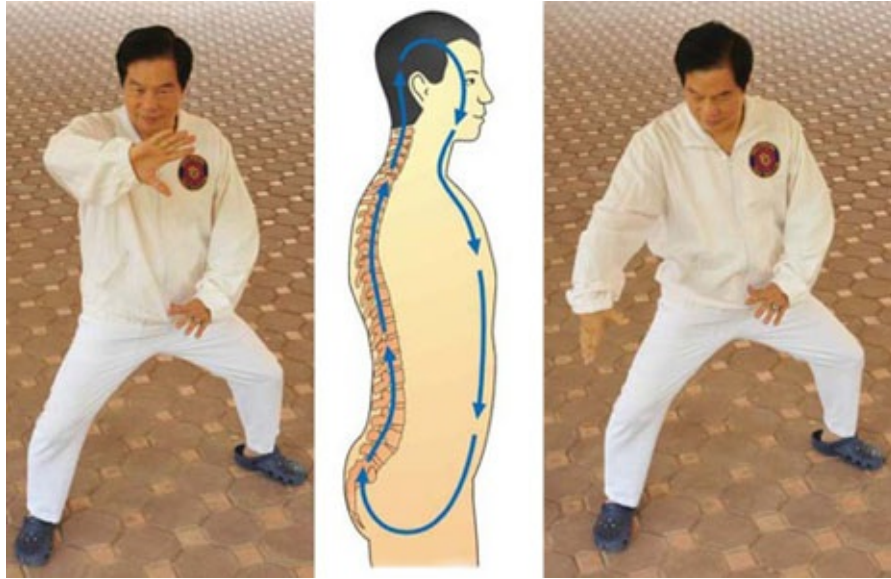


Fig. 4.25. Energy moving in Microcosmic Orbit and Turning the Wheel

☀ ***Left and Right Parry Circles***

This silk-reeling exercise is more frequently practiced by Chen practitioners and includes the left and right hands singly and together (fig. 4.26). The jin moves as follows: it retreats, follows the chi, opens the structure and the bow, rotates the waist with a slight forward movement of the tan tien to the front-side tan tien, then releases the spring via the whole structure—from the sacrum, to the lumbar, thoracic, and cervical vertebrae. From the cervical vertebrae, the arms find the “straight via the curve.”¹⁹



Fig. 4.26. Left and Right Parry Circles

☸ **Rowing the Sampan Oars (Bull)**

This yin technical includes arm splitting, which is akin to the moves of the breast and butterfly strokes in swimming (see fig. 4.27 on page 100). In this particular technical, the tan tien is already forward during the backward movement, so no rotation is required prior to the discharge of jin. In the butterfly action, however, the focus returns to the standard pattern.

Besides working to the sides, silk reeling can also be carried out in front of the body. From the Play the Pi Pa (front guard) position, the arms are rolled forward or backward. The legs can be interchanged when tired. Movement of chi and jin is the same as in Turning the Wheel.



Fig. 4.27. Focusing on chi ball of Sampan Oars

☀ ***Jade Rabbit Pounds the Drug of Immortality***

This technical is done in double-weighted Horse Stance only (fig. 4.28). It works to open the Central Thrusting Channel (*Chong Mai*). Like the above yin technicals, it can train all stages of Fa Jin, however, it is unlike the classic eight gates in that weight is not transferred from one leg to another. Again, follow the principle of allowing the chi to move the limbs.



Fig. 4.28. Jade Rabbit Pounds the Drug of Immortality

Technicals for Practicing the Eight Gates

Little is known about Tan Meng-Hsien, yet his writings have gained classic status. Tan offers explicit visualizations for the execution of the eight forces. In these technical exercises, the eight forces are practiced in sequence and with a specific jin in mind. This is starkly different from the practice or demonstration of the discharge form, during which there might not be the luxury of time to explore the complex internal work that is needed to release power from the tan tien. In the technical environment, however, adepts can practice according to their own inner timing rather than an imposed time constraint.

Multiple repetitions in a relaxed atmosphere allow the natural and

spontaneous movement of chi and jin to occur. The eight stages of release are maintained, including four yin and four yang stages. However, in the following technicals taught by Tan Meng-Hsien, varied visualizations are used to create a template for the Yi to work with.²⁰



The Eight Gates with Visualizations



Gate 1: Peng

Begin on the right side. Practice Peng with a movement like a floating boat supported by the water beneath. When the tan tien feels like it is naturally exploding, visualize it as a loaded spring releasing (fig. 4.29). The aim is to follow the release in a relaxed manner.



Gate 2: Lu

Roll back and sink deeper into your structure as per the Push Hands routine, keeping the kidneys full and the spine straight. Become empty and visualize yourself floating in deep outer space (fig. 4.30). In many respects, Lu represents the first half of the Fa Jin sequence. It can be used on its own to topple an opponent who expects resistance and consequently uproots himself when none is offered.



Fig. 4.29. Core spring in the tan tien



Fig. 4.30. Tan tien as empty outer space

☸ **Gate 3: Ji**

In this exercise, imagine the tan tien or the body to be connected to two different forces, symbolized by the left and right arms. These two forces then create a reaction at the zenith of the movement that is like bouncing a coin off a drum (fig. 4.31).



Fig. 4.31. Tan tien as a drum

☸ **Gate 4: An**

In the yang phase, visualize the energy like water in an outgoing tide—a steady force that fills every defect in the opponent's structure without effort (fig. 4.32). At the moment when the tide seems full—when there can be no more resistance and the opponent is on the verge of imbalance—then release your power.



Fig. 4.32. Tan tien as a wave in the sea

☀ Gate 5: Tsai

Visualize yourself and your opponent in a lever position with a defined fulcrum (fig. 4.33). The wrist, elbow, and shoulder can be targets for pressure applied to engage a lock (*chin na*); finish with discharge power to dislocate a joint or fracture a bone. In this situation, the yin phase breaks the opponent's structure by elongation. In the yang phase (stages 5 to 7), the opponent is set up for the lever. Set up a lever like a balance scale so that only "four ounces" are required to break a thousand pounds.



Fig. 4.33. Tsai using the principle of the lever

☀ **Gate 6: Lih**

Next imagine the tan tien like a spiraling vortex or revolving flywheel.²¹ The fastest moving point is distant from the central eye of the vortex (fig. 4.34). Any force that entangles itself on the outside of this vortex is cast off a thousand times faster than it entered.



Fig. 4.34. Vortex and spiraling in the lower tan tien

☀ **Gate 7: Chou**

In this exercise, visualize the elbow's power as coming from the five elements and being absorbed from the six directions (fig. 4.35). This elemental energy reduces to a unity that ultimately explodes via the elbow joint.²²

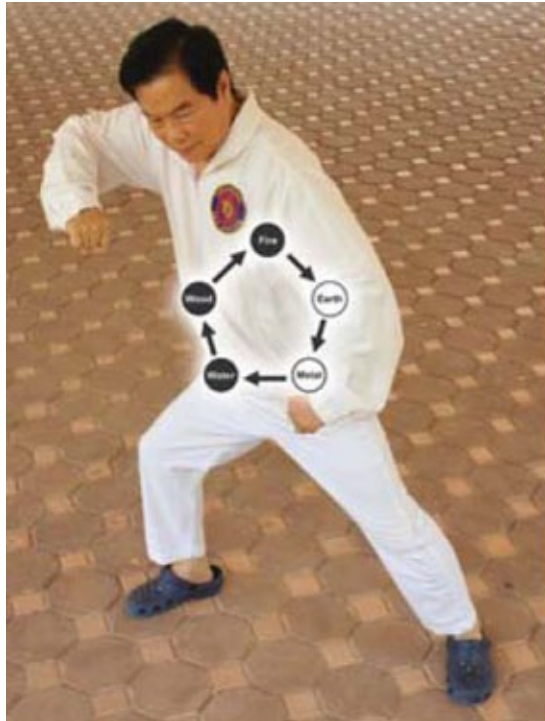
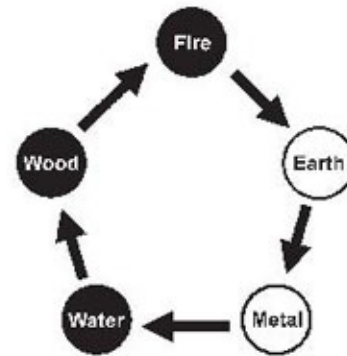


Fig. 4.35. Tan tien absorbing chi from the five elements



☀ **Gate 8: Kou**

The back and shoulder set up a discharge of power using their weight against an imaginary force—much like Pounding a Pestle (fig. 4.36).²³



Fig. 4.36. Shoulder Strike using the principle of the mortar and pestle



Tan Tien Chi Kung

This series of eleven exercises is useful for training the expansion of the tan tien,

rotation of the waist, and movement of the center to the various parts of the lower tan tien. To find specific directions for the eleven animal exercises, see Mantak Chia's *Tan Tien Chi Kung*.¹⁸

TAN TIEN CHI KUNG EXERCISES

EXERCISE	ASPECT TRAINED
Rabbit	Front tan tien
Crane	Side tan tien
Bear	Back tan tien
Swallow	Sides of the tan tien
Dragon	Waist rotation
Eagle	Coupling
Monkey	Striking while relaxed
Elephant	Striking while relaxed
Rhinoceros	All phases of Fa Jin
Horse	All phases of Fa Jin
Bull	All phases of Fa Jin

Specific Discharge Power Yang Technicals

These technicals are carried out in full speed. While all stages of discharge power are required for practice, they focus now on real-time speed.



Civet Cat Catches the Rat

This cultivates the Peng force. It is the classic exercise for development of the one-inch punch, in which power is released from a standing start (fig. 4.37). The opposition of the force comes from the other arm, and its sudden release can create a strong spring-like burst that is almost impossible to defend against. Visualize and imitate nature by moving your fist from an open palm to a closed fist, thus capturing a rat.



Fig. 4.37. Civet Cat Catches the Rat



Chopping Wood

This exercise cultivates Fa Jin in a downward direction (fig. 4.38). The force is released downward with 90 percent of the weight on one leg. There is a simultaneous sinking of the weight with each strike. The sinking of the weight implies that the weight of the practitioner is transferred with the strike. Combined with the power generated from the tan tien and arms, the body weight contributes to a powerful destructive strike. This force is useful in executing the Tsai force. The name of the exercise reflects the principles of this technical: you become like an axe chopping wood. The weight must be more in the hand than in the elbow or shoulder. Maximal power comes from being loose and relaxed.



Fig. 4.38. Chopping Wood posture



Striking to Side

In this technical, Fa Jin is released simultaneously with two arms to the back (fig. 4.39). There is the same sense of releasing power via the spine as in the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung.



Fig. 4.39. Arms swinging to the sides



Leading the Goat

Here power is released along the radial side of the forearm (fig. 4.40). Power is generated as per a roundhouse punch or strike—through rotation of the Central Thrusting Channel and the movement of focus from the side to the central tan tien. The use of the Yi power is encouraged via the image of “Leading the Goat.”



Fig. 4.40. Leading the Goat: swinging arms inward



Flicking Fingers

This technical really encourages relaxation or *fang sung* while striking. Chi is generated from the tan tien, reaching the fingertips like a whip (fig. 4.41). The lightweight yet small fingers are themselves a dangerous weapon, as they can be used to strike the eyes or sensitive parts of the face.



Fig. 4.41. Flicking fingers

5

The Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form

The following pages detail the practice of the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form (fig. 5.1). Beginners and older people generally practice the form with a higher stance. As a student progresses, he or she can practice with a middle-structure stance that is closer to the ground, to increase strength. For martial purposes, one generally uses an extremely low stance.



Fig. 5.1. Discharge form



Introductory Movements



Wu Chi Stance

The first movement of the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form is internal, not external. Outwardly, the practitioner stands still, facing north. This position is related to Wu Chi, the primordial unmanifest state (fig. 5.2).



Fig. 5.2. Wu Chi Stance

1. Stand with your feet close together, but not touching at the ankles. The nine points of the feet should make contact with the ground. This is the root—the connecting point with the earth energy.
2. Keep your back straight and relaxed and the knees straight but not locked. No pressure, tension, or pain should be felt in the lumbar area.
3. Relax your shoulders and pull your head upward at the crown. This is the heavenly pull that draws the earth energy up through the feet.
4. Feel the heavenly pull, as if a chi ball above your head is pulling you up. The pull also stretches your spine, allowing the energy to circulate more freely. At the same time, feel the chi enter your coccyx and straighten your spine.
5. Keep your eyes open without strain. The focus is directly ahead, to the horizon.
6. Pull your chin slightly backward. This subtle movement opens the base of the skull so the energy can circulate freely up to the crown and down the front of the body.
7. Lightly place the tip of your tongue against the palate at a point that helps

induce salivation (fig. 5.3). Your jaw should be relaxed with the teeth lightly touching. If the jaw is biting down hard, there will be tension on the sides of the head and the throat.

8. Relax your throat. Swallow a little saliva and exhale gently to relax the muscles of the neck.
9. The chest should be relaxed and slightly hollowed. This hollowing is produced by a subtle rounding of the scapulae on the back. If the chest is tight, relax it by inhaling gently without making noise and then exhaling just as quietly through parted lips.
10. Breathe deeply and evenly, expanding your abdomen.
11. Bring your attention to your navel or your tan tien. Let the breath penetrate to the tan tien, creating the sensation of a growing energy ball.
12. Relax your arms, leaving a hollow in the armpits as if holding a Ping-Pong ball there. The arms should not be touching the body.
13. Relax the palms of both hands, keeping the fingers loose yet straight. Raise your index fingers very slightly, so you can feel energy sparkling at the tips (fig. 5.4).
14. Feel the palms and soles breathing. Feel the chi ball in the tan tien contracting and expanding with the breath (fig. 5.5).



Fig. 5.3. Tongue placed lightly on the roof of the mouth



Fig. 5.4. Raise your index fingers to feel the energy sparking.

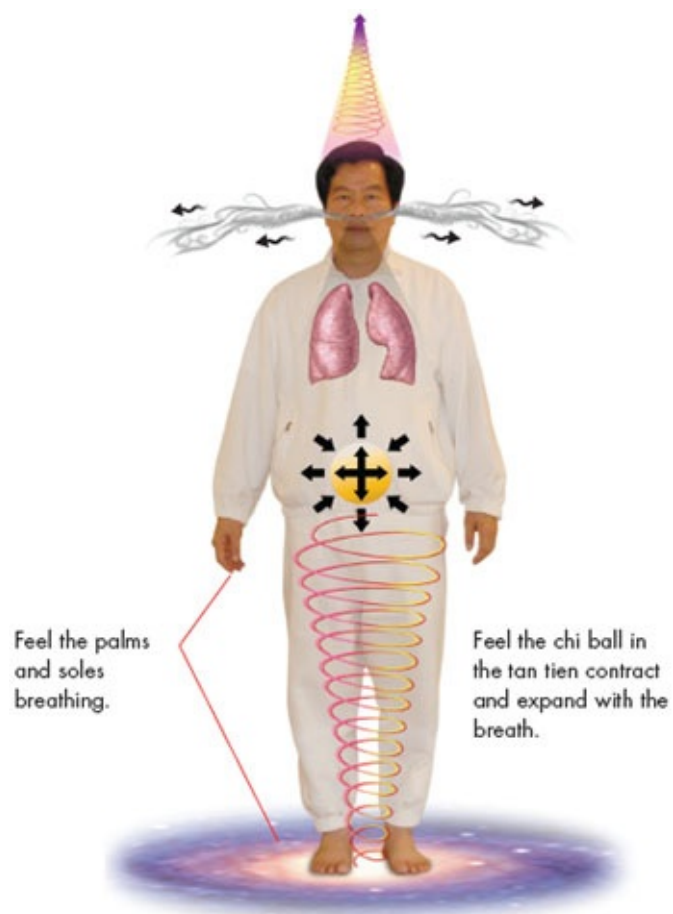


Fig. 5.5. Tan tien breathing

 Smile

1. Smile down to the thymus gland below your neck. Allow the smile to spread to your heart and all other organs.
2. Smile down to your navel.
3. Listen to your heartbeat. Follow the pulse from your heart out through the chest, shoulders, upper arms, elbows, forearms, wrists, hands, and fingers. Feel the pulse in the index and pinkie fingers.

 Breathing

1. Become aware of the earth energy at your feet, the heavenly pull at your crown, and the cosmic energy in front of your body. Inhale gently without making noise and draw the cosmic energy into the mid-eyebrow point.
2. Let the cosmic energy penetrate deeply into the lungs, then spread to all of your organs. Let it fill the soles of your feet.
3. When your inhalation is complete, retain the breath for a moment without straining, then begin to exhale gently without making noise. Your breath should be so gentle that it would not move a piece of paper placed in front of your nostrils.

**Opening the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form**

Preparation: Step Out

1. As you exhale, begin to sink down, shifting your weight onto your right leg. The sinking should originate from the hips and sacrum, as sinking by simply bending the knees puts too much stress on them, resulting in swelling and injury. Sink and fold at the groin (*kua*) without much of a bend in the knees, and feel your weight transfer down the back of your knee to the heel (fig. 5.6).
2. Sink your chest and round the scapulae a little bit more, so that your arms come out slightly from your sides. As the chest sinks, the sternum moves inward, massaging the thymus gland.
3. Rotate your hands so that the palms face back. Feel the energy flowing through your arms down to the palms and fingertips.

4. Begin to shift your weight onto your right leg. Keep your crown aligned with the heavenly force, so there is no leaning to compensate for sinking down on the right leg.
5. When all the weight is on the right leg, inhale as you lift the left heel, keeping the big toe touching the ground.
6. Separate the left leg by brushing the ground lightly with the big toe, as if tracing a line. The separation between the two feet should be roughly the width of the shoulders. This is the base. If the space between the feet is less than shoulder width, the base will be narrower than the top, and the structure will be top-heavy. In this style, the base should not be wider than the shoulders' width.
7. Exhale as you place your left foot at a 45-degree open angle, firmly touching all 9 points on the ground. Shift your weight so that it is on both feet equally.

At this point, your knees should remain slightly bent, but not going over the edge of the toes. Your pelvic area is open, and the energy ball is in the navel area. Your spine should be stretched by the heavenly pull while your sacrum is pulled down by the earth force (fig. 5.7).



Fig. 5.6. Opening the kua (ligaments of the groin)



Fig. 5.7. Chi pressure

The next sequence is the core part of the Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form. It starts with the Left-Hand Form and then transitions into the Right-Hand Form. At the end, there is a series of concluding movements.



Core Movements: Left-Hand Form

The first half of Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form is called the Left-Hand Form. The moves are in a clockwise progression, and the strikes are performed with the left hand.



Step Forward (North)

1. Stand facing north with your feet together and knees straight (fig. 5.8). Relax, then regulate and slow your breath with whole-body breathing. Feel your head suspended by a string from heavenly force, and your feet drawn to earth by the earth force.
2. Smile down and inhale. Round the scapula and sink the chest. Open the armpits. Now exhale, sink down, and bend your knees, shifting your body weight and tailbone to the right foot. Allow the life force in your tan tien to lead the rotation to the left (west).
3. Inhale and pick up your left foot, placing it on the ground a shoulder width apart from the right foot, pointing toward the northwest.
4. Shift your body weight to the left foot. Draw the right hip forward. Step forward with the left foot. Reach with the right hand facing north.
5. Carry out silk reeling in an upward direction, one circle with the right hand then one with the left (fig. 5.9). Turn the waist to the left (south) with the momentum of the silk reeling exercise, rotating your tan tien around the imaginary Tai Chi Pole (Central Thrusting Channel).
6. The right hand, after completing its circle, prepares itself during the left silk reeling and the turn for the Ward Off position, which is palm facing upward and southward. After completing its circle, the left arm turns in the Ward Off position, with the exception that the palm faces downward.

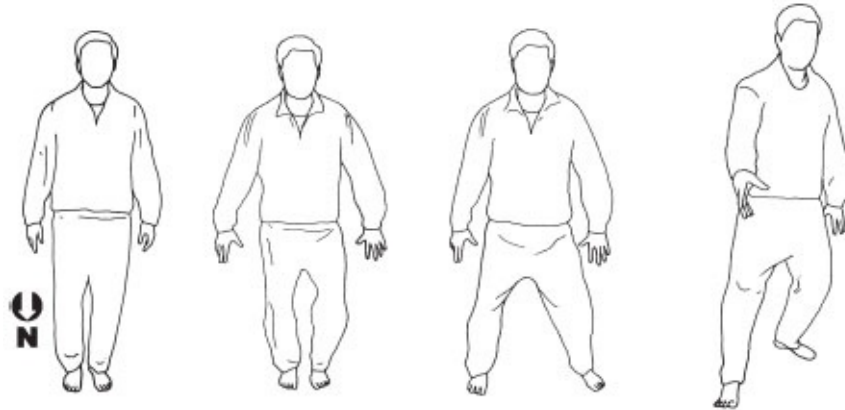


Fig. 5.8. First Ward Off: Opening Stance

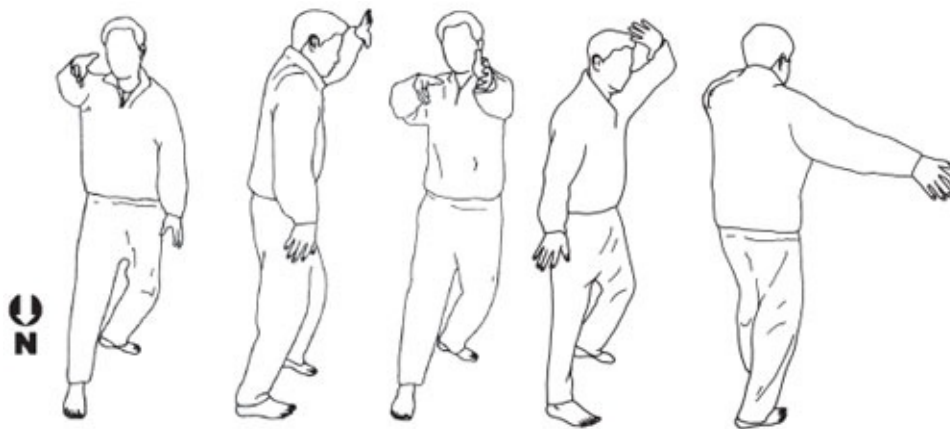


Fig. 5.9. Silk reeling

First Corner (South), Left-Hand Form

1. You now face south. The arms now have formed the Ward Off position and are holding a chi ball (see fig 5.10 on page 122). Your weight is largely on your right foot, with the left foot taking only 20 percent of it. Only the forefoot of your left foot is touching the ground, in a Cat Stance-like posture.

First Bird's Tail (South)

2. Ward Off Strike: Now sink back, letting your weight fall into the right leg.
3. Take your left foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. This means hard work, using your quadriceps to keep the lumbar vertebrae full and held back. This ability can come only from Iron Shirt training. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the process of stepping forward with the left leg.

4. Now release the discharge power with your left hand while allowing the right (back) leg to drag and stay connected to the ground. Remember the Fusion meditations, where the eight forces are fused in the lower tan tien. If reversed, a desired force can be released. While the tan tien has the ability to release any of the eight forces, Fa Jin is primarily associated with Peng. It is like having a thousand troops ready to be released at the call of the general. This single move, described in steps 2–4, is the core feature of the form and repeated in principle throughout.

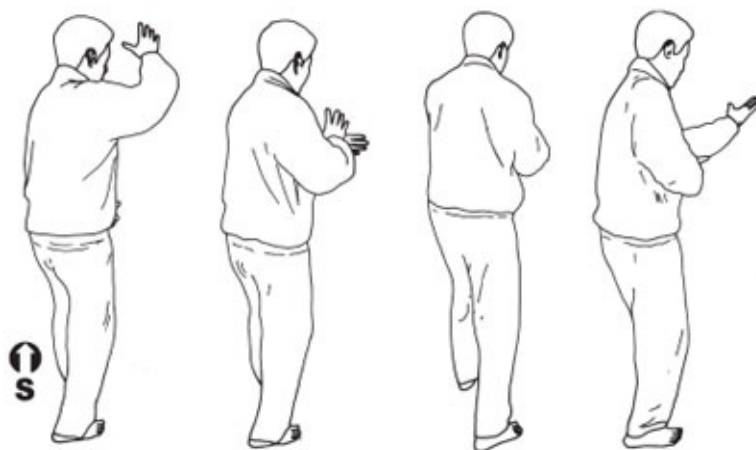


Fig. 5.10. First Bird's Tail (south)

5. Rollback: Return feet to the original position of the Ward Off Strike (step 2 above). This means stepping back with the right leg, as per the fundamental Tai Chi Chi Kung form. At the same time, rotate the left arm so the palm faces the face, and let the right arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the right foot (the anchor leg) straight.

6. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the right palm with the inner aspect of the left wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power. Remember to work the tan tien and keep the right foot (anchor leg) straight.

7. Push Strike: As per the fundamental Tai Chi Chi Kung form, sink back and separate the arms (fig. 5.11). As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the left leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike, dragging a stiff right foot straight. These three movements—the Ward Off, Rollback, and Push—are part of Grasping the Peacock's Tail, more conveniently shortened to "Bird's Tail."

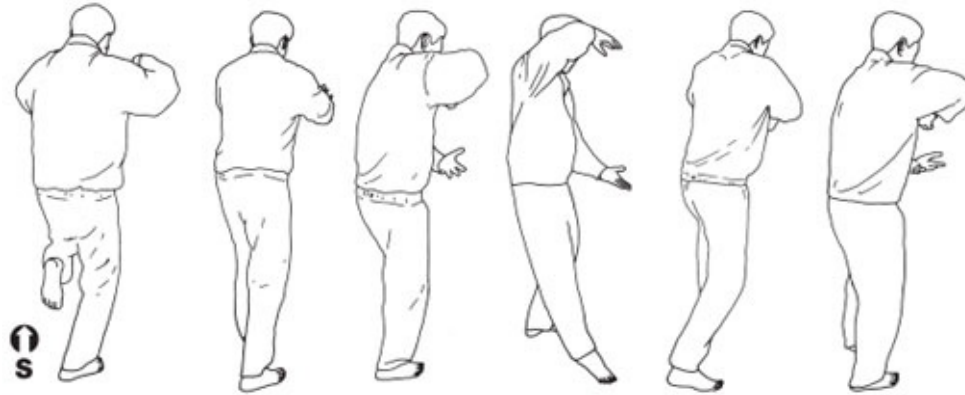


Fig. 5.11. Push to south, Left-Hand Form

Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Change of Direction

8. **Single Whip:** Sink back and put your weight over the right leg. Form a beak with the right hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the left hand. Change the left foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the left foot so that the toes are now facing the west. The Single Whip is not completed as it is in the classic Yang form. Instead, only the initial preparatory half of the form is completed—through the Fair Lady Works the Shuttle.

9. **Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (to north):** Make a circle with the palms (fig. 5.12). The right palm circles to the lower position while the left palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, and then step forward with the right leg to the north. Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Left Palm Strike and a Right Arm Upper Block.

10. **Change directions:** Step back with the left foot pointing west, and follow it with the right foot stepping back also pointing west. Now allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. In order to activate the lower tan tien, however, the right hand carries out two small circles.

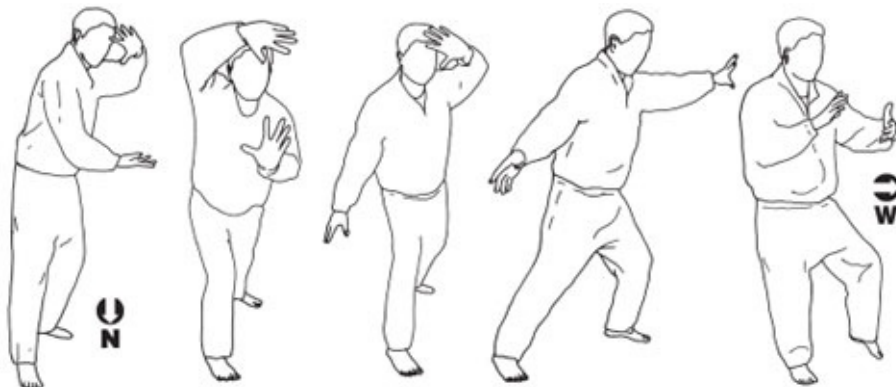


Fig. 5.12. Lady Shuttle to the north and change to west Ward Off

Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form Angular Directions

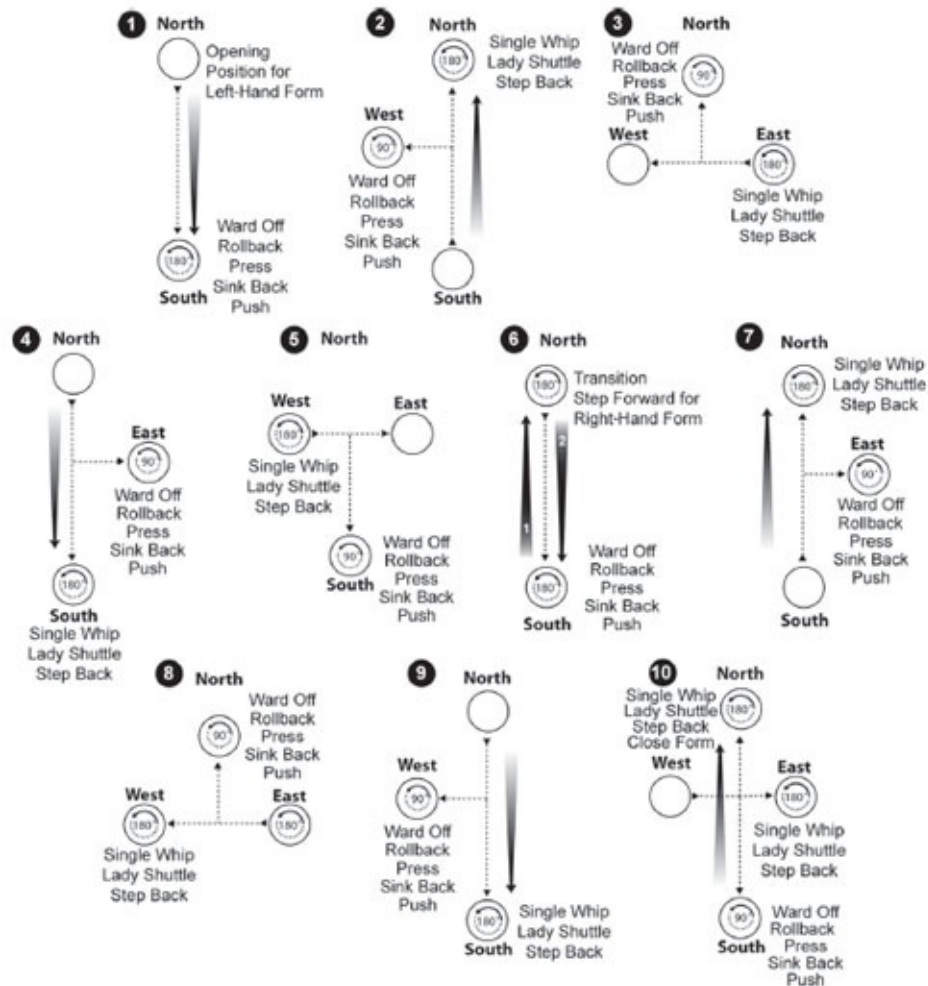


Fig. 5.13. North, South, West, East directions in the Discharge Form

Second Corner (West)

1. The arms now have formed the Ward Off position facing west and are holding a chi ball. Your weight is largely on your right foot, and only the forefoot of your left foot is touching the ground.

Second Bird's Tail (West)

2. Ward Off Strike: Now sink back, letting your weight fall into the right leg. Take your left foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the process of stepping forward with the left leg (fig. 5.14).

3. Now release the discharge power while allowing the right (back) leg to

drag and stay connected to the ground.

4. Rollback: Step back with the right leg, as per the fundamental Tai Chi Chi Kung form. At the same time, rotate the left arm so the palm faces the face, and let the right arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the right foot (the anchor leg) straight.

5. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the right palm with the inner aspect of the left wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power.

6. Push Strike: Sink back and separate the arms. As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the left leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike, dragging a stiff right foot straight.

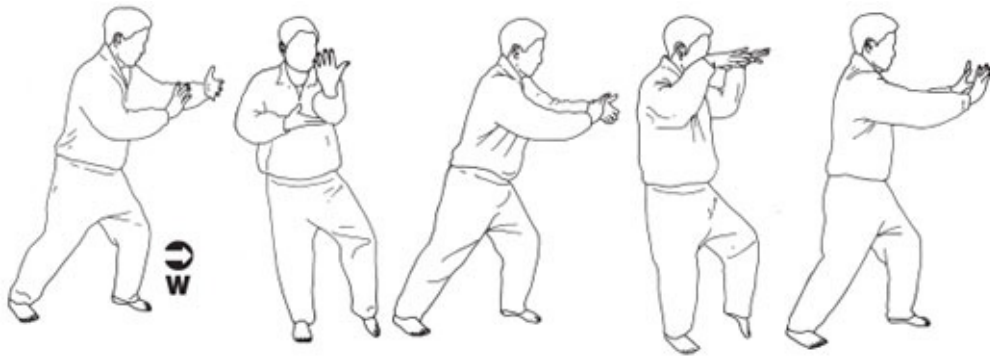


Fig. 5.14. Second Bird's Tail (to west)



Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Change of Direction

7. Single Whip: Sink back and put your weight over the right leg. Form a beak with the right hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the left hand (fig. 5.15). Change the left foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the left foot so that the toes are now facing the north.

8. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (to east): Make a circle with the palms. The right palm circles to the lower position while the left palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, then step forward with the right leg to the east. Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Left Palm Strike and a Right Arm Upper Block.

9. Change directions: Step back with the left foot pointing north, and follow it with the right foot stepping back also pointing north. Now allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. In order to activate the lower tan tien, the right hand carries out two small circles.

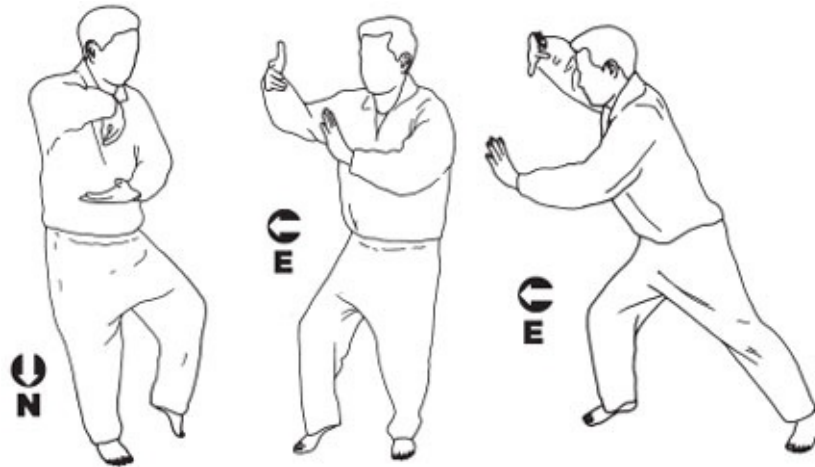


Fig. 5.15. Single Whip, then Lady Shuttle to the east

☀ **Third Corner (North)**

1. You now face north. The arms now have formed the Ward Off position and are holding a chi ball. Your weight is largely on your right foot, and only the forefoot of your left foot is touching the ground (fig. 5.16).

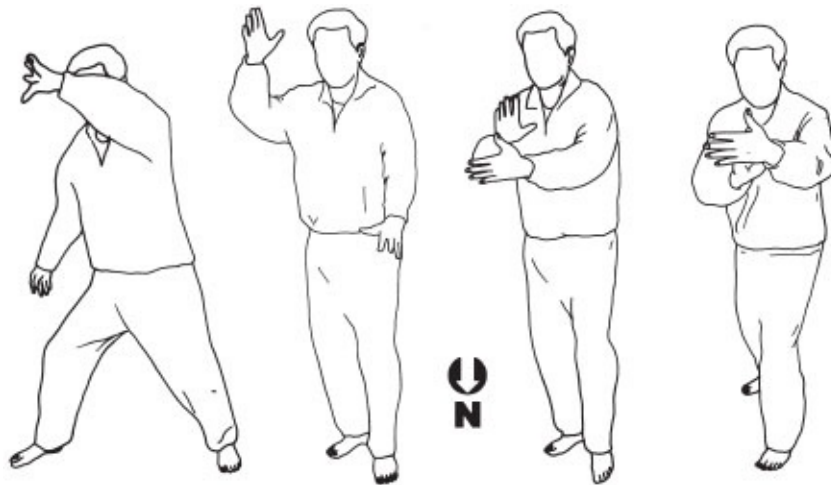


Fig. 5.16. Circle hands and Ward Off to north, Left-Hand Form

☀ **Third Bird's Tail (North)**

2. Ward Off Strike: Sink back, letting your weight fall into the right leg. Take your left foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the process of stepping forward with the left leg.
3. Now release the discharge power while allowing the right (back) leg to drag and stay connected to the ground.
4. Rollback: Step back with the right leg. At the same time, rotate the left

arm so the palm faces the face, and let the right arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the right foot (the anchor leg) straight (fig. 5.17).

5. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the right palm with the inner aspect of the left wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power.

6. Push Strike: Sink back and separate the arms. As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the left leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike, dragging a stiff right foot straight.

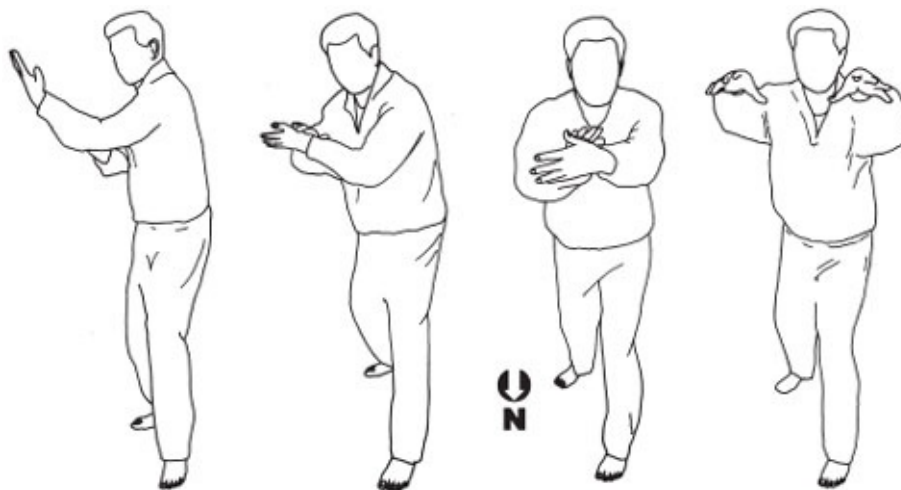


Fig. 5.17. Rollback, Press, and Push to north

Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Change of Direction

7. Single Whip: Sink back and put your weight over the right leg. Form a beak with the right hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the left hand (see fig. 5.18 on page 130). Change the left foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the left foot so that the toes are now facing the east.

8. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (south): Make a circle with the palms. The right palm circles to the lower position while the left palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, then step forward with the right leg to the south (see fig. 5.19 on page 130). Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Left Palm Strike and a Right Arm Upper Block.



Fig. 5.18. Sink back and forming the beak in the Single Whip

9. Change directions: Step back with the left foot pointing east, and follow it with the right foot stepping back also pointing east. Now allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. In order to activate the lower tan tien, the right hand carries out two small circles.

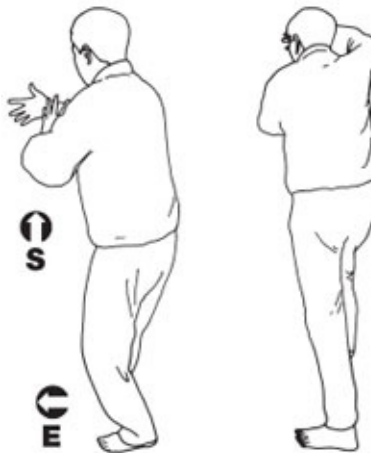


Fig. 5.19. Lady Shuttle Strike to south

Fourth Corner (East)

1. You are now facing east. The arms have formed the Ward Off position and are holding a chi ball. Your weight is largely on your right foot, and only the forefoot of your left foot is touching the ground.

Fourth Bird's Tail (East)

2. Ward Off Strike: Now sink back, letting your weight fall into the right leg. Take your left foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the

process of stepping forward with the left leg.

3. Now release the discharge power while allowing the right (back) leg to drag and stay connected to the ground.

4. Rollback: Step back with the right leg. At the same time, rotate the left arm so the palm faces the face, and let the right arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the right foot (the anchor leg) straight.

5. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the right palm with the inner aspect of the left wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power.

6. Push Strike: Sink back and separate the arms. As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the left leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike, dragging a stiff right foot straight.



Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Change of Direction

7. Single Whip: Sink back and put your weight over the right leg. Form a beak with the right hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the left hand. Change the left foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the left foot so that the toes are now facing the south.

8. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (to west): Make a circle with the palms. The right palm circles to the lower position while the left palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, then step forward with the right leg to the west. Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Left Palm Strike and a Right Arm Upper Block.

9. Change directions: Step back with the left foot pointing south, and follow it with the right foot stepping back also pointing south. Now allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. In order to activate the lower tan tien, however, the right hand carries out two small circles.



Fifth Corner (South)

1. You are now facing south again. The arms have formed the Ward Off position and are holding a chi ball. Your weight is largely on your right foot, and only the forefoot of your left foot is touching the ground.



Fifth Bird's Tail (South)

2. Ward Off Strike: Now sink back, letting your weight fall into the right

leg. Take your left foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the process of stepping forward with the left leg.

3. Now release the discharge power with your left hand while allowing the right (back) leg to drag and stay connected to the ground.

4. Rollback: Step back with the right leg. At the same time, rotate the left arm so the palm faces the face, and let the right arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the right foot (the anchor leg) straight.

5. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the right palm with the inner aspect of the left wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power.

6. Push Strike: Sink back and separate the arms. As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the left leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike, dragging a stiff right foot straight.



Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Transition to Right-Hand Form

7. Single Whip: Sink back and put your weight over the right leg. Form a beak with the right hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the left hand. Change the left foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the left foot so that the toes are now facing the west.

8. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (to north): Make a circle with the palms. The right palm circles to the lower position while the left palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, then step forward with the right leg to the north. Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Left Palm Strike and a Right Arm Upper Block (fig. 5.20).



Fig. 5.20. Lady Shuttle Strike to the north

9. Step forward (west) with the left foot. Perform silk reeling and then sink back (fig. 5.21).

10. Turn to face south, sink your weight into the left foot, and hold a chi ball with your left hand above and right hand below to prepare the first Ward Off.



Fig. 5.21. Step forward to the west, changing directions to transition to the Right-Hand Form, facing south.



Right-Hand Form

Now, the right hand leads each Bird's Tail, and it is the right hand that strikes the chest of your imaginary opponent in the Fair Lady. In the Right-Hand Form, the body moves in a counterclockwise direction.

First Corner (South), Right-Hand Form

1. You are now facing south. Your arms have formed the Ward Off position and are holding a chi ball. Your weight is largely on your left foot, and only the forefoot of your right foot is touching the ground.

First Bird's Tail (South)

2. Ward Off Strike: Now sink back, letting your weight fall into the left leg. Take your right foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the process of stepping forward with the right leg (fig 5.22).
3. Now release the discharge power with your right hand while allowing the left (back) leg to drag and stay connected to the ground.
4. Rollback: Step back with the left leg. At the same time, rotate the right arm so the palm faces the face, and let the left arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the left foot (the anchor leg) straight.
5. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the left palm with the inner aspect of the right wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power.
6. Push Strike: Sink back and separate the arms. As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the right leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike to the west, dragging a stiff left foot straight.



Fig. 5.22. Ward Off, Rollback, and Press to south

Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Change of Direction

7. Single Whip: Sink back, and put your weight onto your left leg. Turn the hips to the right, facing north (fig. 5.23). Form a beak with the left hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the right hand. Change the right foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the right foot so that the toes are now facing the east.

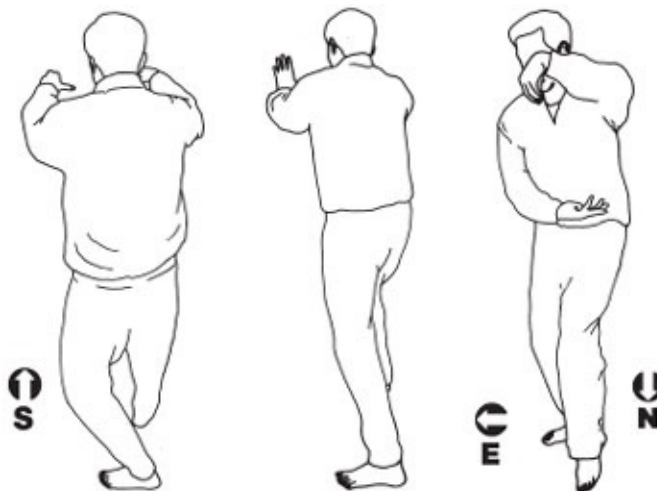


Fig. 5.23. Forming the Single Whip

8. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (to north): Make a circle with the palms. The left palm circles to the lower position while the right palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, then step forward with the left leg to the north. Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Right Palm Strike and a Left Arm Upper Block (fig. 5.24).

9. Change directions by stepping back with the right foot pointing east and follow it with left foot stepping back also pointing east. Allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. Hold a chi ball in the preparatory Ward Off position facing east.



Fig. 5.24. Lady Shuttle to the north and preparing second Bird's Tail

Second Corner (East)

1. You are now facing east. Your arms have formed the preparatory Ward Off position and are holding a chi ball. Your weight is largely on your left foot, and only the forefoot of your right foot is touching the ground (fig. 5.25).

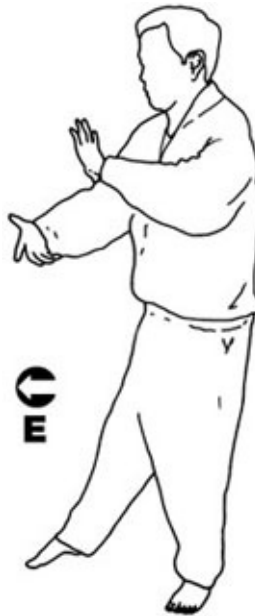


Fig. 5.25. Facing east for second Bird's Tail

Second Bird's Tail (East)

2. Ward Off Strike: Now sink back, letting your weight fall into the left leg. Take your right foot off the ground while keeping the lumbar full, and step forward. Use your tan tien, and feel it twist and hold power in the process of stepping forward with the right leg.

3. Now release the discharge power with your right hand while allowing the left (back) leg to drag and stay connected to the ground.
4. Rollback: Step back with the left leg. At the same time, rotate the right arm so the palm faces the face, and let the left arm float across, preparing for the Press Strike. Keep the left foot (the anchor leg) straight.
5. Press Strike: Connect the outer side (little finger side) of the left palm with the inner aspect of the right wrist. Repeat the same tan tien and footwork as in the Ward Off Strike, and release the discharge power (fig. 5.26).
6. Push Strike: Sink back and separate the arms. As always, allow the arms to automatically follow the tan tien; they should not be moved directly by the mind. Then step forward with the right leg, prepare the tan tien, and discharge with a Double Palm Strike to the east, dragging a stiff left foot straight.

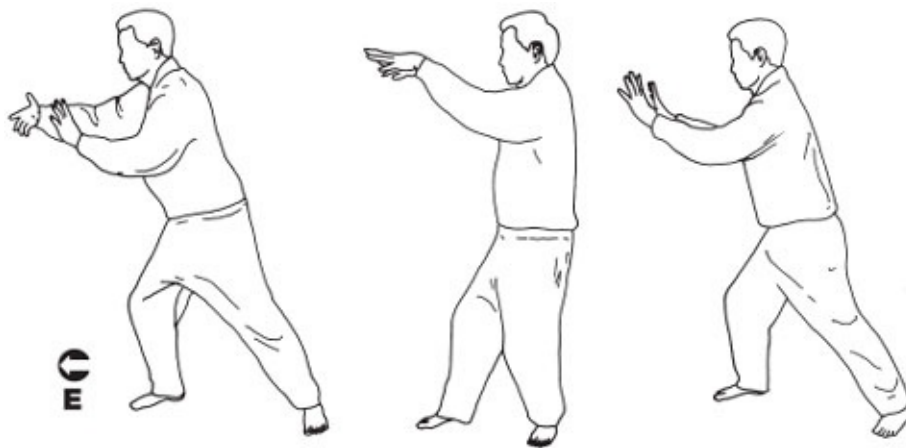


Fig. 5.26. Second Bird's Tail to east

 Single Whip, Lady Shuttle, and Change of Direction

7. Single Whip: Sink back, and put your weight onto your left leg. Turn the hips to the right, facing north. Form a beak with the left hand and face the beak downward to the open palm of the right hand (fig. 5.27). Change the right foot from toes touching the ground to heel touching the ground. Turn the right foot so that the toes are now facing the north.
8. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (to west): Make a circle with the palms. The left palm circles to the lower position while the right palm moves to the top position. Hold the chi ball for a moment, and then step forward with the left leg to the west. Activate the tan tien and discharge the power via a Right Palm Strike and a Left Arm Upper Block.
9. Change directions by stepping back with the right foot pointing north and

follow it with left foot stepping back also pointing north. Allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. Hold a chi ball in the preparatory Ward Off position facing north.

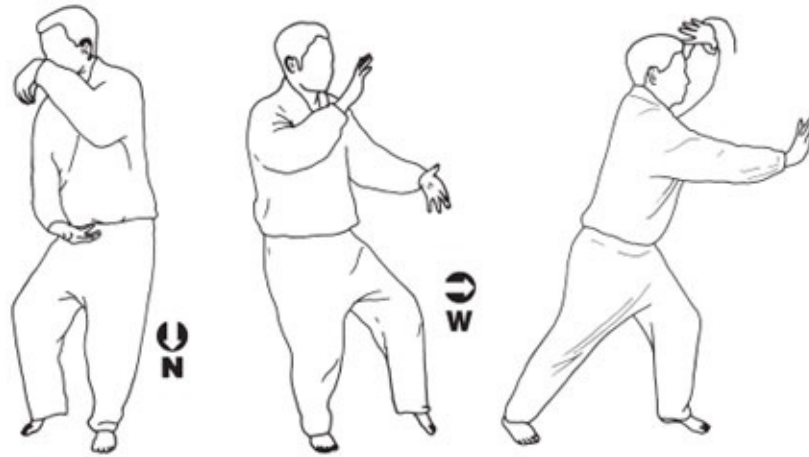


Fig. 5.27. Single Whip and Lady Shuttle to the west

☀ **Third Corner (North)**

You are now facing north. Repeat the steps of the Right-Hand Form from the Ward Off through the Lady Shuttle in this direction. This means a Bird's Tail to the north (fig. 5.28) and a Lady Shuttle to the south.

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback
3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle
7. Change directions by stepping back with the right foot pointing west and follow it with left foot stepping back also pointing west. Allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. Hold a chi ball in the preparatory Ward Off position facing west.



Fig. 5.28. Third Bird's Tail (to north)

☀ ***Fourth Corner (West)***

You are now facing west. Repeat the steps of the Right-Hand Form from the Ward Off through the Lady Shuttle in this direction. This means a Bird's Tail to the west and a Lady Shuttle to the east.

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback
3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle
7. Change directions by stepping back with the right foot pointing south and follow it with left foot stepping back also pointing south. Allow both hands to move to the Ward Off position. Hold a chi ball in the preparatory Ward Off position facing south.

☀ ***Fifth Corner (South) to Completion***

You are now facing south. Repeat the steps of the Right-Hand Form from the Ward Off through the Single Whip in this direction. This means a Bird's Tail to the south and a Lady Shuttle to the north.

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback

3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle: Sink back and push left hand forward with hip. Roll right hand up to protect head facing east.
7. Shift tailbone to right hip. Release Lady Shuttle to north (fig. 5.29).



Fig. 5.29. Final Lady Shuttle (to north)



Closing the Tai Chi Kung Discharge Form

1. Open both hands, moving them up and outward, then downward. At the same time, draw the left foot straight back, setting it down parallel to the right foot while shifting the tailbone to the left heel (fig. 5.30).
2. Lift up the right leg and place it parallel with left. Draw your feet together, keeping the toes even.
3. Cross your hands (right hand over left) 12 inches in front of your body, so that they form an X below your shoulders. Distribute your weight evenly between both feet, then simultaneously straighten your body and lower your hands to your sides, with palms facing backward.
4. End all movements at same time, then relax and center yourself. Feel the chi in your body.
5. Smile down. Collect energy at your navel.

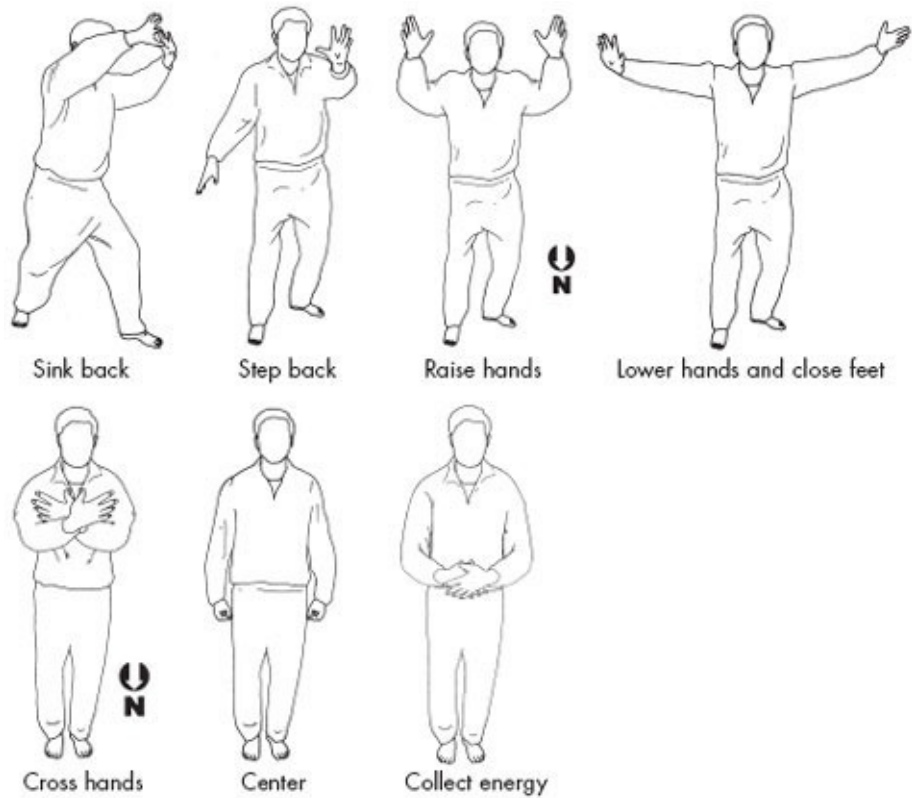


Fig. 5.30. The closing form

6

Summary of the Complete Discharge Form

The following images are an easy visual guide for your daily Fa Jin practice. The form will give you the full benefits of Tai Chi Chi Kung Discharge Form.



Opening the Form

1. Beginning Stance: Stand facing north, with your feet together and knees straight (fig. 6.1). Relax, then regulate and slow your breath with whole-body breathing. Feel your head suspended from a string connected to the heavenly force. Feel your feet connecting to the earth force. As in the preparation for any Tai Chi form, the practitioner needs to make a transition from the everyday mind to the Tai Chi mind. This involves a recall of meditation experience within the moment: the breath slows down to an experience of whole-body breathing; the mind—with the aid of the Inner Smile—sinks down via the middle tan tien to the lower tan tien; consciousness expands not only to the tan tiens but also beyond the self to heaven and earth. A glimpse of the Wu Wei, or blissful nothingness, is remembered before the form is begun.
2. With the above as an initiation into the form, the practitioner sinks down, then opens the armpits and fingers a little.
3. Smile from the eyes down to the navel. Inhale while rounding the scapulae, sinking the chest, and opening the armpits. Then exhale while sinking down.
4. Shift your tailbone to the right heel and lift the left heel up.
5. Inhale while picking up your left foot, then exhale as you set the left foot down a shoulder width apart, at a 30-degree angle. Maintain basic Iron Shirt posture with the left foot open.
6. Shift your tailbone over the left heel. Draw your right hip forward, then step with the right foot and reach with the right hand facing north.
7. Draw your right hip and arm back while simultaneously moving the left hip

and hand forward. Shift your tailbone to the left heel and sink back.

8. Turn left, and torque your left hip while bringing your left forearm up to protect your head. Let the movement of your hips turn your right foot 90 degrees, then shift your tailbone to the left heel.



Core Movements: Left-Hand Form



First Corner (South)

1. Turn hips to left (fig. 6.2). Shift tailbone to right heel. Step wide on left toes, facing south. Raise your right hand from the right hip, circling with the left hand twice, then forming a chi ball.
2. Ward Off Strike: Sink back—kick left foot back—discharge forward wide—drag stiff right leg (anchor leg), right foot straight—no upper movement—sink back.
3. Rollback: Turn hips to right, facing west—drop right hand to left elbow—eyes focus on left palm.
4. Press Strike: Outer right wrist connects to inner left wrist—kick left foot back—discharge forward wide—drag right foot straight (anchor leg)—no upper movement.
5. Push Strike: Sink back—separate wrists—open palms—kick left foot back—discharge forward wide—drag stiff right foot straight (anchor leg)—no upper movement.
6. Single Whip: Sink back (fig. 6.3)—turn hips to right facing west—form right hand beak over left palm—weight on right.
7. Prepare Lady Shuttle: Sink back—step left heel to south—turn left foot 90 degrees west while dropping left hand to protect left knee. Shift tailbone to left heel—right foot step wide to right facing north—circle right hand with left hand twice to right, forming chi ball—weight on left foot.
8. Lady Shuttle Strike to north: Sink back—strike (fig. 6.4)—push left hand forward with hip—roll right hand up to protect head, facing north.
9. Change directions to west: Step back with left foot pointing west—open hip to west—draw right hand down (crossing left wrist) protecting right knee. Left hand protects head—shift tailbone to left heel—left hand down to left knee and right hand up to protect head. Shift tailbone to right heel—circle hands twice forming chi ball facing west.

Second Corner (West), Left-Hand Form

1. Form chi ball (fig. 6.5).
2. Ward Off: Sink back–kick left foot back–discharge forward wide–drag stiff right leg (anchor leg), right foot straight–no upper movement–sink back–strike west.
3. Rollback.
4. Press Strike: Same footwork as Ward Off Strike with connecting wrists.
5. Push Strike: Sink back–separate wrists–open palms–kick left foot back–discharge forward (west) wide–drag stiff right foot straight–no upper movement.
6. Single Whip: Sink back–turn hips to right facing north–form right hand beak over left palm (fig. 6.6)–weight on right leg.
7. Lady Shuttle to the east: Step left heel to west–turn left foot 90 degrees north while dropping left hand to protect left knee–shift tailbone to left heel–right foot step wide to right (facing east)–circle right hand with left hand twice to right–form chi ball.
8. Sink back–strike–push left hand forward with hip–roll right hand up protecting head.
9. Change directions to north: Step back with left foot pointing north–open hip to north while drawing right hand down (crossing left wrist) to protecting right knee–left hand protecting head–shift tailbone to left heel–left hand down to left knee and right hand up protecting head.

Third Corner (North), Left-Hand Form

1. Shift tailbone to right heel–circle hands twice–form chi ball facing north (fig. 6.7).
2. Ward Off
3. Rollback
4. Press
5. Push
6. Single Whip (fig. 6.8)
7. Lady Shuttle to south
8. Change directions to east.

Fourth Corner (East), Left-Hand Form

(Fourth and fifth corners not shown.)

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback
3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle to west
7. Change directions to south.

Fifth Corner (South), Left-Hand Form, and Transition to Right-Hand Form

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback
3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle to north (fig. 6.9)
7. Transition: Left foot steps forward—shift tailbone to left heel—draw left hand forward and right hand back—shift tailbone to right heel—left hand to left hip and right hand forward—turn hips 90 degrees to right (face south)—right foot pointing east—right arm protects head—shift tailbone to left heel—weight on left foot.

Core Movements: Right-Hand Form

The movements now progress in a counterclockwise direction, and strikes are performed with the right hand.

First Corner (South), Right-Hand Form

1. Right foot steps wide to right (facing south)—circle right hand around left hand twice to right—form chi ball (fig. 6.10).

2. Ward Off Strike: Sink back–kick right foot back–discharge forward wide–drag stiff left leg (anchor leg), left foot straight–no upper movement.
3. Rollback
4. Press
5. Push
6. Single Whip (fig. 6.11)
7. Lady Shuttle to north (fig. 6.12)
8. Change directions to east.

 Second Corner (East), Right-Hand Form

1. Form chi ball (fig. 6.13).
2. Ward Off
3. Rollback
4. Press
5. Push
6. Single Whip (fig. 6.14)
7. Lady Shuttle to west (fig. 6.15)
8. Change directions to north.

 Third Corner (North), Right-Hand Form

1. Form chi ball (fig. 6.16).
2. Ward Off
3. Rollback
4. Press
5. Push
6. Single Whip (fig. 6.17)
7. Lady Shuttle to south
8. Change directions to west.

 Fourth Corner (West), Right-Hand Form

(The fourth and fifth corners are not pictured.)

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback
3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle to east
7. Change directions to south.

 Fifth Corner (South), Right-Hand Form, to Completion

1. Ward Off
2. Rollback
3. Press
4. Push
5. Single Whip
6. Lady Shuttle to north (fig. 6.18)

 Core Movements: Closing Form

1. Completion: After releasing Lady Shuttle, open both hands (fig. 6.19). Move them up and outward then downward, drawing the left foot straight back, setting it down parallel to the right foot. Shift tailbone to left heel—lift up right leg placing, it parallel with left—draw feet together with toes even.
2. Raise hands 12 inches in front of body, then cross right wrist over left wrist and place them on your chest to form an X below the shoulders.
3. Distribute weight evenly between both feet. Simultaneously straighten body and lower hands to sides, with palms facing back. All movement ends at same time. Relax and center yourself, and feel the chi expand in your body.
4. Smile down, and collect energy at your navel.



UN

Opening stance



Step out to left



Fig. 6.1. Opening the form



Step forward
right foot and hand



Sink back



Turn left, draw back
right hip and arm



Shift tailbone
to left heel

Fig. 6.1. Opening the form, continued



Turn hips to left



Shift tailbone
to right heel



Circle Hands
form chi ball



Ward Off Strike



Rollback



Press Strike



Kick left foot back
for Push Strike



Push Strike

Fig. 6.2. First Bird's Tail (to south)



Sink back and form
beak for Single Whip



Sink back



Step out



Shift tailbone

Fig. 6.3. First Single Whip and preparing Lady Shuttle



Lady Shuttle Strike



Roll right hand up to protect head



Changing directions: now left hand protects head



Change direction to west

Fig. 6.4. Lady Shuttle Strike (to north), and change of direction (to west)



Form chi ball



Ward Off Strike



Rollback



Press Strike



Sink back



Push Strike

Fig. 6.5. Second Bird's Tail (to west)



Form the beak for Single Whip



Lady Shuttle



Lady Shuttle Strike



Change direction to north

Fig. 6.6. Second Single Whip, Lady Shuttle (to east), and change of direction (to north)



ON

Form chi ball



Ward Off



Ward Off Strike



Rollback



Press



Press Strike



Sink back



Push



Push Strike

Fig. 6.7. Third Bird's Tail (to north)



Form the beak



Lady Shuttle



Lady Shuttle Strike

Fig. 6.8. Third Single Whip and Lady Shuttle (to south)



Fifth Lady Shuttle Strike
(to north)



Sink back



Changing to
Right-Hand Form



Changing to
Right-Hand Form

Fig. 6.9. Last Lady Shuttle (to north) and transition to Right-Hand Form

This concludes the movements of the Left-Hand Form. The art on the following pages illustrates the Right-Hand Form. The movements of the Right-Hand Form progress in a counterclockwise direction and strikes are performed with the right hand.



Form chi ball



Ward Off



Ward Off Strike



Rollback



Press Strike



Sink back



Push Strike

Fig. 6.10. First Bird's Tail (to south)



Form the beak



Single Whip



Circle hands

Fig. 6.11. First Single Whip and preparing Lady Shuttle (to north)



Lady Shuttle Strike



Changing direction to east

Fig. 6.12. Lady Shuttle Strike (to north), and change of direction (to east)



Form chi ball



Ward Off Strike



Rollback



Press



Press Strike



Sink back



Push Strike

Fig. 6.13. Second Bird's Tail (to east)



Form beak



Circle hands



Lady Shuttle

Fig. 6.14. Second Single Whip and preparing Lady Shuttle (to west)



Lady Shuttle Strike



Changing direction to north

Fig. 6.15. Lady Shuttle Strike (to west), and change of direction (to north)



Form chi ball



Ward Off Strike



Sink back



Rollback



Press Strike



Sink back



Push



Push Strike

Fig. 6.16. Third Bird's Tail (to north)



Forming the beak for Single Whip



Lady Shuttle



Lady Shuttle Strike

Fig. 6.17. Third Single Whip and Lady Shuttle (to south)



Fig. 6.18. Final Lady Shuttle Strike (to north) with a single-hand Push



Sink back



Cross hands



Draw hands down



Close feet



Collect energy

Fig. 6.19. Closing movements

7

Push Hands (Tui Shou)

Discharge power is never done in isolation. While it can be demonstrated in a form or on a punching bag, it ultimately requires interaction with another live being. Power needs to be borrowed from the opponent. For that reason, Push Hands is an ideal practice for the study of discharge power; it encompasses the principles of fighting but is practiced in a safe arena. Injuries are rare in Push Hands.

The reasons for studying Push Hands are the same as those for studying Fa Jin: it can be part of one's journey toward the Tao. Push Hands ultimately reveals to us any ways that we deviate from wholeness—any shortcomings in our ability to integrate mind with body, with movement, and with another human being. Our defects are brought to the surface through interaction with a colleague whose purpose is similar to our own. With patience and practice, these defects can then be slowly understood and healed. We progress toward a unity of vision and skill and get closer to realizing the Tao.

DEVELOPING A PUSH HANDS PRACTICE

The first step in developing a Push Hands practice is learning the routine. Single Push Hands is a good start for beginners, while Double Push Hands can be pursued next, according to the particular style of Tai Chi you have chosen. Being familiar with the routine is very important as uncertainty about form immediately creates tension in both the structure and movement. Excessive tension is one of the most common faults in Tui Shou.

Once you are familiar with the movements, then all the principles of Iron Shirt training can be integrated into this routine. In Iron Shirt training, the practitioner learns to rely more and more on energy and less and less on muscle tension to maintain structure. The adept turns on the central axis of the Tai Chi Pole (the Central Thrusting Channel) and can thus evade or attack on the left or right side. The Iron Shirt is developed enough to be executed on one leg, which means that even in the rear position, the kidneys stay back and the practitioner is strong.

Initially, the practitioner relies on the monkey mind, but the routine eventually becomes so familiar that the intellectual mind can forget it. Once this happens,

the adept can really let go and use his integrated mind to interpret and understand his opponent. Now the body itself—via the tan tiens—interprets movements and acts reflexively. Eventually, of course, the great masters can interpret at even higher levels. They sense the intention of the opponent even earlier, and their whole body reacts as if directed by a spirit.

In Push Hands, the aim is “to stay connected and move coherently while external forces are applied to the body.”¹ Ultimately, there can be no intellectual thought, just a merging with the opponent and the chi forces that surround him or her. The coherence relies on an integration of Iron Shirt structure, release of power as per the fundamental Tai Chi Chi Kung form, and effortless movement that is centered on the Tai Chi Pole/Central Thrusting Channel.

Initially, there is little connection to the opponent as the adept is too stiff and preoccupied to listen. As the form becomes more familiar, however, the adept relaxes and begins to soften. Next, he uses just enough force that individual hairs will be bent but not squashed. He maintains a connection with his opponent when appropriate. The self is not separate in this merging but a new identity. There is neither forethought nor memory of past encounters, just a focus on the present contact. At some point, the opponent loses the foundation principle of Tui Shou and creates a disturbance that initiates an automatic response in the adept—the release of force via one of the eight gates. The tan tien is charged and releases.

The choice of which gate to use is based on a deep familiarity with each form, so that the correct gate is chosen in a given scenario. The choosing, however, is not an intellectual exercise but a decision that occurs in the integrated body-mind that lets go to the heavenly and earthly forces. Ultimately, this reaches a stage of “no method” with a release of maximal power. In some respects, the correct path requires learning to invest in loss. By losing and letting go of the monkey mind, and gradually assigning action to some greater though ill-defined force, progress is made. However, this progress is dependent on practice and discipline. Letting go would be useless to a novice who hasn’t learned the eight forces or the routine of Push Hands itself.

Mastering Push Hands is an important accomplishment. However it is not an end in itself. Losing is equal to winning as it helps the adept in his journey toward the Tao. The adept should engage with others with a sense of humility, recognizing the opportunity for self-reflection.

ROUTINES



Single Push Hands

In the beginning position, the student starts facing forward with one leg in front of the other (see fig. 7.1 on pages 180–81). All the principles of Iron Shirt apply.





Fig. 7.1. Single Push Hands posture

1. Stand with the arms a little lower than in Embracing the Tree posture. Make sure the kidneys are back.
2. Rotate the hand so that the ulnar side of the palm contacts the wrist of the opponent.
3. Move forward maintaining structure and connection to the earth. Remember all the basics of Iron Shirt training, and keep the nine points of the feet in contact with the ground.
4. Move the tan tien forward so that there is a slight pressure difference on the front of the tan tien. Leave the upper body relaxed but not floppy. The primary force here is Push (*An*). The opponent initially receives the force with Peng. In other words, the force from the opponent is used to activate the lower tan tien.
5. When you cannot retreat any further without falling backward, use the

oncoming force to rotate around the Central Thrusting Channel. The kidneys must be back in line with the rest of the back. Beginners, because they have not developed the tan tien, tend to sink back with the bottom and keep their normal lumbar curve (fig. 7.2).

6. Alternatively, the beginning practitioner will lean back with the shoulders instead of relying on the tan tien to maintain posture (fig. 7.3).



Fig. 7.2. Moving backward losing the lumbar curve



Fig. 7.3. Leaning back and crunching the lower vertebrae

The gate used here is the Rollback (*Lu*). Upon completion of the rotation around the Central Thrusting Channel, the force makes a circle and then returns to the opponent as Peng again.



Applications of Single Push Hands

During Single Push Hands, there are a number of common situations that can be addressed quickly and effectively with appropriate movements.

☸ ***Opponent Pushes Excessively***

Lead opponent's force to the rear side. Turn palm slightly such that there is an ounce of stickiness. Continue the direction of the force and uproot the opponent (fig. 7.4).



Fig. 7.4. Single Push Hands uprooting because of excessive force

☸ ***Opponent Pulls Back Excessively***

Sometimes an opponent may react with fear to an imminent uprooting and pull back excessively after a failed Rollback by the practitioner. At this point, the adept follows the withdrawal and initiates a Push (fig. 7.5).

☸ ***Opponent Fails to Maintain His Iron Shirt***

When an opponent does not maintain his Iron Shirt protection or Peng force, the practitioner seizes this moment with a Push at the apex of the circle, driving his elbow into the opponent to destroy his structure and topple him (fig. 7.6).



Fig. 7.5. Opponent withdrawing and the adept following with a Push



Fig. 7.6. Breaking an opponent's structure via elbow



Double Push Hands (Simple)

Here the practitioner and the opponent make contact with the wrist and elbow of one arm (fig. 7.7). The same circles are made as in the Single Push Hands form. Thus in the first position, the practitioner starts with the kidneys back and pushes on his opponent's forearm.

As with the Single-Hand Push above, the second position occurs when the opponent cannot retreat any more and therefore rotates on his Tai Chi Pole (Central Thrusting Channel) (fig. 7.8).

In the third position, the practitioner now returns the force as a Two-Hand Push to the opponent (fig. 7.9).



Fig. 7.7. Double Push Hands showing hand and elbow contact with feet position



Fig. 7.8. Two-handed rotation



Fig. 7.9. Ready for Push posture



Double Push Hands (Complex)

Inserted into the simple Double Push Hands described above is a complex hand interchange (fig. 7.10).







Fig. 7.10. Double Push Hands with a complex hand interchange

To improve your practice of Push Hands, it is helpful to remember the following rules.

Some Basic Push Hands Rules

- Always receive a Push with the top arm, which lies parallel to the chest.
- When you cannot retreat any more, turn on your Central Thrusting Channel toward the side of the top arm's hand (not elbow).
- Use your rear hand to lift your opponent's elbow, so he can make that forearm horizontal and parallel to the chest.
- Allow the hands to move so that both palms connect with your opponent's forearm.
- When changing sides, use your hand to lead the Push to the opposite side and to return your opponent's connecting arm back to his side.

DEEPER PRINCIPLES OF PUSH HANDS

Once the routine of Push Hands has become familiar to the body and mind, the deeper principles can be entertained. First, the fundamental principle of maintaining Iron Shirt structure throughout the routine is paramount. This prevents the major faults of bending forward (*fu*) or bending backward (*yang*). Second, the practitioner begins to adopt the principles of connecting, sticking, adhering, and following the opponent. Third, the practitioner studies the principles of listening and understanding the movements in conjunction with the

eight gates. Over time, the four faults of butting, deficiency, losing contact, and resisting disappear. Even if the practitioner does break from the opponent, this does not destabilize him and reconnection is easy.

Maintaining the Iron Shirt and Central Thrusting Channel in Movement

The ability to move well in Push Hands is developed by years of meditation and Iron Shirt training, which teach the practitioner to rely on chi to maintain the structure. These practices also teach how to keep the waist loose, allowing the tan tien to solidify and giving the practitioner the ability to rotate around the Central Thrusting Channel.

If the adept is comfortable with an Iron Shirt posture in a one-leg stance, then in defense he can transfer his weight to the back leg. If the kidneys remain back and full, then the Central Thrusting Channel remains open. This prevents the major fault of bending backward and allows the body to receive any force at a point external to the Central Thrusting Channel. The force will spin off at a tangent and consequently turn an opponent's attack into a loss.

As Yang Pan-Hou explains, "If we can entice the opponent into our circle, then the technique of four ounces repelling a thousand pounds will succeed."² In this passage, enticing is a key concept. To entice means to draw the opponent into the mechanism of the Tai Chi Pole (Central Thrusting Channel). This means that the average practitioner will need to extend his reach in order to maintain contact. As he extends and overreaches, he will engage the spinning pole of the adept and get deflected (fig. 7.11). If he pulls back because of this loss, the adept can follow with a release of Fa Jin, and the opponent will be repelled in the direction opposite from which he pushed.

When moving forward, the tan tien and rooting power maintain effortless connection to the earth. Power can be transmitted via the structure as discussed in chapter 3. This prevents the fault of bending forward (*fu*) (fig. 7.12).



Fig. 7.11. Tai Chi Pole and deflection



Fig. 7.12. Incorrect bending forward and correct forward posture

When attacking an opponent, the aim is to send a force vector that he will not deflect. This means that the practitioner must break the Iron Shirt structure of his opponent prior to discharging a force. The vector is aimed to the center of the opponent's Tai Chi Pole so that deflection is made less likely (fig. 7.13).



Fig. 7.13. Adept aiming vector of force to the opponent's center

Connecting, Sticking, Adhering, and Following

Wang Tsung-Yueh described the core Push Hands principles of connecting, sticking, adhering, and following as *zhan*, *lian*, *nian*, and *sui*:

Zhan is the energy that finds and connects with the partner's energy

Lian is the energy that links and joins with the partner's energy

Nian adheres and merges with the partner's energy

Sui pursues and follows a partner's energy.³

Upon first analysis, Yang and Wang appear to be saying the same thing. According to Yang, these principles are actually stages between disconnection and a state of merging.⁴ In the sparring situation, there is no contact; therefore, the first aim is to connect (*zhan*). From there, the adept makes an external link with the partner's movement (*lian*). Going deeper, the adept merges with the partner's internal energetic framework (*nian*) until finally the merging becomes a unity and it appears that the adept follows (*sui*) each and every move of the opponent. In actuality, they become one.

Now, in adhering to the opponent's energy, the practitioner merges his mind into the opponent's structure. He senses where the opponent's structure has deviated from the Iron Shirt position. This could happen at any point in the Push Hands sequence. At the moment the practitioner senses a deviation—or force outside the prescribed pattern—he neutralizes that force and returns it to the opponent. Therefore the practitioner must follow the opponent like a soft shadow, staying only one millimeter or one gram of force away from the

opponent's inner structure.

The ability to do this comes in part from repeated Iron Shirt practice and meditation. There is a move away from reliance on the monkey mind and the ego, and a deep trust in the move toward the mind that has fused with the lower tan tien and the opponent. This mind relies on chi and the will of nature rather than on the ego's intention. This ideal state of connecting, sticking, adhering, and following is captured by Wu Yu-Hsiang's pithy observation: "If others don't move, I don't move. If others move slightly, I move first."⁵

Listening and Interpreting

The monkey mind cannot hear the chi directly, but requires the body and the senses to do this. Listening (*ting*) is the way we analyze chi filtered through the five senses.

Cultivation of the senses comes from awakening the body through basic and advanced practices. The first achievement is to turn the mind inward via the five senses, until the whole of the body becomes alive with chi. As Yang Chen-Fu reminds us, "wherever the mind goes the chi will follow."⁶ This practice is a fundamental aspect of Fusion of the Five Senses and is perfected in Sealing of the Five Senses. In these practices, the senses remain aware of the body's every move, perceiving whether it is grounded or not, fast or slow, light or heavy, connected or disconnected, pushed or pulled.

The deeper art of Push Hands cannot be appreciated if the mind is largely centered in the head and removed from the body. Full understanding and the ability to listen require integration of the senses from the upper mind into the body's center—the lower tan tien. Again, we return to the importance of that ideal state in which our three minds have become one. The senses of the upper mind and the spirit of the heart mind unite with the lower mind into one force known as the Yi power. Yang Pan-Hou called this level of accomplishment, "conscious movement."⁷

Interpreting (*dong*) is the next stage of progress. It describes the ability to accurately perceive an opponent's structure and intention. What is there to interpret? Firstly, one needs to interpret the opponent's faults and anticipate which gate he intends to use. Possible faults include deviations from ideal Iron Shirt posture as well as the faults of pushing too hard, pushing too soft, resisting, and breaking contact.

If the adept can read an opponent's faults, this knowledge can lead to a winning move. Again this has to be at an instinctive bodily level that requires no thought. The practitioner must immediately interpret the opponent for breaks in

structure and adherence. For the practitioner to do this, his senses must invade the opponent and detect subtle realms of stiffness. He must notice when the opponent is using muscular force or overstepping structure. For example, if the elbow is stiff and close to the body, then it should immediately be pushed. If the arm is held too high, it should be lifted. If the opponent pushes too hard, the practitioner should follow that force and amplify it.

By following the opponent's energy, a body well versed and rehearsed in all of the eight gates is able to respond appropriately and immediately, rather than having to form an intention. By centering the body in the lower tan tien, with the only fixed point being the Central Thrusting Channel, the practitioner enables his body to respond as a passive yet conscious moveable vehicle. When it senses a gate being used, it will automatically use the appropriate counter. For example, if an opponent does a Rollback against me, then I will instinctively feel that force in my body, and before I know it my elbow or shoulder has struck. Wang Tsung-Yueh summarizes the attainment of interpreting with the following verse.

What is true interpreting energy? If your vision and hearing have no basis, it is difficult to achieve accuracy. When your vision takes in far and near, left and right; when your hearing takes in rising and falling, slow and fast; when your understanding of movement encompasses evading, returning, provoking, and completing; and when your sense of action embraces turning, exchanging, advancing, and retreating, then this is true interpreting.⁸

Here he emphasizes the ability of consciousness to move outside oneself and understand the thirteen postures.

COMMON FAULTS DURING PUSH HANDS

The faults—*butting (ding)*, *deficiency (bian)*, *losing contact (diu)*, and *resisting (kang)*—are those outward manifestations that prevent connecting, sticking, adhering, following, listening, and interpreting. In order for these faults to disappear, the practitioner must cultivate a steady growth in his use of chi, the integrated mind, and knowledge of past masters.

Butting

According to Yang Jwing-Ming, butting is when you use excessive force (fig. 7.14).⁹ This can occur within the set routine of the Push Hands sequence or in the event of an application. Within the routine, it is a gross error and is characteristic of a novice first learning the routine. Novices are reminded to use only enough

force to squash a hair to the skin. In applications, excessive force can be used by your opponent to topple you.

Of course, the grand masters not only topple their students but send them flying to the opposite side of the room; this could be regarded as excessive force. However, the nature of this force is a little different. The grand master senses that his opponent will topple with just one ounce. Up to this point he has used no excessive force and has applied the principle of following (*sui*). By a release of Fa Jin at this precise moment, however, like an explosion out of the most pure softness, the opponent is flung away.



Fig. 7.14. Pushing too hard, also known as butting

Butting also impedes listening. If a practitioner is pushing hard, then how can he read his opponent's structure? Listening and interpreting require the chi, which cannot coexist with tension. They are mutually exclusive. Often, the novice butts because he has a move in his monkey mind, but this opens him to incidental attack. He is already preoccupied and this manifests as stiffness.

Deficiency

Deficiency (*bian*) is the opposite state, when insufficient force is applied to exert an application or complete a routine. Deficiency means that the novice is trying too hard to relax. Instead of dilating and filling with chi, he sags and becomes like tofu. Consequently, his Iron Shirt is deficient and easily broken. A simple minor push on the elbow will collapse the structure and result in a fall (fig. 7.15).



Fig. 7.15. Loss of balance because of collapsed elbow

If insufficient force is used in an application via one of the eight gates, then the consequence will be that the opponent is not finished off. Instead, he is given a chance to retaliate and exert a counter move. It is likely in this case that the novice has not allowed the jin to pass unimpeded from the earth through the legs and waist to be emitted via the spinal column through the arms (finding the curve in the straight). Alternatively, fear or the monkey mind may have over-censored the application, resulting in ineffectual discharge power.

Losing Contact

Losing contact (*diu*) occurs when the practitioner disengages from the opponent during the usual routine of Push Hands (fig. 7.16). (For obvious reasons, it does not include the moment after an opponent has been toppled or has received a successful application of Fa Jin.) Losing contact is an obvious violation of the fundamental principles of adherence and following.



Fig. 7.16. Losing contact

For the novice, the root of losing contact may be lack of familiarity with the routine. In the intermediate student, it can be due to a lack of trust in one's ability to respond with a correct counter to an application initiated by an opponent. Losing contact also occurs when there are “hollows or projections”¹⁰ in the adept's Iron Shirt posture. The flow of energy is broken when the chi meets the blockage; it disengages as it does not have the ability to continue.

The entire Push Hands sequence must embrace the principles of Iron Shirt structure and the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung, not only in the routine but also in defense and attack. Remember also that the ability to interpret your opponent is more difficult when you disconnect. However, in a sparring situation—unlike in Push Hands—contact is intermittent. In this situation it is possible to interpret and follow your opponent without touch, but it requires greater skill.

Resisting

Resisting (*kang*) often has the same root cause as losing contact. It manifests itself as tension within the routine of Push Hands. This tension can appear in a range of positions and anatomical regions, including the wrist, elbow, shoulder, hips, knees, ankles, neck, chest, or waist. From inner observation during Iron Shirt training or sitting meditation, tension tends to collect in segments of the vertebral column and then manifests along acupuncture meridians or nerve root segments (see fig. 7.17 on page 202). Relieving tension in the vertebral column opens up the corresponding acupuncture meridians and corresponding myotomes.

To open the elbows and wrists, the adept needs to open C5 to T1. To open the

chest so that the scapulae round and the sternum sinks, T3 to T9 would need to open. Opening the thoracic and cervical vertebrae implies that the sacral and lumbar vertebrae would need to be pushed back first. Essentially, the Taoist practitioner becomes a master of each vertebra. This requires investment of time and consciousness during basic, intermediate, and advanced meditations ranging from Microcosmic Orbit and Fusion practices to Kan and Li practice.

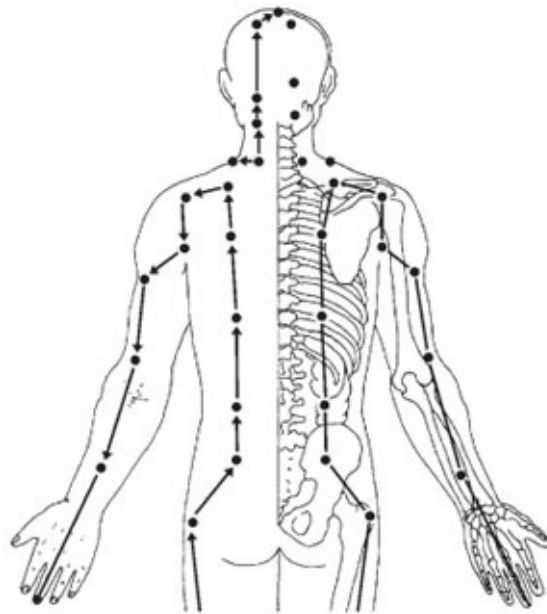


Fig. 7.17. Acupuncture channels may become blocked.

As shown in figure 7.18, each vertebra has a symbolic connection to phases of the moon and the various chakras. The sacrum governs the sexual chakra, the Ming Men governs the kidneys and the navel chakra, which in turn relates to the emotions of fear and gentleness. The vertebrae can also be related to the organs through the back Shu points. From this perspective, each of the main vertebrae governs one of the main organs. In order to open the vertebra, the organ itself must be balanced.^{*19}

Opening up the Governing Channel is a major step forward in reducing resistance, but ultimately the Central Thrusting Channel (*Chong Mai*) needs to open so that the Tai Chi Pole can function (see fig. 7.19 on page 204). The Tai Chi Pole reduces the need to resist as an opponent's force can be deflected without resisting.

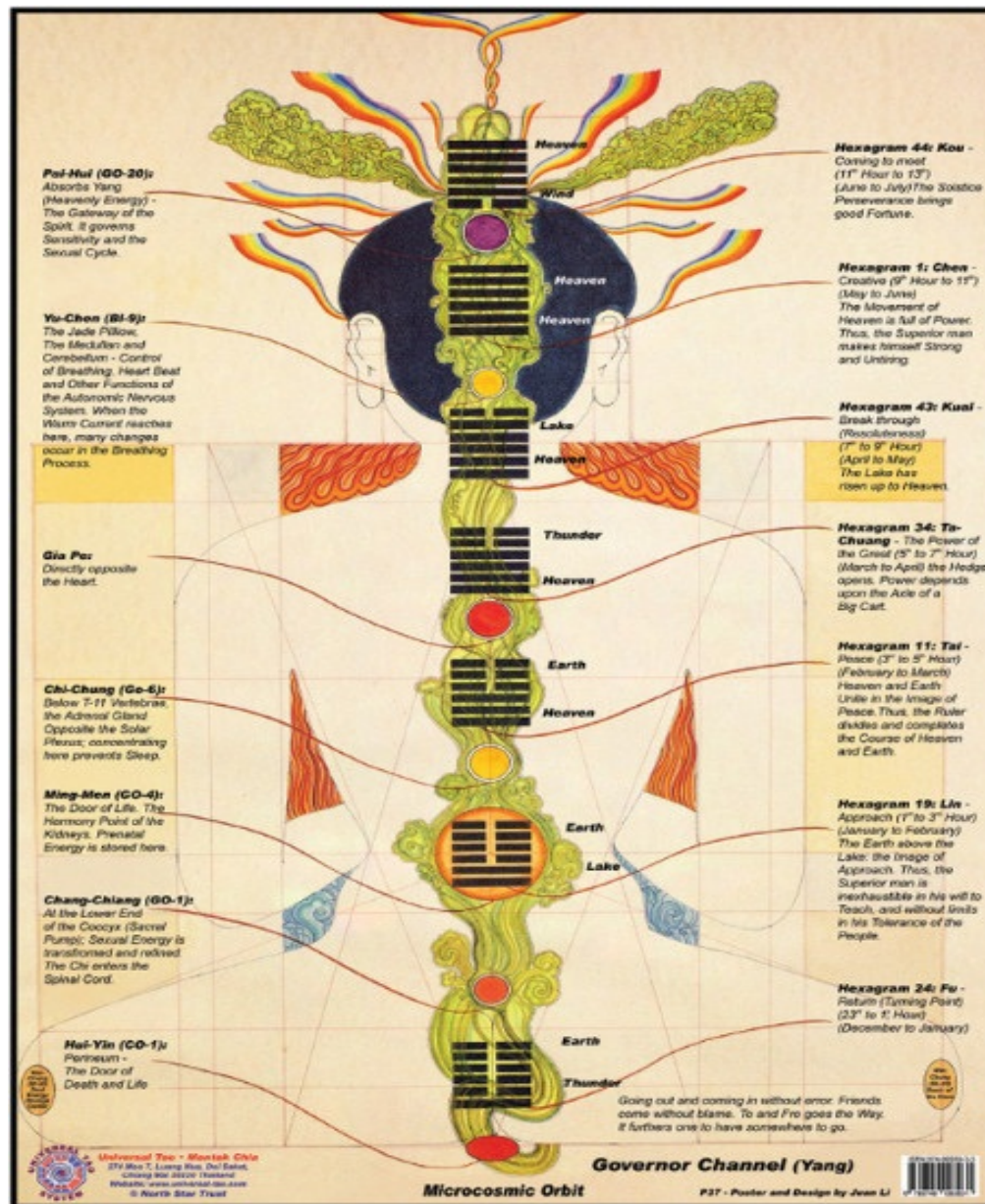


Fig. 7.18. Connections of the vertebrae

In addition to manifesting as blockages in the body, resisting can signify an insufficient ability to neutralize an opponent's force by sending it into the earth. This can be due to a lack of knowledge or a mistrust of one's own structure. Rather than trusting the chi, the novice uses Li power and muscular tension, which manifest as resistance.

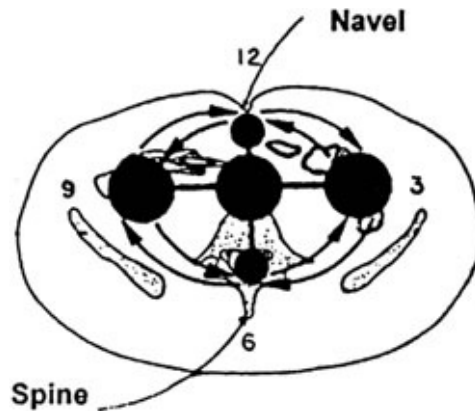


Fig. 7.19. Cross section of the waist with Central Thrusting Channel in the middle

STAGES OF AWARENESS

The practitioner goes through four stages of bodily awareness during Push Hands practice. The first is the novice stage, characterized by the absence of awareness of parts of the body or one's connection to the opponent. The second involves a partial opening of the channels, and following this stage is the recognition of yang and yin chi. Yang chi is unpleasant, vibratory, intense, and associated with the negative emotions. When tension begins to dissolve it usually passes through the yang state first. Yang chi is characteristic of the novice who is intense, pushy, and excited.

Yin is soft, pleasant, quiet, and associated with the positive emotions or virtues. Yin chi is associated with the master who is calm, soft, and peaceful. Therefore, when interacting with an opponent, allow tension to dissolve and the yin and yang to coexist and connect. This may be just another way of saying relax and be soft, but allow yang energetic states to connect with this softness.

The yin and yang chi can then divide into varied sensations that correspond with the five elements and the pakua. Each yin and yang has certain types of energies that are suited to varying circumstances, hence the concept of the eight gates or the eight forces. This sounds like the Taoist creation story and is repeated through all aspects of Chinese culture. However, Tan Meng-Hsien says that once this state is achieved, the opponent cannot resist your force and it enables explosive power.¹¹

8

Martial Applications of the Discharge Form

The martial way relies on the fact that universal forces feed the adept's meditation, which in turn feeds Chi Kung practice, Tai Chi, Push Hands, and, finally, Tai Chi boxing. Tai Chi boxing is thus an outward manifestation of the connections first made to the universal forces in meditation. This is how progress in meditation ultimately leads to progress in martial practice.

The martial applications of the discharge form revolve around five of the eight gates of Push Hands. Those five gates can be used as follows:

1. Opening Form
2. Back Turn
3. Ward Off (Peng)
4. Rollback (Lu)
5. Press (Ji)
6. Push (An)
7. Fair Lady Works the Shuttle (Lieh)
8. Circle before Ward Off



Opening Form

This form, which is similar to the silk reeling forms, can be used for multiple blocks in the Tai Chi boxing combat scenario (fig. 8.1). It has already been discussed as a technical exercise in chapter 4. This move trains the rotation of the waist around the central axis, as well as the use of the Lu force to divert and suck in an opponent's energy. It is very useful for sucking in an opponent's punch, borrowing the opponent's energy, then charging the tan tien and returning with jin.



Fig. 8.1. Opening form application of Cross Hands technique



Back Turn

This twist is generated from the tan tien. It can be a response to a back attack. The coordination is similar to a ballet or dance turn, except that the spin prepares the Ward Off. The arms circle, and can be used to lock an arm, grab a kick, or simply prepare for a Ward Off (fig. 8.2).

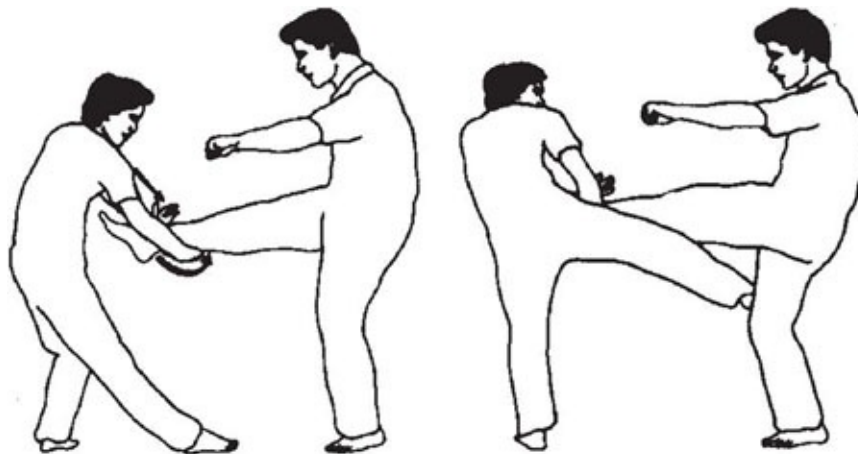


Fig. 8.2. Leg grab after back turn



Ward Off

The Ward Off has been extensively described in *The Inner Structure of Tai Chi*.^{[*20](#)} It relies primarily on the Peng force to redirect an opponent's force. It can be used as a neck breaker or converted to a Palm Strike (fig. 8.3).

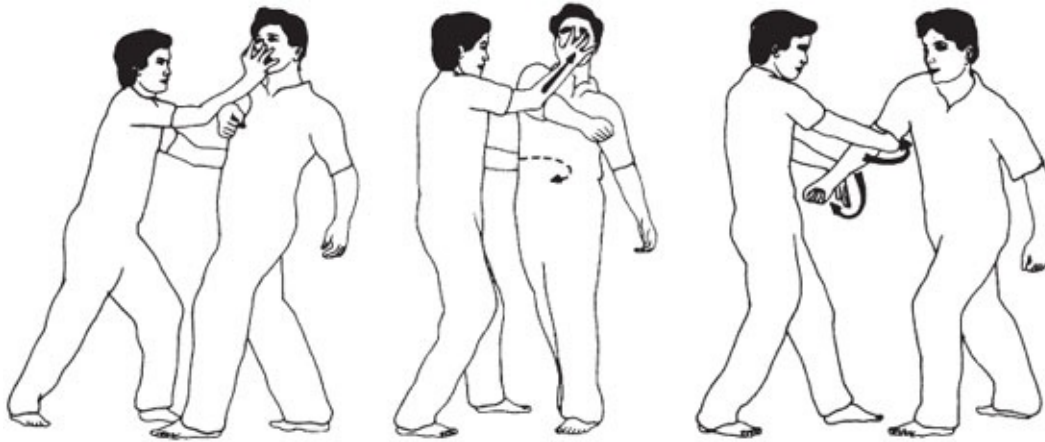


Fig. 8.3. Breaking the structure and alignment is a major goal in Tai Chi applications.

A leg cut can be added to the Ward Off to help break an opponent's balance (fig. 8.4). The leg push is used to break the opponent's structure at a lower level to facilitate less force above. This is obeying the fundamental principle of setting up "four ounces to deflect a thousand pounds."¹ Leg cutting and leg locks are a more dominant feature of Chen Push Hands.

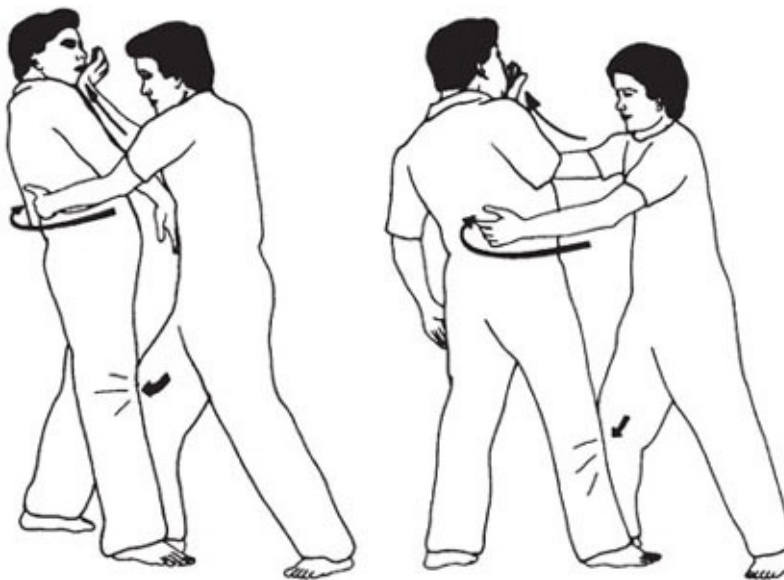


Fig. 8.4. Trap opponent's front leg with your front leg, causing his knee to lock and hyperextend.

For a further variation, the top hand can be taken higher and turned into a descending Palm Strike (fig. 8.5). The movement is more characteristic of the Wu Style offensive Palm Strike, and was apparently Yang Chen-Fu's favorite strike. This is because the palm has a descending vector, which, when combined with a dropping of the body, imparts maximum momentum transfer. If the leading hand engages the opponent, force can be borrowed and used to charge up the tan tien prior to the release of Fa Jin.



Fig. 8.5. Descending Palm Strike as a variation of the Ward Off



Rollback

The usual function of the Rollback is to absorb the opponent's strike so that Fa Jin can be released via one of the eight gates after that. However, the Rollback can be an attack in itself. In this context, it can uproot and topple an opponent on its own (see fig. 8.6 on page 210).

In the sparring situation, an inward parry serves the same function as Lu in Push Hands. Like the opening form, the Rollback can also be doubled up, combining two forceful sucking-in parries (see fig. 8.7 on page 210). Such a combination occurs in the Tai Chi boxing move called the Willow Tree, which is discussed in more detail on page 213.



Fig. 8.6. Uprooting an opponent with Lu



Fig. 8.7. Downward parry



Press

The Press is described as the Ji gate in chapter 3 and in the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung. The beauty of this move lies not so much in its final external form but in its ability to emerge from a disadvantaged position. For example, if your arm has been pulled across by an opponent, this position can easily be converted by turning your waist and pressing against the outstretched arm (fig. 8.8).

In an attack situation, the Press can be used against an opponent's upper arm.



Fig. 8.8. Lu performed by your opponent being countered with a Press



Combining Ward Off with Press

1. Gently deflect your opponent's right punch to your right (fig. 8.9a).
2. Once your opponent's force is neutralized, join your right palm to your left wrist (fig. 8.9b).
3. Guide your opponent's force downward. Absorb it into your rear leg, gathering energy for the Press (fig. 8.9c).
4. Release your stored energy from your rear leg and throw your opponent back using the Press. Your front leg can simultaneously attack and trap his leg (fig. 8.9d).

The Press is also useful after an upward deflection of an opponent's strike. Here, it is an ideal strike for attacking the face.



Fig. 8.9. Ward Off and Press

☀ ***The Willow Tree***

The Press/Ji can be modified for boxing situations, such that the two arms are delivered almost simultaneously as a back fist and a punch (fig. 8.10). This technique is called the Willow Tree because of its relaxed flowing movements akin to a gust of wind passing through the loosely hanging branches of a willow tree. Here the Rollback/Lu is delivered as two inward parries, and is followed by a back fist and strike. The movements are not separate, but are done in one continuous action. They are mere manifestations of the circle of energy that returns and is then emitted. Jin is included in that return, and it is a manifestation of true internal power.



Fig. 8.10. Press changed to a back fist and strike



Push

Many martial artists consider the Push to be too soft, because it merely moves the opponent away. Yet there are many self-defense situations in which inflicting serious injury is not the goal. In these situations, the Push can be combined with skilled Fa Jin to throw an opponent several meters away. As discussed in the last chapter, the Push Hands has an inner trick: the practitioner can lock the opponent's elbow. As one side resists, the other hand can apply more force. The beauty of the Two-Hand Push is that with delicate listening, the move has more Jin behind it, and the practitioner can sense where the opponent's body is stiff and which way the force is moving.

OTHER PUSH HANDS MOVES ADAPTED FOR BOXING

Like the above applications, the Push Hands moves can be modified for boxing. The Double Push can be replaced by a Double Palm Strike, which can be executed upward, level, or downward (fig. 8.11).



Fig. 8.11. Double Palm Strike



Fair Lady Works the Shuttle

On the surface, this move consists of a fairly straightforward upward block and a Palm Strike to the chest or face. However, with more sophistication, the form can take on broader applications. For instance, the blocking arm can be used to defend against any strike originating from the opponent on the same side (meaning the right hand of the practitioner and the left hand of the opponent) (fig. 8.12). The striking palm can also block any strike originating on the opponent's same side (therefore the practitioner's left and the opponent's right side).²¹ This is similar to the flexibility of the applications of the Single Whip in the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung. The power of this form comes from the splitting of the gate or Lieh force, in which the two vectors explode in two different directions. Each force is generated by the rotation of the tan tien around the Central Thrusting Channel using discharge power.



Fig. 8.12. Application of Fair Lady Works the Shuttle, blocking a same side strike from opponent

A further variation on the Lieh gate is the Bird's Tail (fig. 8.13). In this form, the split also creates a simultaneous circular motion. The rear arm blocks a roundhouse punch while the forward arm prepares to block a lower punch using a Tiger Claw Palm. The power stolen from the opponent's roundhouse punch is returned in a Double Strike to the opponent's chest.



Circle before Ward Off

As in the Tan Tien Form described in *The Inner Structure of Tai Chi*, it is important in this form to activate the arm tendons and prepare the tan tien to release its power. By a small rotation, the arms activate the arm tendon/tan tien connection. Another way of describing this is activating the Iron Shirt structure to prepare for Fa Jin (fig. 8.14).



Fig. 8.13. Bird's Tail



Fig. 8.14. Arms in ready position following the small circle

This circling action can be used as an external lock on an opponent's arm (fig. 8.15). These locks are known as *jin na*. Using the Tsai Force in this lock position while simultaneously controlling the opponent's elbow, wrist, or shoulder with the other arm, the practitioner can lever the opponent down to the ground.



Fig. 8.15. Lock on wrist and elbow

SUMMARY

When the eight gates of Push Hands are applied to Tai Chi boxing techniques,

the principles of discharge power and Push Hands apply. By being relaxed yet aware, the adept is able to borrow power from the opponent to activate the Iron Shirt (bow and arrow) in his own body. Even if there is no physical connection, the impression or sense of the opponent's power can be drawn into the adept's structure. It is neutralized in the earth, and then begins its return as a continuation of movement within a circle.

When the jin journeys through the body, it does so in a very simple and predictable way. Thus, whether one uses the shoulder, elbow, or hands, it does not matter. It also does not matter if the hand makes the shape of a fist, spear, or claw. Furthermore it does not matter whether the move is an attacking or a defending one. These variations are mere dressings on the base of discharge power. Obviously, each of these variations is better suited for some applications than for others, but the foundation of each variation is the same. After some time, the adept allows all techniques to become one technique. This, of course, mirrors the primary reversal of Taoist creation theory—the return of multiplicity to unity.

9

Home Practice

Your home is the playground for your self-cultivation and progress toward learning to discharge jin. Home practice encompasses two aspects of your training: the first is a training schedule that you develop at home for when you are not participating in a workshop or retreat. The second is the progress toward your particular and unique unfolding as you develop your jin or discharge power. In this second regard, “home practice” comes to signify the cultivation of your individual journey within the internal Taoist martial arts.

This chapter will discuss this second aspect first and end with practical suggestions for a routine at home.

HOME PRACTICE WITHIN

Home practice is the avenue for sustained improvement in your unique individual direction. Ultimately, each practitioner creates his or her own goals and destiny, but it is important to recognize that achieving goals at a superficial level may not be concordant with your ultimate destiny. As you become whole, foreknowledge of your destiny is likely to be more accurate.

In Taoist terms, becoming whole involves integration of all energies in order to experience the source, or Original Chi. These energies can be understood as the five elements or as the duality of yin and yang. In either case, the individual energies correspond to particular portions or aspects of the psyche—what Jung referred to as *archetypes* or *psychophysical energies*.¹ The student’s aim is to understand, balance, and coordinate these energies within herself. Thus she embarks on a particular journey, trusting that a higher force will lead her through the maze, arranging each experience and trial according to her needs.

Multiple teachers and masters are parts of this maze, hence the adage “when the student is ready the teacher will appear.”² Therefore, it is important to take away any attachment or anxiety about having a single teacher for one’s entire journey. There may be one teacher who is right for a long stretch of your journey, and others who serve in that role for just a short time. Some teachers may be there primarily to teach you a negative lesson. Unfortunately, there are no easy lessons; what is most important is to remain devoted to your inner

development.

Therefore, it is important to relax and accept your progress, your current teacher and teachings, and to allow the mystery of Tao to reveal itself as it will in its own particular way. To rush is to cause yourself harm. Conversely, to not seize opportunities as they arise is also counterproductive. Making decisions about such alternatives is often a matter for the heart or intuitive gut feeling. Within the Universal Healing Tao framework, decision-making resides within the heart (middle tan tien) or the lower tan tien. It is important to remain cognizant of what excites the heart and what faults we project onto others. What we like to teach is often what we need to learn. Stay mobile and fluid and let the mystery of the “mother” draw you closer.^{*22}

In internal training, new positive experiences are initially transmitted by the teacher to the student. It is often in the master’s presence that a student first experiences chi or other revelations.^{†23} For a while, this dependence is necessary, as the energetic blueprint is passed on from master to student. However, at some stage this dependence becomes counterproductive. The student remains subject to the teacher’s presence rather than developing on his own. In this situation, practicing alone is the necessary correction. The student should seek to gain his own experiences by his own methods.

Many of my Universal Tao students are too dependant on my formulas and voice to achieve inner experiences; they forget that developing these experiences on their own is also important. I advise these students to let go, reminding them of the Doris Day song, “*Que sera sera* / whatever will be will be.” Often progress requires simply that—letting go and just observing and following the energetic experiences inside. Each training session is different. The chi dances according to its own particular tune. Hear the tune and dance. Allow the Tao to unfold in its own particular way.

At times, it will seem to one of my students that a particular formula of mine or one handed down from my teacher needs to be questioned. The willingness to question or even reject the teachings of one’s teacher can be thought of as a rite of passage. In order to embrace the Tao, one needs to seemingly reject it. In order to achieve an experience of a particular practice, one needs to not be too desperate for it. Paradoxically, the process of rejection and nonattachment allows the deeper meaning and experience to appear.

I am not saying to naively reject the practices. What I’m suggesting is that you find a healthy balance between the formulas and your own unwinding or progress. Question, argue, reflect, and attempt the formulas that are described in the Universal Healing Tao texts. Allow your deep intention to create the

unfolding and revelation of the path required.

Remember that inner development goes hand in hand with this kind of “home practice.” Bruce Kumar Frantzis, a reputable Western internal martial arts practitioner, describes the process this way:

Critical to attaining real excellence in internal martial arts is the ability to practice for long periods of time on your own. It is most often during these solitary practice sessions that you find the true sources of your inner strength and discover and correct your most dangerously vulnerable weak points.⁴

DEVELOPING A HOME PRACTICE

There are five features of progress in developing discharge power. These are:

- Merging of practices
- Becoming more yin
- Letting go of control to chi
- Yi (Integrated Mind)
- Shen (Spirit) power

Principles of Progress

There is no doubt that progress relates to the gradual reduction in chi blockages or areas of stiffness in the body. Sites of stiffness originate in the spine and manifest themselves within the limbs. Blockages of the sacrum and lumbar region make the hips and legs tight. Blockages in the cervical and upper thoracic vertebrae make the arms tight. Progress is the gradual unveiling of tension to provide the practitioner with an open spine/Governing Channel (see fig. 9.1 on page 224).

For many, the spine will open during retreat—when they are away from a tension-producing life. In the milieu of relaxation, spiritual contemplation, appropriate food, and lack of stimulants or sedatives, the body begins to open up. This opening is further accentuated in the presence of a master or teacher who transmits this state to his students. For more experienced students, the spine may open with some warm-ups and preliminary meditation. Finally, the spine stays open most of the time. With this open spine there are open kidneys (Ming Men), an open heart, a long neck, and a “suspended head top.”⁵

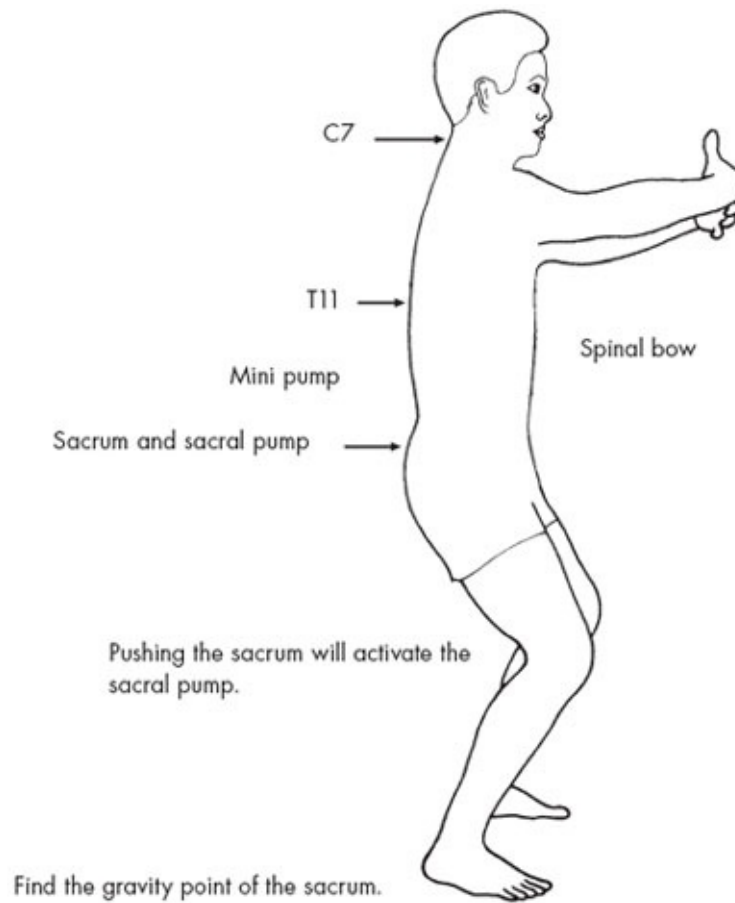


Fig. 9.1. Iron Shirt structure with key points along the spine

Coincident with this opening of the body—and particularly the channels of the Microcosmic Orbit—is an inflation of the body that originates in the lower tan tien and expands to the middle and upper tan tiens (fig. 9.2). The body inflates with chi from the inside out. Again, this experience is likely to happen on retreat first, and it can then be cultivated by individual students in their everyday lives. The gradual opening of the Microcosmic Orbit and the tan tiens in everyday life involves the same principles that are used to open them in meditation. However, opening them into everyday life means that the process needs to be integrated at a very deep level. The whole being becomes more and more soft, or in Taoist terms, more yin. At the same time, the more “substantial”⁶ or yang energies are reduced. More is achieved by being gentle, kind, open, and loving rather than being impatient, forceful, attached, or too determined. More is achieved by being soft and placid and by doing little, than by intervening and forcing an outcome. In essence, the adept learns that the true path to controlling one’s energies lies in doing little and being soft and kind to oneself. In addition to creating an internal milieu that is saturated by these virtues, a new system of internal governance is created.

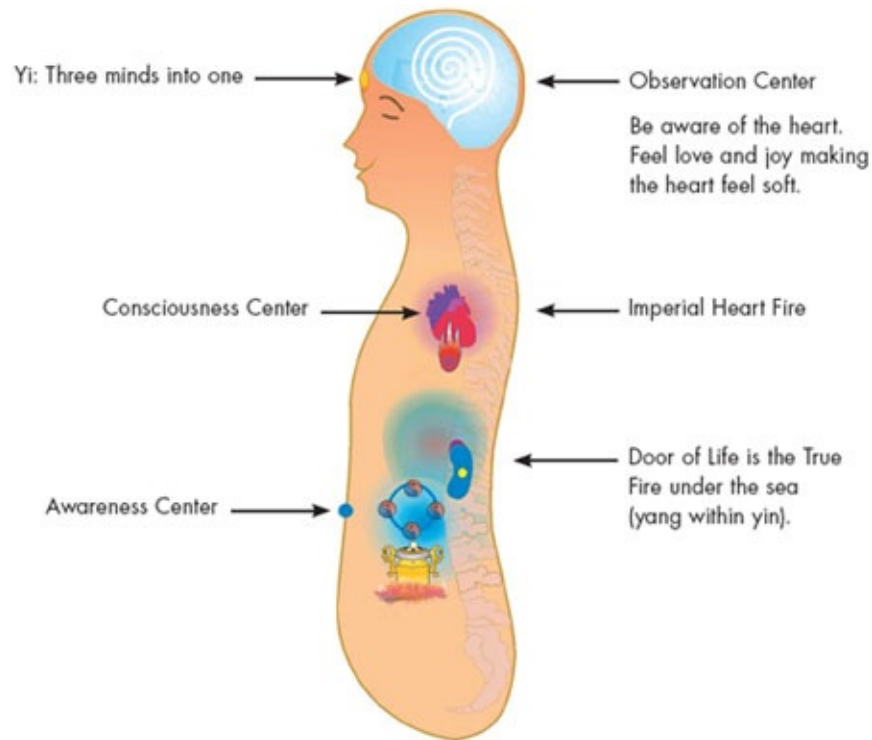


Fig. 9.2. Three tan tiens merging into Yi power

The new system of governance is the release of control of the monkey mind to Yi power—an integrated mind held by the heart (*xin*). The body holds the chi, which moves the limbs around during Tai Chi practice. However, the chi lacks knowledge, so the heart/ mind must direct the martial moves. Ultimately, it is the spirit that controls the heart and is therefore the final commander. To some, this may sound like traditional Chinese medicine fundamentalism. However, there is a tangible experiential reality for the adept searching for Fa Jin; the journey provides distinct physical sensations and experiences, some of which are described below.

The adept gradually relinquishes initial control of movement to the chi. The arms and legs have to feel like they are moved by a faint breeze of chi directing them “hither and thither.” If the student gets impatient, then the chi will not move the limb—the monkey mind will. The trouble is that the monkey mind is poor at coordination and can never take the student to the point of learning Fa Jin.

In the next stage of experience, the tan tiens start to move the limbs, which have been mobilized by the chi. This is felt as both a pulling and pushing of the limbs by the three major tan tiens. One can even feel the tan tiens contracting and expanding as they direct the movements of the limbs.

Finally, it is the spirit that begins to orchestrate the body from above.²⁴ The

spirit is worn like a cloak that embraces the flesh to carry out its will. It is often perceived as a light from the spiritual body or perhaps from a higher plane of existence. In Fa Jin, some practitioners experience a sudden expansion of the tan tien that is triggered by a light from above. In order to have this sensation, control of the body must be truly released from the usual intellectual mind. Maximal opening of the Microcosmic Orbit and the three tan tiens can occur only when the three minds are fully integrated.

GRADING THE STUDENT'S PROGRESS

The progress of a Tai Chi or Fa Jin practitioner is characterized by this process of letting go of the intellectual mind and embodying the integrated body/mind—a state open to direction by the spirit—with concomitant opening of the tan tiens and the Microcosmic Orbit. These achievements provide a framework for understanding the various methods for grading progress that have been developed in the arts of Tai Chi and Fa Jin.

The Grading System of Chen XiaoWang

One grading system developed by Chen XiaoWang describes five stages. (Chen XiaoWang is an accomplished living Grand Master of the Chen style, and for his lineage he is named one of the “Four Tigers” of the art.)^{*25} This grading system is particularly relevant as the modern Chen style has more emphasis on Fa Jin than modern Yang style practices.

Chen XiaoWang's five levels are summarized below.² For the reader's benefit, his framework of required skill sets is explained by vocabulary from the Universal Healing Tao system.

In the first level, the student is learning the principles of Iron Shirt posture. Hence postures are often incorrect with excessive forward, backward, and even sideways bending. In both static and moving postures, the tan tien and body are relatively empty of chi. Tai Chi movements are either stiff or performed with excessive or deficient force. The passage of chi or power through the body as taught in Tai Chi Chi Kung is incorrect. Martial applications may be learned intellectually, but due to all the above reasons, they will be performed poorly. In terms of substantial and insubstantial energies, they are in essence 90 percent yang and 10 percent yin.

At the second level, the student begins to feel the passage of chi/jin through the spine and body as per the fundamental form of Tai Chi Chi Kung. The student begins to grasp the coordination between body and mind, which is demonstrated when the internal closing of the tan tiens matches the closing of

the limbs. The student begins to feel that all the tan tiens can pulsate, open, and close in a rhythm. The skill required for Push Hands remains inadequate, with constant butting, deficiency, stiffness, and loss of contact. The principle of following has not yet been learned, so attacking first is often the way that a second-level practitioner attempts a win. This level is characterized by 20 percent yin.

The third level involves the transition from gross motor movements to energetic ones. Thus the big circle described by the waist or trunk can be replaced by an internal energetic circle of energy. A movement that involves returning, turning, and moving forward now appears on the outside as a one-inch punch. No returning or turning is seen by an observer. The student now begins to understand that in order to mobilize and coordinate the chi, he must let go and govern through the heart/mind connection via the spirit. Likewise, to control the breath means allowing the self to breathe naturally, although in Fa Jin training, some direct control of the breath is necessary at this stage. At this level, chi is beginning to appear in the tan tien. In Push Hands, a practitioner of this level is beginning to internally understand the use of the eight gates.

The fourth level is characterized by the ability to practice the Tai Chi form with correct spirit and intention. Like true shadow boxing, every move encounters an imaginary opponent in a process that engages the intention of the form. The student begins to understand the art of Push Hands. There is a lack of intellectual thought or preempting. The body/mind follows the principles of connection, linking, adhering, and following (*zhan, lian, nian, sui*). The student demonstrates smooth transitions between attack and defense, with appropriate suspension (*duan*) and reconnection (*jie*). The four faults of butting, deficiency, breaking, and stiffness begin to disappear. This level is described as 40 percent yin.

At the fifth level, the spiritual, cosmic, and earth connections are tangible and important in everyday practice. Fa Jin is accomplished by the appropriate coupling of the substantial and insubstantial (yang and yin) energies. Listening (*ting*) and interpreting (*dong*) are highly developed, to the point where an attack to any part of the body is readily understood, and appropriate use of Fa Jin via the eight gates is initiated.

At this level, the body and tan tien are balanced with an internal energy that is 50 percent yin and 50 percent yang.

John Chang's Grading System

John Chang teaches a system for grading the progress of jin that is part of the

Mo Pai tradition. This system includes seventy-two levels of attainment, which the immortal Chang SanFeng is considered to have achieved.

The first level is the appearance of ill-defined chi in the lower tan tien. In the second level, the chi becomes stronger. In the fourth level, the yin and yang can be coupled (fig. 9.3).

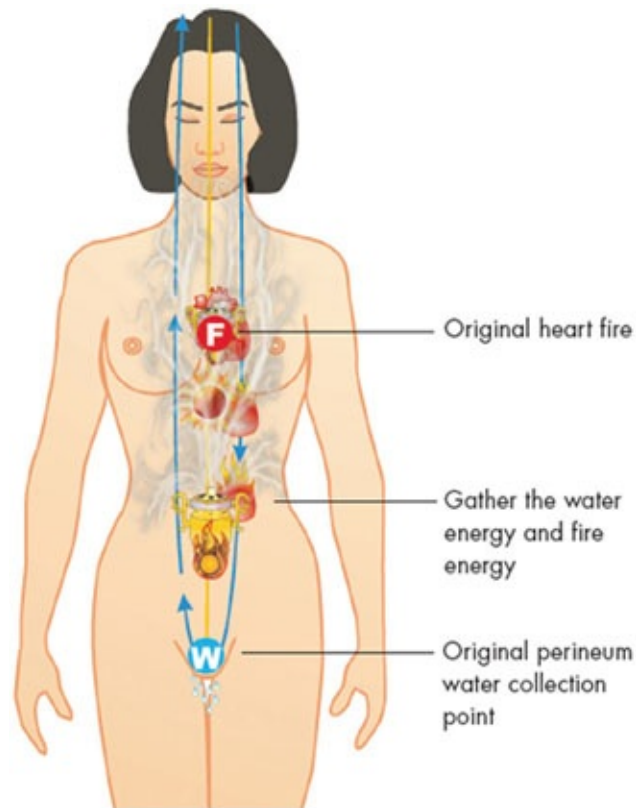


Fig. 9.3. Coupling of yin and yang (water and fire) in Kan and Li practice

The Grading System of Glenn Newth

A third system, which has some similarities to the one described by Chen XiaoWang, is outlined by Glenn Newth in his book *Hwa Yu Tai Chi Chuan*.⁸ Newth describes level one as the stage in which students use muscle power alone. Because the monkey mind is controlling movement, the muscles are not well coordinated and work against each other.

The next level is called the “Bone Level.” At this stage excessive muscle tension has dissolved, so that gravity can now connect to the skeleto-ligamentous structure (fig. 9.4). At this level, fear has left the body and the muscles work synergistically with, rather than against, each other. A sense of dance prevails, with graceful and lively movements. At the third level, chi, the tan tiens, and the Central Thrusting Channel are all engaged in movement. At the final level, the spirit governs the chi, which in turn coordinates the muscles and structure. This

is the final letting go.

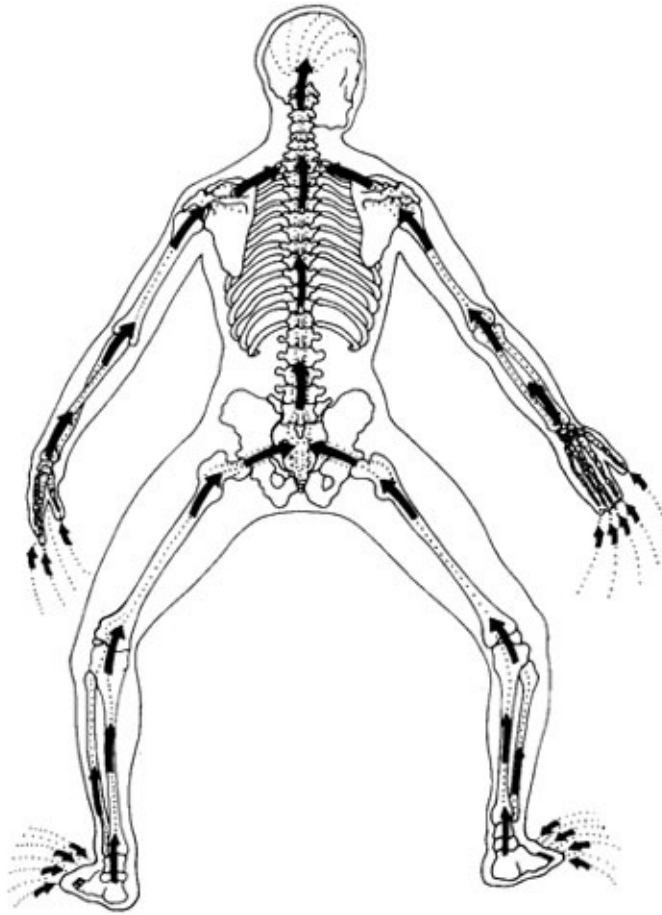


Fig. 9.4. Skeleton Bone Breathing

THE DEVELOPMENT OF A UNIVERSAL HEALING TAO GRADING SYSTEM

Below, we have created a system for evaluating the development of discharge power in terms of Universal Healing Tao practices. The system is comprised of four levels, each of which includes specific skill sets developed in Universal Healing Tao practices. It is important to recognize that students must train in other Universal Healing Tao practices to learn these skill sets before they appear in Fa Jin practice. The primary avenue for progress is meditation and the march toward the mystical experience of unity.

In this grading system, the four levels can be applied equally across four disciplines: Meditation, Iron Shirt, Tai Chi, and Push Hands practices. Each discipline will be subdivided into the four levels and will include aspects of internal and external appraisal (except meditation practice, which can be evaluated only on an internal level).

The four levels are the same for Meditation, Iron Shirt, Tai Chi, and Push Hands practice. In level one, the student uses intellect and muscle power (Li) alone. In level two, the student can perceive chi in the master's presence, within a group, or while on retreat. At home, the student may need audiotapes to assist his awareness of chi. In level three, the student can generate chi and achieve high levels of meditation using his own skills. Most skills are learned at this level, and the student is a competent teacher. However, the opening of the chi channels and the accomplishment of the integrated mind is still episodic at this level. Level four is the master level, wherein the adept is openly integrated most of the day and perhaps even during sleep. This level is characterized by a complete letting go, so that it is the spirit that governs thought, practice, and movement.

Unfortunately, a student really needs to get to level four to even begin to exercise discharge power. All the principles of Iron Shirt, Push Hands, Tai Chi, and Meditation have to be learned up to the letting go stage for the practice of even low-level Fa Jin. From there, Fa Jin practitioners can be divided into those that use jin, chi, or shen. These levels correspond to the lower, middle, and upper tan tiens. Successful Fa Jin demands the competence of a master.

Meditation

Because meditation is an internal practice, there are not many external markers that can be used to assess a student's progress. As in the other disciplines, progress is marked by the ability to become more yin, to open the Microcosmic Orbit, to fill the tan tiens, and to make a connection to the spiritual body from above (fig. 9.5). In Kan and Li practice, for instance, the student learns to invert and couple the yin (insubstantial) and yang (substantial) energies. Within the various high level meditations, there are moments of sudden expansion of the tan tien, which releases a chill, shake, or even an orgasm throughout the body.

With progress, the student applies these meditational experiences from workshops or retreats to her everyday practice of Tai Chi Chi Kung, Push Hands, and the Yang Discharge Form. In level 4, the channels are open most of the day and even during sleep. The expansion of chi from the tan tien is harnessed for Fa Jin practice.



Fig. 9.5. The Microcosmic Orbit

MEDITATION LEVELS IN SUMMARY FORM

LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
No perception of chi	Perception of chi in presence of master or on retreat	Ability to open channels with chi in home practice	Channels open most of the day in everyday life—even in sleep
However, student can visualize and imagine formulas	Learns Microcosmic Orbit, Fusion practices, and Kan and Li practice, and can practice them successfully on retreat	Student can practice Microcosmic Orbit, Fusion practices, and Kan and Li practice alone	Formulae are let go.
	Reliant on formulas	Formulas begin to blend into one practice	Practices become one and are spontaneous
		Generates skill for Fa Jin	Generates skill for Fa Jin

Iron Shirt

External Assessment. External assessment relies on the assessor’s interpretation of the adept’s adherence to fundamental principles. As the student progresses into level 2 of Iron Shirt practice, she can successfully remove the “hollows and projections”⁹ that are symptoms of chi blockage. In other words, she has at this point overcome stiffness and removed chi blockages from the spine and the

corresponding affected limbs. She thus requires fewer corrections to her form, such as dropping the elbows, sinking the chest, opening the lumbar spine, tucking in the chin, *etc.*

In level 3, the student can take pushes from all directions and in multiple postures (Embracing the Tree, Holding the Golden Urn, Golden Turtle, *etc.*). With progress, the student needs less and less time to warm up before being able to take a push. She has fewer bad days as her structure becomes consistently strong. Eventually, she can take pushes from different opponents of varying heights and strengths. In level 4, pushes can be taken from multiple persons at once (see fig. 9.6 on page 234).

The principles of Iron Shirt inform the Tai Chi and Push Hands forms, so that every move begins to carry the foundation principles. Iron Shirt teaches students how to inflate the tan tien so that force can pass through the structure, thereby creating the foundation for release of Fa Jin via the eight gates. Furthermore, it is in Iron Shirt practice that the practitioner learns to borrow the opponent's energy and use it to charge the tan tien, thereby improving the quality of his/ her structure.



Fig. 9.6. Correct Iron Shirt posture withstands multiple-person pushes.

Internal Assessment. The best judge of your development is of course yourself. Your senses can easily detect stiffness and stagnation of chi as well as smoothness and power. With progress into level 3, areas of stiffness disappear with minimal warming up. In time, you find a more yin approach to forming an Iron Shirt posture, and learn to respect the power of yin energies in accessing and sustaining the Iron Shirt. Yin energies appear in the body more often, like sensations of peace (*an jin*), unaroused sexual chi, love, openness, and so on (fig. 9.7). Tension or blockages disappear and you can accept yang energies—like fear, anger, and anxiety—alongside the yin energies in your body.



Fig. 9.7. Love and peace (an jin)

Integration of chi, the bodily senses, and the mind occurs with progress. In level 3, the body begins to think and respond by itself. As an opponent pushes, the practitioner's intellect remains dormant while the body itself decides how to react to a push. In level 4, the integration occurs beyond the body and manifests the interplay of heaven, earth, and spirit. Individual identity becomes lost in something greater.

IRON SHIRT LEVELS IN SUMMARY FORM

LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
Uses muscular effort. Uses the monkey mind or intellect. No perception of chi.	Beginning to relax and learning to work with gravity. Can use chi in presence of master or on retreat.	Ability to open channels with chi in home practice. Three minds become one mind.	Channels open most of the day in everyday life—even in sleep. Three minds merge with spirit.
Multiple blockages in channels	"Hollows and projections" disappear on retreat or in presence of master	Good Iron Shirt can be experienced alone but still requires warm-up.	Iron Shirt with adept most of the day
	Reliant on teacher's presence to maintain structure. Tolerates pushing in a couple of postures.	Iron Shirt structure beginning to become second nature. Can tolerate pushes in all classic postures.	Iron Shirt appears naturally in all postures. Can tolerate very strong pushes from multiple opponents.
90% yang. Postures are tense throughout.	70% yang, 30% yin. Learning to find power of relaxation (<i>fang sung</i>). Tension still appears in postures.	60% yang, 40% yin. Tension disappearing. Utilizes yang (shaking, intense chi sensations) and yin energies.	50% yang, 50% yin. Balanced energies prevail and almost no tension remains in the body.
		Generates skill for Fa Jin	Generates skill for Fa Jin

Tai Chi Form

External Assessment. The Tai Chi student's form is assessed according to how completely the chi is allowed to move the limbs in an integrated manner. Initially, because the structure is fragmented, power can only be generated by isolated limbs and is very weak. With training, power from the earth learns its correct path, and the chi begins to move the limbs at a slow constant pace that is graceful and has no beginning or end. Yang Chen-Fu says:

The root is in the feet, it is issued through the legs, controlled by the waist and expressed in the hands. From the feet to the legs to the waist there must be a continual flow of Chi. When the hands, waist and feet move, the spirit (*shen*) of the eyes move in unison. This then, can be called the "Unity of the Upper and Lower Body." If just one part is not synchronized, there will be confusion.¹⁰

This principle of integration is drummed into all Universal Healing Tao

students right from the beginning: all parts of the body move in a coordinated manner when chi softly progresses through the legs, spine, and upper limbs. If there are no channel blockages, there is no need to force the chi anywhere. Forcing can result in jerky movements and in leaning too far forward or backward.

The breath mirrors stillness and the mastery of the foundation principles. In the beginning, the breath is all over the place. Next, the practitioner has enough control to inhale with closing movements and exhale with outward movements. Later, with further relaxation, the breath is even and mostly silent. It is coordinated with movement such that the phenomenon of whole-body breathing appears.²⁶ Finally, the spirit is engaged and the breath spontaneously mirrors the primordial energy of each form. In a Yang slow style the breath may be quiet, while in a discharge form the adept may produce sudden loud exhalations.

With deeper understanding of the form, each posture can be seen to capture the essence of its application. Initially the adept is caught up in relaxing and focusing on the chi, and sometimes he needs to close his eyes to be able to do this. However, when the entire organism lets go to the spirit, the practitioner becomes able to incorporate all the aspects of breath, form, jin, and martial application. Often the spirit can be seen in his eyes.

Internal Assessment. To enable the complex coordination required for Tai Chi, the adept must let go. With progress, you bring less and less monkey-mind intention into the form. The mind relinquishes its stronghold to the wisdom of the heart and the intuition of the gut. This is transformed into actual physical movement when the tan tiens expand and contract in response to opening and closing movements. Gradually, movement is relinquished to the spiritual body. You will feel lighter and more coordinated, with the sense that a puppeteer is moving your body around. The strings are, of course, the chi. The puppeteer is the spiritual body, which has connections beyond the comprehension of the intellect, and which enables the magic of internal discharge power to emerge.

Jerky movements, rising and falling, and stooping forward and backward are all manifestations of poor Iron Shirt, using too much monkey mind, and not allowing the chi to direct the limbs. Continuity is based on a deep memorization of the form that is integrated to all levels of mind. Because the chi directs the movement, there are no stops and starts. Chi is ever flowing and never ceases! As Chang SanFeng puts it, “Tai Chi Chuan is like a great river rolling on unceasingly.”¹

There is a happy connection with the soft yang energies from the heavens and

the pleasurable yin energies from the earth. These feed directly into the tan tien like the breath. When you are about to exert a strike, the tan tien expands with yang chi. In the closing or withdrawal phase of a form, the tan tiens contract and pull the limbs in via the medium of yin chi. It inevitably becomes a dance of the Tao—the interplay of yin and yang, humming with the stillness of the Primordial or Original Chi. The dance becomes, as its meaning declares, the “Supreme Ultimate.”

When complex movements are entertained in parts of the body that have blocked chi, the breath will be erratic. As the mind settles and the body relaxes, the breath can coordinate with movement. A good way to encourage this coordination is to inhale during closing movements and exhale during strikes, kicks, and outward movements. Eventually, the breath marries the body and we enable whole-body breathing, in which the breath supports and synergizes movement. During whole-body breathing, especially in the Yang, Wu, and Sun styles, the breath is very quiet. To an outside observer there is no breath, but internally one feels the whole body—and each form—breathe with movement. Ultimately, this is carried into the top level of Tai Chi Chuan practice, in which the breath is controlled by the forces beyond the individual.

The applications of the form are an essential component of Tai Chi Chuan. Without meaning, each posture becomes empty and too yin. The forms should each embody their name and spirit, which may relate to activities of daily living or aspects of nature—Grasp the Bird’s Tail, Single Whip, Catch the Moon at the Bottom of the Sea, and the White Crane Spreads its Wings. Within these metaphors are also martial applications. If the spirit is involved, the adept will have a sense that he is channeling—letting his body be taken over by another. With practice, Tai Chi Chuan will lead you to finding discharge power.

TAI CHI LEVELS

	LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
MIND	Uses muscular effort and uses the monkey mind or intellect. Student has no perception of chi.	Beginning to relax and learning to work with gravity. Starting to use chi to move the body.	Integrated tan tiens with meaning and form episodic. Mind moves the chi, which moves the limbs.	Spirit engaged such that meaning and movements are generated throughout form without fatigue.
BODY, STRUCTURE, AND POWER	Body disconnected. Multiple blockages in forms and between postures. Forces not aligned.	"Hollows and projections" beginning to disappear from forms. On occasions, student may still be excessively forward, backward, or use too much or insufficient force. Power does not pass smoothly through the structure.	Most forms show good Iron Shirt structure. Power passes from the legs through the waist, spinal column, and then to the hands.	Ideal structure of all forms, with constant and steady center, and upright posture. Each move shows correct passage of jin through structure.
CONTINUITY BETWEEN FORMS	Multiple breaks in form. Disconnected from chi including the heavenly and earthly forces.	Segments of connection and continuity of forms. Muscles are more relaxed and movements naturally slow.	Grace and chi engaged in most forms with ongoing continuity. The chi is listened to and followed.	Entire form takes on a unique meaning foretold by the spirit grounded in stillness.
BREATH	Breath is labored and loud.	Breath is connected to form. Yin movements inhale, yang movements exhale.	Whole-body breathing, breath almost disappears to an observer.	Breath is spontaneous yet quiet and easy. The breath mirrors the spirit of each form.

	LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
MEANING AND MARTIAL APPLICATIONS/ FA JIN	Applications not understood or portrayed	Some understanding of meaning and applications	Meaning becomes apparent through placement of head, arms, waist, and legs.	Higher awareness of the intention of each form creates a sense of deep understanding of martial application.
			Beginning to generate skill for Fa Jin	Generates skill for Fa Jin

Push Hands

External Assessment. The student first learns single-handed Push Hands, then two-handed Push Hands. Within the routine, the student learns how to change directions, have strength in the five postures, and grasp the intentions of the eight gates. Once this is familiar, the practitioner forgets about the routine and concentrates on the subtleties of following and interpreting. Once the eight gates have been learned by the intellectual mind, the rest of the body must memorize them.

At first the student is awkward, as the monkey mind cannot master the art of Push Hands. The intellect cannot interpret or understand an opponent's movement; the integrated three minds are required for this. The novice's structure is poor and he has trouble sitting back. When the kua and kidneys are weak then the student will tend to bob up and down. He will stoop forward and lean too far back. Eventually, the student can apply principles of good structure to situational movements. In Push Hands, you win if you maintain your structure and you lose if you do not.

Initially, internal power is incomprehensible. However with time, practice, and understanding, the student learns how to correctly release power from the earth through the body. Likewise, learning to read an opponent's structure through touch (following, listening, and understanding jin) occurs with time and devotion. It is a giant leap forward when the adept realizes the power of relaxation and becomes able to attune himself to his opponent and the forces around him. Internal Assessment. After spending a couple of years learning the routines—the skills of listening, understanding, and the use of the eight gates of discharge—Push Hands becomes like a meditation in itself (fig. 9.8). The multiple avenues of sensory input are reduced by the integrated three minds to a primordial perception. The opponent's internal structure is interpreted for its faults, and the body spontaneously reacts with an exaggeration of the defect to

culminate in successful discharge.

PUSH HANDS LEVELS

LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
Learning the routine	Relaxing into the routine	Using opponent's movements as guide	Using spirit to guide movements
Uses the monkey mind with predetermined ideas	More relaxed but still keeping a move in mind	Following, interpreting, and listening	Truly spontaneous, appears to read an opponent even before the opponent moves
Broken structure, with difficulty sitting back. Center moves up and down.	Four faults of butting, deficiency, breaking, and stiffness	Faults disappear, good structure in the five steps	Soft and alive in all positions
Uses muscles and Li power	Power still fragmented; breakages in link between earth, legs, waist, spine, and arms	Power is aligned.	Transmits power from the earth
Learning eight gates	Learning eight gates, becoming familiar with a few	Familiar with all eight gates	Eight gates include Fa Jin

Fa Jin

It is difficult to create a precise and uniform grading of Fa Jin skills, as Fa Jin is a continuum from muscle power to spirit power. We have discussed in chapter 3 that masters can discharge power from the jin level (lower tan tien), chi level (from the heart), or shen level (upper tan tien and spirit). The ability to throw opponents several meters with minimal touch is a feature of a master with a life-long dedication to the art.



Fig. 9.8. Listening, understanding, and following in Push Hands

The Universal Healing Tao student who first gains mastery of meditation, Iron Shirt, Tai Chi, and Push Hands practices and will find that in time, he will be able to release his power with less effort. Ultimately, the whole process of discharge power becomes spontaneous with no effort.

HOME PRACTICE ROUTINE AND THE CHI CYCLE

Sleep at night, train first thing in the morning, eat, go to work, slow down in the afternoon, be with family and friends in the evening, and then prepare for sleep: home practice is based on tuning in to the chi cycle in order to enable enduring maximal performance.

Western society is so focused on top performance that it drains the nurturing aspects of the day. An easily understandable and practical interpretation of the

chi cycle can be found in a book called *The Perfect Day Plan*,^{*27} by Australian traditional Chinese medicine practitioner Jost Sauer. In the book, Sauer explains that you can find your true power by tapping in to the cycle of life.

The Chi Cycle

The cycle of the day reflects the interplay and harmony of the five elements. It divides the day into twelve two-hour increments, each of which is governed by a certain organ and its corresponding element. By directing our activities so that they correspond to the appropriate organ at the appropriate time, we maximize our body's potential for growth, power, and regeneration.

Man is not separate from the universal forces and should not try to be. The more he divorces himself from the natural rhythm of these forces, the sooner he will age and sicken. There are no shortcuts but to live in harmony with the Tao. Relinquishing yourself to the forces outside of yourself enfolds you in the world of spirit and paradoxically allows you to find your true nature. Sauer maintains that this relinquishment gives each person a sense of not being alone—of being a part of something greater. This leads us, in turn, to doing things that are great.

In our Western lifestyle, we are determined to do more than we are capable of—by rushing, skipping meals, staying up late, and forcing things. Gradually, as separation occurs from the divine, we lose our power and lose our way.

However, all is not lost. Sauer recommends that the first step to redemption is to begin by tuning our body to the chi cycle first thing in the morning by arising at 5:00 a.m. This is the time that corresponds to the large intestine. There is an abundance of perceptible chi at this hour. Our spirits have been in the dream world and now we must awaken and get back into our bodies with all the information and chi that our dreams have so desperately been trying to procure. This is the ideal time to practice stretching, meditation, empty force breath, Chi Kung, and Tai Chi. Awareness, perception, and understanding of chi and jin are at their height between 5:00 and 7:00 a.m.

From 7:00 a.m. to 9:00 a.m. is the stomach time (fig. 9.9). We have embodied the chi from the dream world and it is time now to digest the chi from the material world. The taste buds are ready, the digestive juices are ready—the body is waiting for its material nourishment. A large cooked breakfast is ideal, with food prepared for digestion that includes dishes like porridge.^{*28}

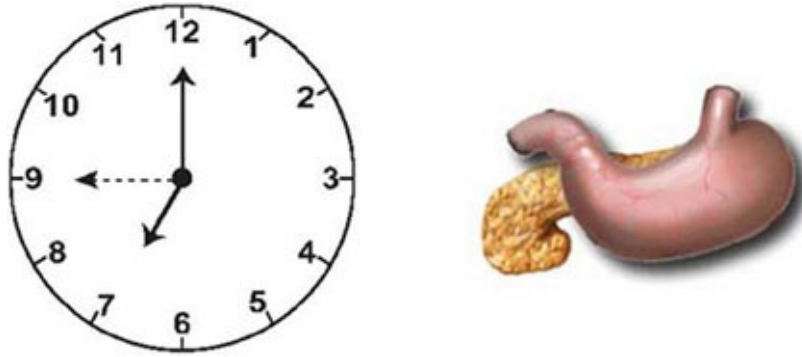


Fig. 9.9. Stomach time from 7:00–9:00 a.m.

From 9:00 a.m. to 11:00 a.m. is spleen time—the hour for embarking on earthly activities that help us to realize our dreams (fig. 9.10). Thinking is a function of the spleen so this is a great time for solving problems, studying, and performing seemingly difficult tasks.

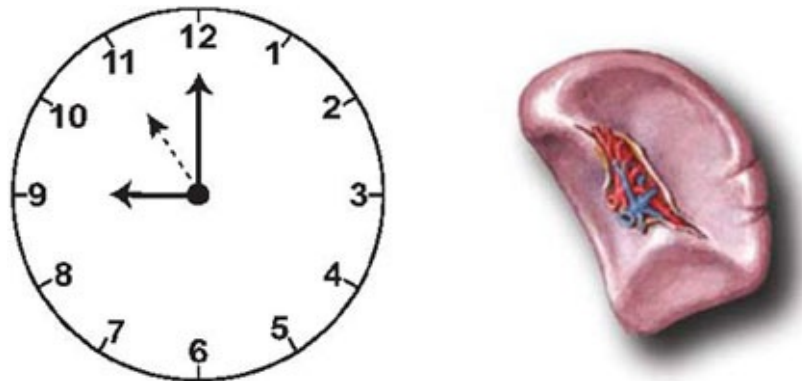


Fig. 9.10. Spleen time from 9:00–11:00 a.m.

From 11:00 a.m. to 1:00 p.m. is heart time (fig. 9.11). This is the middle of the day and a good time to explore and realize the creative insights of the heart.

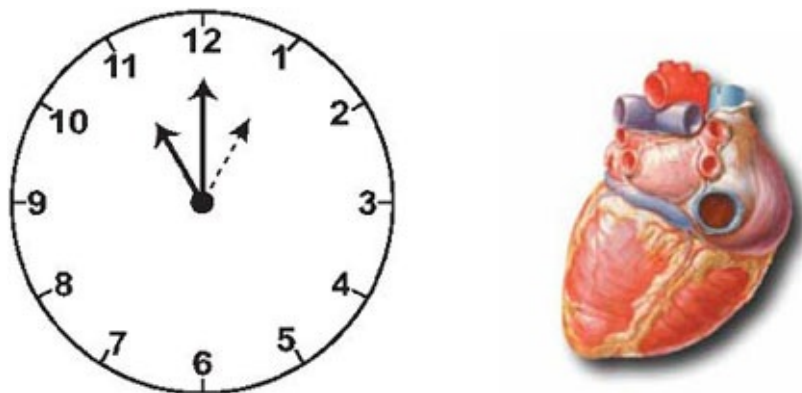


Fig. 9.11. Heart time from 11:00 a.m. to 1:00 p.m.

From 1:00 p.m. onward, the outward or yang energies of the body start to decline. This may be a good time to have some lunch, as 1:00 p.m. begins the

time of the small intestine (fig. 9.12). Again, it is important to attune your meals to nourishment and food chi (*ku*). Fast foods, processed foods, and genetically modified foods lack food chi. On the other hand, fresh organic foods come with both flavor and energy. It is ideal to have a little rest after lunch, and this can vary from some quiet time alone to a brief meditation or even a power nap. The small intestine time continues till 3:00 p.m., so it is a good time to continue purification of the creative thoughts and ideas from the heart. However, effectiveness in the real world is abating.

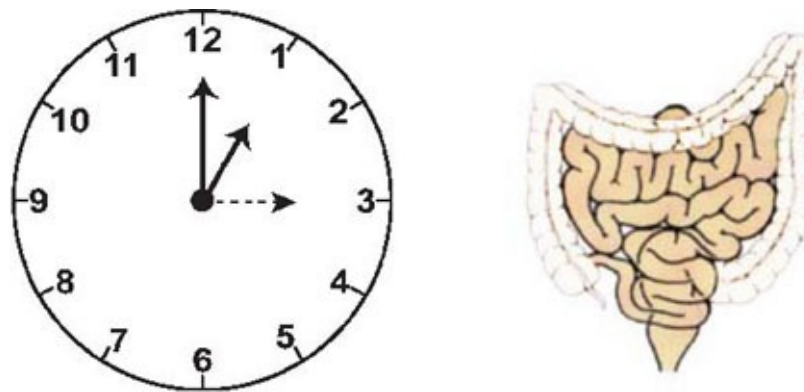


Fig. 9.12. Small intestine time from 1:00–3:00 p.m.

From 3:00 to 5:00 p.m. is bladder time, while 5:00 to 7:00 p.m. is kidney time (fig. 9.13). Because the bladder is an organ that is paired with the kidneys,^{*29} the whole time period belonging to the bladder and kidneys (3:00 to 7:00 p.m.) can be used to support the vital energy of the kidneys. Kidney yin is closely related to sexual feelings and is paramount for the lubricating functions in the body. Kidney chi nourishes the mind, while kidney yang determines our willpower. Therefore, bladder and kidney time is a good time to connect again with our sexual urges. For many people, sexual energy becomes blocked by the negative emotions surrounding their work. The politics, human emotions, and various stresses at work interfere with connection to our primordial drives. This may be a good time to do some exercise to clean the body of negative emotions. A visit to the park, a swim, or even some time alone is very therapeutic. Thereafter, one can engage in some sexual practices with either dual or single cultivation.

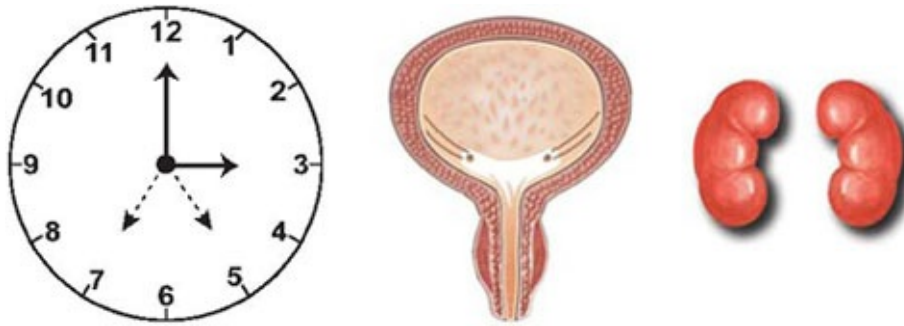


Fig. 9.13. Bladder time from 3:00–5:00 p.m., kidney time from 5:00–7:00 p.m.

From 7:00 to 9:00 p.m. is a time for being in an environment that protects the heart: it is pericardium time (fig. 9.14). For most people, this will mean relaxing at home with family. For others, it is time to spend with your friends or Taoist buddies. Friendship and the sharing of the day's experiences over a light evening meal is ideal.

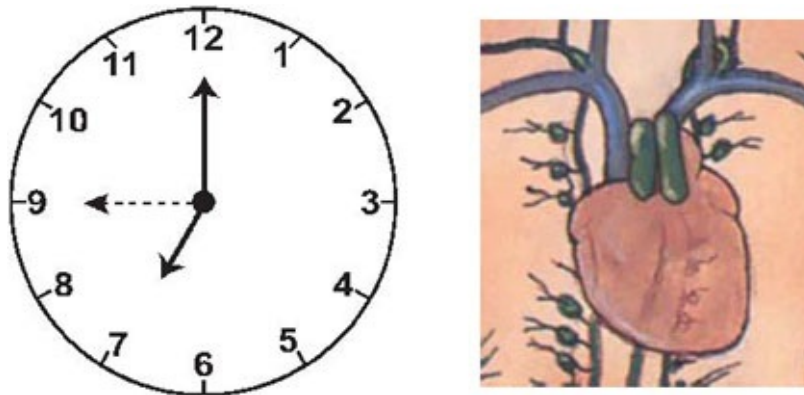


Fig. 9.14. Pericardium time from 7:00–9:00 p.m.

From 9:00 p.m. until 11:00 p.m. is preparation for sleep. During this time, the triple warmer has the function of dispersing chi to the three warmers and ensuring equal warmth (fig. 9.15). To enter sleep easily, the body should feel open and energized to a degree. If we are laden with negative emotions and blockages, then sleep will be hard to come by. Therefore, the Six Healing Sounds practice and soft stretching on the floor with Tao Yin exercises are ideal. Vigorous Chi Kung or meditation will be counterproductive at this hour, as they engage too much yang chi and can awaken the body and mind too much.

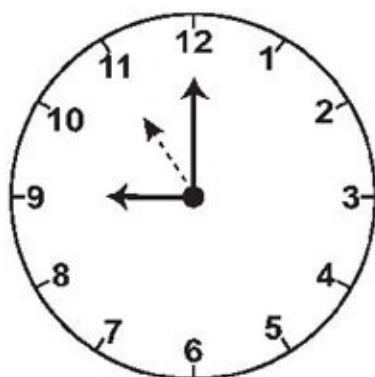


Fig. 9.15. Triple warmer time from 9:00–11:00 p.m.

It is a good idea to be well and truly asleep before the gallbladder and liver time (11:00 p.m.–3:00 a.m.). The ethereal soul leaves the body at this time and merges with the realm of spirit. There is potential here not only for healing but for advancement in one's practice. The ethereal soul can meet with other masters, solve problems, and even practice high-level alchemy. Lucid dreaming—a vehicle for further self-cultivation that is taught during our darkness retreats—can also be practiced during these hours.

From 3:00 to 5:00 a.m. is a continuation of the sleep cycle during which the realm of dreams and spirit dominates (fig. 9.16). The ethereal soul of the liver (*hun*) hands over its knowledge to the corporeal soul of the lungs. This begins the process of descent from the unconscious back to consciousness, and the transfer of shen to bodily chi.

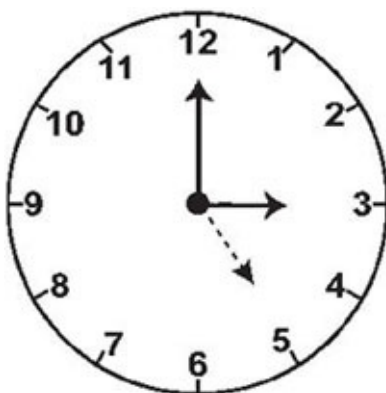


Fig. 9.16. Lung time from 3:00–5:00 a.m.

Harmonizing with the Cycles of Nature

The processes involved in self-cultivation, improving our daily life, and Fa Jin are similar. All are grounded in the harmony of the five elements and their corresponding organs as they express their interplay within the cycle of the daily spin of the earth. Yang Pan-Hou reinforces the importance of the relationship between our daily choices and Fa Jin. He says, “After reaching this level, how can one not be cautious in regards to daily activities, diet, and elimination?”¹²

Each element corresponds to an aspect of Push Hands, thereby returning us to the five steps of front, back, center, left, and right. In the context of the five elements, the five steps are advance (fire), retreat (water), gaze left (wood), look right (metal), and central equilibrium (earth).¹³ Within each element there is a yin and a yang component, yin being soft, contractile, and withdrawing, while yang lets go, expands, and can initiate or attack. Appropriate use of these yin and yang aspects of the five elements leads to better use of the eight gates.

According to five element astrology, each element will express its yin and yang modalities according to the seasons, as determined by the axis of the earth making its yearly rotation around the sun. Beyond that, there are cycles dictated by the rotation of the other planets around the sun—especially the twelve-year cycle of Jupiter. Even further, there may be cycles that arise and repeat as our solar system moves within our galaxy. However beyond us all this may seem, we can each improve our connection to the greater universe—and thereby our discharge power—by striving to harmonize ourselves with the daily cycle of chi in our bodies.

THE CHI CYCLE IN DAILY LIFE

TIME	ORGAN	DAILY ACTIVITIES	CORRESPONDING FA JIN AND PUSH HANDS PRINCIPLES
5–7 a.m.	LARGE INTESTINE	Getting ready for the day. Heavenly and earthly chi is pouring into the body like a rapidly flowing river. Activities should assist the embodiment of dreams. This time is a bridge between the spirit world and earthly worlds. Begin with light meditation, chi weight lifting, Empty Force Breath, warm-ups, Tai Chi, and Chi Kung. Finish with meditation.	
7–9 a.m.	STOMACH	The time that the energetic dimension meets the material world of tastes, nourishment, warmth, and splendor. A warm cooked breakfast is ideal and can be the main meal of the day.	The earth element governs the digestion and absorption of chi. It also holds the center, providing peace, centered-ness, and balance. It is about connecting and bonding with trust.
9–11 a.m.	SPLEEN	Action time: hard work, earthly problem solving, meetings with others, and healing of others. Absorption of chi continues with reading and writing—including study of the classics. Fulfillment of your grounded earthly mission.	
11 a.m. – 1 p.m.	HEART	Creativity and hard work continue. Follow your heart and exercise the spirit that lives in your heart. Here you will find true internal power.	Creativity: heart yin begets insight while heart yang expresses it. Spirit resides in the heart during the day (and in the liver at night).
1–3 p.m.	SMALL INTESTINE	Time for lunch and the start of the yin phase. Take the opportunity to switch off with a power nap or brief meditation.	The small intestine purifies the creativity of the heart.
3–5 p.m.	BLADDER	Time for activities that are more mundane and require little mind power. Exercise in the afternoon may be a waste of time.	
5–7 p.m.	KIDNEY	Time to detoxify from work and nurture the kidneys. This is good time to gather some rejuvenation, including sexual practices. Kidney yin lubricates the jin. Kidney chi helps to receive air chi (<i>zhong chi</i>) and combine it with stomach digestion chi (<i>ku chi</i>) and Original Chi (<i>yuan chi</i>).	The combination of kidney yang and kidney chi forms willpower. ¹⁴
7–9 p.m.	PERICARDIUM	Home time: time to protect the heart. Be with family, friends, and Taoist buddies over a light evening meal. Best to go to bed slightly hungry. Do winding down exercises—ideally on the floor—including Tao Yin and the Six Healing Sounds.	Pericardium yin protects the spirit by closing the heart. The pericardium helps to find the right teacher and colleagues for safe creative expression.
9–11 p.m.	TRIPLE WARMER	Time to fall asleep. The triple warmer disperses the chi, moves you into new dimensions where you can discover your true identity.	The triple warmer distributes energy evenly between the three cavities of the body, creating balance and warmth. It prevents extremes of thoughts and behavior.
11 p.m. –	GALLBLADDER	Sleep time	

1 a.m.			
1–3 a.m.	LIVER	Restoration time: you should be in a total yin state, fast asleep. This is when the ethereal soul (<i>hun</i>) ventures off to the spirit world to converse with Immortals and past masters. “This is the time when the unconscious is supreme.” ¹⁵ The hun passes its information to the corporeal soul (<i>po</i>).	Movement energy: liver yang is action. Liver yin allows us to retreat and wait. The liver provides “the wisdom to know when to move and when to be still.” ¹⁶ It governs the eyes, tendons, ligaments, and storage of blood.
3–5 a.m.	LUNGS	This is the grand time: the corporeal soul (<i>po</i>) brings the information and inspiration from the spirit world—and the magic of the world of dreams—back into the body.	Letting go (yang) and reattachment (yin).

Glossary

An: one of the eight gates, the Push

back Shu points: Acupuncture points along the spine that correspond to and influence the solid and hollow organs

Ba Gua: Eight-sided symbol representing the eight forces of nature, also spelled *pakua*

Ba Gua Zhang: One of three internal Chinese martial arts featuring discharge power

Ba hui: The point at the crown of the head

bian: Deficiency, one of the four faults of Push Hands practice

chan su jin: Silk reeling

chi: the vibration of the life force felt by the senses

Chi Kung: To work the chi

Ching Chi: Fluid essence most commonly associated with sexual essence

Chong Mai: Central Thrusting Channel

Chou: One of the eight gates, the Elbow Strike

Dai Mai: Belt Channel

Du Mai: Governing Channel

ding: Butting, one of the four faults of Push Hands practice

diu: Losing contact, one of the four faults of Push Hands practice

dong jin: Understanding power

Fa Jin: Internal discharge power

fu: Bending forward

Hsing Yi Chuan: One of three internal Chinese martial arts featuring discharge power

hun: The soul of the liver; the ethereal soul

Ji: One of the eight gates, the Press

jin: Internal force

jin na: Locks

Kan, Li, Chen, Tui, Kun, Ken, Sun, Chien: Water, Fire, Thunder, Lake,

Earth, Mountain, Wind, and Heaven

kang: Resisting

Kou: One of the eight gates, the Shoulder Strike

ku: Food chi

kua: The ligaments of the pelvis

Lieh: One of the eight gates, the Split

Lu: One of the eight gates, the Rollback

Ming Men: Door of Life (the acupuncture point between the second and third lumbar vertebrae)

Nei Kung: Internal strength work

pakua: see Ba Gua

Peng: One of the eight gates, the Ward Off

po: The soul of the lungs; the corporeal soul

Ren Mai: Conception Channel

shen: Spirit

Tai Chi Chuan: One of three internal Chinese martial arts featuring discharge power

tan tien: Energy center

Tsai: One of the eight gates, the Lever

Tui shou: Push Hands

Wu wei: Nothingness

yang: Bending backward

Yi: Integrated mind power

zhan, lian, nian, sui: connecting, sticking, adhering, and following

CAST OF TAOIST/TAI CHI CHARACTERS

See chapter 1 for more details.

Bruce Lee (1940–1973): Movie star

Chang SanFeng (1279–1368 CE): Legendary immortal who created Tai Chi and was an alchemist

Chen Man-Ching (1902–1975): Student of Yang Chen-Fu

Dong Hai-Chuan (1797–1882): Founder of Ba Gua Zhang

Li I-Yu (1832–1892): Taught by Wu Yu-Hsiang

Tan Meng-Hsien: Little is known, included in Yang family manuscripts

Wang Tsung-Yueh (actual dates unknown, either ca. 1368–1644 or eighteenth century): The first historical Tai Chi character after Chang SanFeng

Wu Yu-Hsiang (1812–1880): Founder of Hao style, taught by Yang Lu-Chan

Yang Chen-Fu (1883–1936): Son of Yang Jian

Yang Jian (1839–1917): Son of Yang Lu-Chan

Yang Lu-Chan (1799–1872): Founded the Yang style

Yang Pan-Hou (1837–1892): Son of Yang Lu-Chan

Footnotes

CHAPTER 1

[*1](#) The techniques of Fa Jia are elaborated in the text of *Taoist Cosmic Healing* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2003), and to some extent in the *Chi Nei Tsang* series: *Chi Nei Tsang* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2007), *Advanced Chi Nei Tsang* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2009), and *Karsai Nei Tsang* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2011).

[*2](#) For more information about the Fusion practices, see *Fusion of the Five Elements* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2007), *Cosmic Fusion* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2007), and *Fusion of the Eight Psychic Channels* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2008). More detailed instruction about Kan and Li practice can be found in *The Taoist Soul Body* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2007).

CHAPTER 2

[*3](#) Chang SanFeng likened battle and alchemy when he wrote, “It is the process of mercury and lead. When we encounter an opponent in battle, the yin and yang of Kan, Li, Dui, and Zhen in the trigrams perform the way of yang seizing yin, and is the four directions [of Tai Chi Chuan]. The yin and yang of Qian, Kun, Gen, and Xun demonstrate the way of yin adopting yang and is the four corners.”²

[†4](#) It is worth noting that Zen Buddhism derived from Chang Buddhism, which was itself a fusion of Taoism and Buddhism.

[*5](#) The left-and right-hand paths of single and dual cultivation have been discussed at length in other Universal Healing Tao texts, including *Healing Love through the Tao* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2005).

CHAPTER 3

[*6](#) These techniques were brought to the West by Bruce Lee.

[*7](#) Mantak Chia, *Iron Shirt Chi Kung* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2006).

[*8](#) Mo Pai was a student of the school of Mo Tzu who successfully merged yin and yang chi.

[*9](#) Chen XiaoWang says, “Both taiji and calligraphy involve the same ‘transportation of qi’ (yun qi) in our body. When I fight, I try to transport my qi to the point of impact without friction, still maintaining maximum efficiency. When I write, I try to do the same, except it is the tip of my brush. I practice my calligraphy the same way I do my taiji—with correct postures, relaxation, and efficient yun qi. Both activities complement each other.”¹⁰

[*10](#) Yang Chen-Fu says, “If you do not use Li but use Yi, when the Yi arrives the chi arrives immediately.”¹¹

[†11](#) For biography and video demonstrations of Sifu Yeung’s demonstration of discharge power see: <http://pathgate.org/LamaDondrupDorje.html>.

[*12](#) The classics refer to the Universal Tao’s Iron Shirt structure in many ways. In the *Yang Family Forty Chapters*, Iron Shirt is referred to as *zhong tu* (central equilibrium or central earth). It is also referred to as “standing on the posts (*zhan zhuang*)” and “In central equilibrium the feet develop root.”¹²

[*13](#) The *kua* are the ligaments connecting the sacrum to the pelvis posteriorly and from the pelvic wings to the symphysis pubis anteriorly.

[*14](#) Mantak Chia, *Fusion of the Eight Psychic Channels* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2008).

CHAPTER 4

[*15](#) “That, in a spleen, unfolds both heaven and earth; And ere a man hath power to say ‘Behold!’” [§]

[†16](#) “Come to my woman’s breasts, and take my milk for gall . . .” [‡]

[*17](#) These techniques are discussed more extensively in *Bone Marrow Nei Kung* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2006).

[*18](#) *Tan Tien Chi Kung* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2004), 112–50.

CHAPTER 7

[*19](#) Balancing the organ energies belongs to the realm of basic practice and can be learned via the techniques of the Six Healing Sounds and the Inner Smile.

CHAPTER 8

[*20](#) Mantak Chia and Juan Li, *The Inner Structure of Tai Chi* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2005).

[*21](#) In Tai Chi boxing, movements are generally described as basic forces rather than as contacts between specific parts of the practitioner's and opponent's bodies.

CHAPTER 9

[*22](#) “Tai Chi comes from Wu Chi and is the mother of yin and yang,” says Wang Tsung-Yueh in *Tai Chi Chuan Lun*.³

[†23](#) However, there are many notable masters who have reached enlightenment or achieved a practice spontaneously without transmission. For example, Master Leung Fong gained the name and title: Dondrup Dorje Dakpa Gyaltsen, which translates as “Spontaneously Accomplishing Thunderbolt, Famous Banner of Victory.”

[*24](#) In this context spirit is experienced as light or consciousness that can exist beyond the bodily self.

[*25](#) The other three tigers of the nineteenth generation of descendants of the Chen style are: Zhu Tian Cai, Chen Zheng-Lei, and Wang Xi-An.

[*26](#) For more information on whole-body breathing, see Mantak Chia’s *Bone Marrow Nei Kung* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2006).

[*27](#) Jost Sauer, *The Perfect Day Plan: Unlock the Secrets of Your Body Clock* (Crows Nest, NSW: Allen and Unwin, 2009).

[*28](#) For more information on how to maximize your health through the foods you eat, see Mantak Chia and William U. Wei, *Cosmic Nutrition* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2012).

[*29](#) For more information on the relationship between the bladder and the kidneys, see Mantak Chia’s *Healing Light of the Tao* (Rochester, Vt.: Destiny Books, 2008).

Endnotes

CHAPTER 1. HISTORY OF THE TAI CHI CHI KUNG DISCHARGE FORM

- [1.](#) Chang SanFeng, quoted in *The Taijiquan Classics*, trans. Barbara Davis, (Berkeley, Calif.: North Atlantic Books, 2004), 75.
- [2.](#) Douglas Wile, trans., *Lost T'ai-Ch'i Classics from the Late Ch'ing Dynasty* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1996), 112.
- [3.](#) Benjamin Lo and Martin Inn, trans., *The Essence of Tai Chi Chuan: The Literary Tradition* (Berkeley, Calif.: North Atlantic Books, 1979), 11; and Bing F. YeYoung, *The Origins of Tai Chi—the Chang San Feng Camp*, www.literati-tradition.com/zhang_sanfeng_camp.html.
- [4.](#) Wile, trans., *Lost T'ai-Ch'i Classics*, 114.
- [5.](#) Lo and Inn, trans., *The Essence of Tai Chi Chuan*, 13.
- [6.](#) Douglas Wile, trans., *T'ai-chi Touchstones: Yang Family Secret Transmissions* (New York: Sweet Ch'i Press, 1983), iii, xvi.
- [7.](#) Chang SanFeng, quoted in *The Essence of Tai Chi Chuan*, trans. Lo and Inn, 25.
- [8.](#) Wang Tsung-Yueh, quoted in *The Essence of Tai Chi Chuan*, trans. Lo and Inn, 33.
- [9.](#) Wile, trans., *T'ai-chi Touchstones*, 39.
- [10.](#) Yang Chen-Fu, "Ten Important Keys to Taijiquan," in *Tai Chi Secrets of the Yang Styles*, trans. Yang Jwing-Ming (Boston: YMAA Publications, 2001), 35.
- [11.](#) *Ibid.*, 100.
- [12.](#) *Ibid.*, 162.
- [13.](#) Li I-Yu, quoted in *The Essence of Tai Chi Chuan*, trans. Lo and Inn, 76.
- [14.](#) Xing-Han Liu, *Hidden Knowledge in the Taoist Martial Art* (Berkeley, Calif.: North Atlantic Books, 1998), 33.
- [15.](#) Dong Hai-Chuan, quoted by Frank Allen and Tina Chunna Zhang in *The Whirling Circles of Ba Gua Zhang: The Art and Legends of the Eight Trigram Palm* (Berkeley, Calif.: Blue Snake Books, 2007), 178.
- [16.](#) *Ibid.*, 192.
- [17.](#) *Ibid.*, 195.

[18.](#) Ibid.

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[Mantak Chia](#) has been studying the Taoist approach to life since childhood. His mastery of this ancient knowledge, enhanced by his study of other disciplines, has resulted in the development of the Universal Healing Tao system, which is now being taught throughout the world.

Mantak Chia was born in Thailand to Chinese parents in 1944. When he was six years old, he learned from Buddhist monks how to sit and “still the mind.” While in grammar school he learned traditional Thai boxing, and he soon went on to acquire considerable skill in aikido, yoga, and Tai Chi. His studies of the Taoist way of life began in earnest when he was a student in Hong Kong, ultimately leading to his mastery of a wide variety of esoteric disciplines, with the guidance of several masters, including Master I Yun, Master Meugi, Master Cheng Yao Lun, and Master Pan Yu. To better understand the mechanisms behind healing energy, he also studied Western anatomy and medical sciences.

Master Chia has taught his system of healing and energizing practices to tens of thousands of students and trained more than two thousand instructors and practitioners throughout the world. He has established centers for Taoist study and training in many countries around the globe. In June of 1990 he was honored by the International Congress of Chinese Medicine and Qi Gong (Chi Kung), which named him the Qi Gong Master of the Year.

ANDREW JAN



[Dr. Andrew Jan](#) is a senior instructor for the Universal Healing Tao system. He first became an instructor in 1992 and has been a senior instructor since 2001. He began studying martial arts as a young child and has been studying the internal arts of Wu Shu for 25 years. His teachers include Chen Lu, John Yuen (Blackburn Tai Chi Academy), Liu De Ming (Associate Professor Martial Arts, Fujien University), Huo Dong Li in Beijing (Senior Judge, Beijing Wu Shu Federation), Zhu Tian-Cai (one of the contemporary “tigers” of Chen Jia Guo), and of course Master Mantak Chia.

Andrew Jan has won multiple medals in Push Hands competitions in Victoria, New South Wales, and won a Full-contact All Styles, Lightweight Division title in 1984. In 2000, he became the National Tai Chi and Wu Shu Champion in the over-forty section and also won first place in Wu Style, Yang Style, and Weapon divisions.

Dr. Jan is currently an Emergency Medicine specialist and Director of Emergency Medical Services at a large private hospital in Perth, Western Australia. He is also a qualified acupuncturist with the Medical Acupuncture College. He was born in Australia to a Chinese father and an English mother. Dr. Jan has always found himself exploring and synthesizing Eastern and Western traditions, an ability he applies to healing as well as martial arts. He is married to his loving wife and fellow practitioner, Fiona, with one daughter, Nikita.

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